OFFICIAL E-BOOK EDITION · FULL EDITION

VOLUME 1

SNSHERO OFFICIAL WEB NOVEL SERIES

SNSHero

Kadan & Arcane Echoes

Part 1 · Complete Edition (Episodes 1 – 40)

Born amidst the tragedy of Elwin Village on the frozen frontier of Lighthaven, Kadan inherits the shattered shield and sacred vows of the Holy Knights—an epic dark fantasy chronicle uniting 11 continental realms and 100 Guardians.

Created & Published By

ModooSoft · SNSHero Revolution

Complete 40 Episodes

Official English e-Book Edition

Main Characters

Kadan & Arcane Echoes Dramatis Personae

Kadan

The Last Shield of the Holy Knights · Heir of Arcane

Son of Aleksandar. Guided by the creed that true strength is a shield raised to protect the weak rather than a blade to dominate, he marches forward to uncover the truth of the continent.

Celia

Informant of Lighthaven · Guide of the Wind

Raised on the backstreets of the capital yet blessed with peerless wit and perception, she forges a fateful alliance with Kadan to unlock the secret passages of the royal court.

Ignis

Prince of White Flame · Seeker of the Ember

Son of Balian, raised as an imperial prince in the Red Glass Court. Drawn by the mystery of the white flames at his fingertips and his true bloodline, his path collides with Kadan's.

Aleksandar

Guardian of Twin Blades · Father of Kadan

A fallen hero of the Holy Knights who stood alone atop the wooden bridge of Elwin with shattered steel until his final breath to save the villagers and his pregnant wife.

Balian

Master of the Arcane Spear · Father of Ignis

Sworn blood-brother to Aleksandar. Plunging into the mist-shrouded gorge while drawing the imperial cavalry away from his wife Ysela, he began a long, perilous exile.

Hercul

Pilgrim of the Golden Aegis · Elder Paladin

The veteran paladin who pursued the covenant of court traitors and entrusted the twin silver rune-daggers to the two unborn children as a testament of truth.

Death Knight Artus

Regent of the Red Glass Court · Lord of Obsidian

The mastermind who conspired with the Shadow Realm to seize the kingdom and unseal forbidden dark magic across the ancient sanctums.

Elwin

Mother of Kadan · Beacon of Endurance

Surviving her husband's sacrifice, she braved the blizzards of the northern wastes to raise Kadan with unwavering integrity and honor.

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CHAPTER 01

Episode 1 · Two Vows Beneath the Blizzard

Part 1 · Episode 01 of 40

At the southernmost edge of the Kingdom of Lighthaven, where jagged mountain ranges met the frozen tundra, winter arrived with unsparing brutality in the village of Elwin. By midday, howling gales and razor-sharp flurries had wiped the stockades and watchtowers from sight. Before dusk could settle, the blizzard swallowed the muddy tracks and stone roofs whole. The villagers sealed their windows with grease-coated parchment, covered their hearth embers, and extinguished their lanterns early. Rumors had spread across the ice like wildfire: the dreaded shadow cavalry from the conquered northern marches had already breached the frontier woods.

Inside a weathered log tavern hidden behind the village smithy, Aleksandar and Balian sat across from each other, nursing chilled infusions by the dull glow of charcoal. Aleksandar was a quiet hunter of the northern borders who wielded twin blades with effortless grace, while Balian was a seasoned veteran capable of piercing the throat of a winter wolf through the thickest whiteout with his arcane spear. Both men concealed their lineage as descendants of the fallen Order of Arcane Holy Knights, choosing instead to till the stony earth and hammer iron in silence. The impending birth of their firstborns from their heavily pregnant wives, Elwin and Ysela, was the solitary lantern that kept the bitter defeat of their homeland bearable.

Suddenly, the heavy pine door groaned on its iron hinges and burst open. Ahead of the freezing draft came the sharp reek of blood and scorched ozone. Framed against the howling squall stood Hercul, clad in tattered pilgrim vestments. At his belt dangled the cracked golden seal of the Holy Knights, and faint ripples of radiant mana leaked through his torn gauntlets, etching incandescent runes into the damp floorboards.

In the span of a single heartbeat, the tip of Balian's arcane spear hissed forward, freezing a bare inch from the intruder's throat. Behind him, Aleksandar's twin blades were already drawn in a fluid cross-guard, sealing every line of retreat.

> "If you are a hound dispatched from the Shadow Realm, speaking your name will only hasten your demise," Balian growled, the azure spark along his spearhead reflecting the stranger's grim eyes.

Hercul did not reach for a weapon. Instead, he slowly opened both empty palms.

"Stand down, brothers. I bear the blood of wolves upon my mantle, yet I do not hunt for the pack."

A dome of golden protective aegis blossomed outward, muffling the roar of the exterior tempest in an instant. Along the tavern shelves, earthenware flasks vibrated in harmonious resonance. Hercul had manifested a defensive perimeter without initiating a single hostile gesture. Reaching into his tunic with steady fingers, he placed a shattered breastplate insignia upon the rough oak table—the undeniable relic of their executed Grand Master.

As the tension subsided, Hercul swallowed a stale crust of bread and laid bare the kingdom's grim plight until the early hours of dawn. The court at Lighthaven wallowed in gluttonous banquets and extortionate levies, leaving frontier outposts entirely defenseless against demonic incursions. Hercul had been tracking a treasonous covenant of nobles who had sold their fealty to the Shadow Realm. At the summit of this black list sat Regent Death Knight Artus and the ambitious courtier Lucian.

"The shadow reaches even into this southern basin," Hercul whispered, his gaze shadowed with sorrow. "Inquisitors flying royal banners will descend upon this hamlet before the new moon."

Before stepping back into the blizzard, Hercul produced two slender silver daggers wrapped in oiled doe-skin. Along the white-silver fuller slept ancient runes of the Holy Order, pulsing like faint blue veins beneath frost.

"When your sons draw their first breath, place these silver daggers into their hands," Hercul urged, his voice trembling with solemn gravity. "Do not bestow them to demand blood debts or inherited vendettas. When the continent drowns in falsehood and betrayal, let these blades preserve the inner truth so they may discern who stands as brother and who lurks as foe."

Aleksandar gripped the hilt, nodding with resolute northern stoicism.

"If my son enters this world, I shall name him Kadan—the enduring shield that never shatters."

Balian pressed his hand to his chest as he received the companion blade.

"And mine shall be named Ignis, that his spirit may never lose its way, even within the furnace of tribulation."

Raising cups filled not with wine but with melted snowfall, the three warriors consecrated their vows for the unborn children. Yet fate was swifter and far crueler than their hopes.

Three mornings later, amid a blinding snow fog, the young highborn Lucian encountered Aleksandar's wife, Elwin, on the village perimeter. Disguised as an injured merchant who had lost his mount, Lucian concealed beneath his ermine cloak the serpentine crest of the Red Glass Court. When Elwin offered him warm barley broth and tended his fabricated wounds with boundless mercy, a twisted, possessive obsession ignited within Lucian's corrupt heart. To claim her as his own, he fabricated imperial charges declaring the entire settlement a nest of insurgents.

At dawn, iron-clad legionnaires encircled the village under cover of burning pitch. Torches set the straw thatch ablaze. Aleksandar shoved the pregnant Elwin toward the secret northern waterway, drawing his dual swords to hold the solitary wooden bridge alone. Balian concealed his expectant wife, Ysela, within the covered cart, brandishing his arcane spear. Dozens of times they shattered the advancing lines, but Lucian mercilessly drove captive villagers forward as living shields.

"Surrender your steel, Aleksandar!" Lucian sneered from horseback atop the ridge. "Confess your treason, and I may grant your woman her wretched life!"

Refusing to strike the innocent captives, Aleksandar deflected blows with the blunt spines of his swords, absorbing spear thrusts and bleeding profusely from shoulder and thigh. Looking upon the burning village, his eyes burned with unyielding resolve.

"My wife's life is not a favor to be bartered from a traitor's tongue!"

With a thunderous cry, Aleksandar severed the massive mooring cables supporting the span. Screaming legionnaires plunged headlong into the icy torrent below.

Near the rear alleys, Balian's escape cart overturned under iron chains. Ysela crawled desperately through the mud, shielding her belly with both arms, only to be blocked by Lucian's warhorse. She hurled a handful of frozen slush into the nobleman's face with fierce defiance.

"Lay no hand upon me, monster!"

Hearing her desperate cry and believing she had slipped past the cordon, Balian charged toward the precipice to draw the pursuing cavalry away from her.

"Live, Ysela! You must live!"

Snapping his spear haft, Balian dragged several mounted foes with him over the mist-shrouded chasm into the raging river rapids. In the chaos, Lucian threw his heavy cloak over the unconscious Ysela and whisked her south toward the imperial palace.

On the ruined bridge, Aleksandar broke his twin swords across the breastplate of the final commander before collapsing upon one knee. Through the blinding snow, his fading eyes caught a fleeting glimpse of Elwin's cloaked figure escaping into the safety of the northern wilderness.

Reaching the frozen tundra, Elwin dropped to her knees, looking back toward the pillars of smoke rising from their ruined home. Beneath her bodice, the silver dagger resonated faintly against the broken sword-sheath of her husband. Inside her womb, the unborn child kicked with sudden strength.

The elderly refugees who caught up with her could not bear to speak Aleksandar's demise aloud. Elwin did not ask. She tucked the broken sheath against her breast, scooped away the snow with bare fingers, and buried a fistful of golden wheat seeds into the frozen loam.

"Even if we never return," she whispered softly, "someone must live to bake bread upon this ground once more."

Wiping the frozen tears from her cheeks, Elwin turned north into the gale.

"My child, you were not born to carry the burden of vengeance," her voice rang steady against the wind. "Only promise me that you will never bow your head before a lie."

The blizzard buried the blood of two brave men, yet the seeds beneath the snow and the twin silver daggers glowed in the darkness like an ember that no storm could ever quench.

CHAPTER 02

Episode 2 · Oath of the Seven Pursuers

Part 1 · Episode 02 of 40

When Hercul arrived at the smoking ruins of Elwin village, nothing remained upon the desolated earth save for charred rafters and crimson trails frozen like tear-streaked ice. For three days and three nights he had ridden without pause. Though his greaves were caked in mud and freezing slush, the paladin planted his holy warhammer deep into the drift and fell to his knees to search for Aleksandar's traces. From beneath the shattered bridge, amidst the ice-choked shallows, his fingers drew forth the broken blade of a twin sword. Along the jagged fuller lay a cruel serrated groove and imperial seal never found on standard Shadow Realm armaments.

"The royal insignia of Lighthaven's elite frontier high command... This was no barbarian raid. The slaughter was engineered from within the palace walls."

Hercul's jaw hardened with righteous fury. Carefully burying the remains of the slaughtered villagers beneath clean drifts of snow, he wrapped the broken blade alongside Aleksandar's scabbard and followed the scent of the conspirators southward toward Sevenbridge, the bustling port metropolis where sea fog mingled with the shouts of merchants and desperate refugees. Sweeping through the narrow labyrinth of the fishmongers' quarter, Hercul found himself confronted by seven formidable figures bristling with lethal intent.

At their forefront loomed Grimli, a broad-shouldered dwarven blacksmith resting a colossal maul across his scarred pauldrons. Flanking him was Aila the Demon Hunter, her scarlet braids drawn back as she leveled a cocked heavy crossbow with narrowed eyes. Beside them stood Eliana, an apothecary hung with leather herb-pouches, Gawain, a blind tracker tracing subterranean reverberations with an iron staff, Kaze, a flamboyant gambler flicking silver shillings between his knuckles, Rondol, a canal boatman who commanded water currents with runic paddles, and Robinyard, an agile acrobat balancing effortlessly along the eaves. They were frontier outlaws, distinct in race, tongue, and weapon.

"A gilded hound from the royal holy guard sniffing around our docks!" Grimli spat on the cobbles, his gravelly voice grating like iron on grindstone.

The encounter flared instantly into violent misunderstanding. Hercul had acted on intelligence warning of child slavers operating from the docks, while the Seven Pursuers took one look at Hercul's golden tabard and branded him an imperial inquisitor dispatched by the Red Glass Court to destroy the evidence of their atrocities.

"You will tear not one orphan from this harbor, court lapdog! Drop your steel!" Aila barked, her bowstring snapping with lethal resonance.

A silver-tipped quarrel whistled straight for Hercul's eyes. Reflexively, the knight flared his radiant barrier, deflecting the projectile upward. The kinetic shock tore market awnings to shreds and hurled wooden crates across the quay. Each time Grimli's maul battered the translucent golden dome, harmonious shockwaves rippled out to the distant maritime bell tower.

Gawain tapped his staff, his ears twitching as he parsed the cadence of Hercul's stance.

"Hold your hands, Grimli! His tread bears no bloodlust toward the innocent!"

Yet the roar of battle drowned his counsel. Kaze cast seven silver coins into the air, pinpointing micro-fractures in Hercul's barrier, while Rondol summoned seawater from the canal to freeze around the knight's boots. As Hercul channeled his inner flame to shatter the frost, Eliana hurled a vial of pulverized sun-peppers, raising a blinding, pungent cloud of vapor. Despite his burning eyes, Hercul tilted his shield to keep flying splinters from striking nearby commoners.

The skirmish was halted by a ragged young girl who darted out from behind Aila's cloak, clutching Hercul's torn surcoat with tears streaming down her soot-streaked cheeks.

"Sir Knight, please cease! These people are not slavers! They risked their very lives to drag us from the hold of the slave galleys destined for the Red Glass Court!"

Hercul's warhammer froze mid-swing. The Seven Pursuers lowered their arms in sheepish disbelief. From his travel pouch, Hercul produced the merchant ledger recovered from the burnt wagon. Impressed across its parchment was Prince Lucian's personal wax seal, detailing orders for the total liquidation of the Arcane Holy Order and the trafficking of survivors. On disparate paths of vengeance and justice, these warriors had chased the same monstrous serpent.

Grimli rested his hammer on the flagstones, letting out a rough bellow of laughter.

"Curse my squinting eyes. An honest-to-god holy knight rather than a court lackey. We were too hasty with our bolts, brother."

Raising Aleksandar's broken sword, Hercul recounted the tragic stand at Elwin village, the valor of Aleksandar and Balian, and the grim fate of the two expectant mothers. Then, revealing the gleaming silver dagger, he bowed his head with profound solemnity.

"Aleksandar's wife escaped into the savage frost of the northern Wildlands. Balian's child has been dragged south into the viper's nest of Lucian's court. I implore you, champions of the

frontier. Seek out Aleksandar's bloodline in the howling northern plains and shield the child from destruction."

Gawain rested his hands upon his iron staff, nodding with calm dignity.

"We are men and women who dwell within the border shadows. But we will never allow the blood of a hero to freeze unavenged upon the wastes."

Aila slid her crossbow onto her back, her hazel eyes softening with determination.

"Consider it done. We shall comb every nomad encampment until Aleksandar's son is safe in our hands. We will forge him into a warrior whom no northern wolf can break."

Kaze chuckled, flicking a shining crown between his fingers.

"And I shall grant him the sharpest instincts and dagger arts to outwit any scoundrel on this continent."

Rondol nodded, securing his oar.

"And the endurance to navigate tempestuous tides upon unyielding waters."

Eliana patted her leather satchel.

"And the wisdom of nature to identify deadly venoms and mend shattered bones."

Robinyard leaped lightly from the eaves, landing gracefully beside them.

"With my acrobatic balance to dance across chasms without fear, the boy will be peerless."

Hercul placed a fist over his heart in gratitude.

"Then I shall plunge into the gilded darkness of the Red Glass Court to watch over Balian's child. I swear by my sacred vows that the Shadow Realm shall not corrupt his soul."

Gawain's lips curled into a fierce smile as he offered a parting wager.

"Then let us seal one more compact, Paladin. In eighteen years, on the night of the midwinter solstice, let us convene atop the Star-Drunken Bell Tower in the heart of the continent. Bring forth the boy you have guided, and we shall bring the boy we have tempered in the blizzard. Let an honorable martial duel reveal whose path forged the truer shield for this broken realm."

Hercul brought his silver dagger against Gawain's iron staff, the chime of white metal echoing over the misty bay like a consecrated pledge.

"So be it! Not for vanity or pride, but to prove that the legacy of their fathers lives on to pierce the darkness of this world!"

Thus was born the legend of the Oath of the Seven Pursuers. Turning their steeds toward the howling blizzards of the north, the seven outlaws rode into destiny, while Hercul walked alone into the blood-scented shadows of the southern courts. Two divergent fates set forth across the vast canvas of the Arcane continent.

CHAPTER 03

Episode 3 · Blood on the Mist Cliff

Part 1 · Episode 03 of 40

Crossing the jagged mountain ranges toward the northern borderlands, the Seven Pursuers found themselves disoriented within the eerie silence of Mistfall Cliff. Colossal basalt monoliths, carved by ancient titans millenia ago, loomed through the vapors like primeval tombstones. Though it was high noon, icy mist rising from the bottomless abyss swallowed their horses' hooves before thickening into an impenetrable shroud that reached their shoulders. Across the dark volcanic rock faces, sinister spirals of dried blood trailed like claw marks.

Eliana dismounted, uncorking a glass vial of azure reagent to sprinkle upon the stone. With a sharp hiss, silvery powder billowed into the air.

"A forbidden strain of dark necromancy," Eliana warned, her voice trembling in the damp mountain chill. "It drains the living vital mana from travelers, petrifying their flesh into crystallized corpses."

Her grim diagnosis vanished into the swirling fog. The mounts snorted anxiously, backing toward the narrow trail. Loose shale clattered down into the void, echoing faintly against the rock walls below.

"Steady, everyone. Draw your steel," Gawain commanded softly, lifting his heavy iron staff. "This mist is born of malice, not mountain weather."

Kaze flicked three silver coins into the air, listening to their metallic ring as they dropped into his palm.

"The wind twists inward toward a single vortex," Kaze muttered. "I smell rotting blood instead of coin."

Rondol gripped the wave-carved staff upon his back, shaking his head.

"This is no river vapor rising from the lowlands. It is a barrier woven from the blood and malice of tormented souls."

Grimli planted his maul upon the flagstones, smoothing his braided beard.

"Any devil stepping before my hammer will see his skull forged into an anvil."

Robinyard leaped lightly atop the parapet, gazing through the vapors with a wry grin.

"Ease your shoulders, comrades. In tightrope dancing, freezing in fear is what sends you over the brink."

That very night, within the ruined titan shrine perched atop the precipice, two ominous silhouettes emerged silently between the broken colonnades. They were Medusa Gorgo and the crystal-shaper Belphegor—banished apprentices of the wind sage Aeolus from the distant Wind Isle. Having stolen the dark codex of Nine Shadows, they sought to harvest wandering warriors to complete their forbidden techniques. Gorgo, her blind eyes shrouded in black silk, perceived the world through minute acoustic vibrations, while Belphegor was encased from head to heel in jagged obsidian armor that sprouted directly from his flesh.

Gawain struck the flagstones thrice with the heel of his iron staff.

Clang. Clang. Clang.

The reverberation returning through the granite bedrock yielded not seven footsteps, but eight. The veins upon Gawain's knuckles tautened like bowstrings.

"Above us! Scatter!"

A deafening roar split the night. Shattering the ceiling rafters, Belphegor slammed his obsidian fist into the floor, fracturing the flagstones into radial spiderwebs. Grimli surged forward, his heavy maul deflecting Belphegor's crushing blow at the cost of numbing both his arms, while Aila loosed three rapid quarrels into the swirling mist.

Yet the blind Gorgo heard the friction of the feathers whistling through the air and arched her spine with inhuman grace to dodge each shaft.

"Insolent insects marching willfully into their own tomb!"

Black filaments of concentrated shadow mana erupted from Gorgo's talons, impaling Robinyard's shadow upon the stone wall behind him. With his shadow anchored, Robinyard's physical body locked in place as if bound in invisible iron chains.

Though each of the seven pursuers was a master of their craft, they had never fought together under the pressure of mortal peril. Kaze's throwing daggers were swept aside by Rondol's unruly water currents, and the gale from Grimli's hammer threw stone dust directly across Aila's line of sight.

"Fools! Your hearts shall nourish the completion of my obsidian carapace!" Belphegor bellowed, striking Grimli across the chest and sending the dwarf skidding across the stones, vomiting blood. To worsen their plight, Gorgo unleashed a cloud of purple venom that brought the hunters to their knees, gasping for breath.

"Hold your breath! The poison burns the lungs and corrodes mana!" Eliana shouted, casting purifying herbs into the wind, but the toxic haze thickened relentless.

It was Robinyard, the quietest of the band, who seized the decisive moment.

"Keep your filthy claws off my kin!"

Drawing a serrated skinning knife, Robinyard sliced through his own flesh and gouged the enchanted flagstone beneath him, severing the necrotic threads that pinned his shadow. Though the agony of tearing his spiritual tether burned like molten lead, the acrobat launched himself through the air, wrapping both arms and legs around Belphegor's neck.

Thwack!

Jagged crystal spikes erupted from Belphegor's shoulders, piercing clean through Robinyard's torso. Yet even as lifeblood poured from his lips, Robinyard locked his limbs in an unbreakable vise around the monster's joints.

"Now... Aila, Grimli... listen to each other's breath!"

Robinyard's desperate cry tore through the mist.

Gawain's iron staff struck the stone with a clear, bell-like chime. Guided by that acoustic beacon, Aila fired three paces to the left. Kaze's deflection blade clipped the bolt mid-flight to bend its arc, Rondol's rushing tide doubled its velocity, and the projectile drove straight into the vulnerable joint beneath Belphegor's jaw. Roaring with renewed fury, Grimli brought his maul down in a crushing overhead blow that obliterated the crystal core. As Eliana splashed consecrated holy water into the fracture, Belphegor shrieked in agony and plummeted over the cliffside into the abyss.

Gorgo hissed in fury as her partner vanished into the fog.

"Seven Pursuers... you shall repay this blood a thousandfold!" she snarled, dissolving into the swirling vapors.

On the mist-soaked stones, Robinyard touched the faces of his weeping companions one last time.

"Brothers and sisters... do not weep. Trading one rogue life to fell that abomination is a bargain well struck."

Robinyard whispered, coughing faintly as the silver bell at his hip tinkled softly in the gale.

"Go north... find the boy... keep the vow to Aleksandar..."

"Robinyard! Stay awake! I can close the wound!" Eliana cried, but the brave acrobat smiled gently and closed his eyes forever beneath the freezing wind.

With heavy hearts and tear-streaked faces, the six surviving masters interred their brother upon the rocky summit. Grimli bound Robinyard's silver bell firmly to the crown of his heavy warhammer with hardened steel wire.

"Every time this bell chimes in battle, I shall know you are dancing beside us. Robinyard... we shall forge that boy into the realm's greatest shield."

"We are six now, but Robinyard walks forever within our breath," Gawain said softly. "Forward, to the northern wastes!"

Only through this bitter sacrifice had the hunters forged an unbreakable bond of mutual trust, stepping forward as true guardians of the realm.

CHAPTER 04

Episode 4 · The Child Raised in the Wastes

Part 1 · Episode 04 of 40

Six cruel winters passed across the northern steppe. Holding fast to her son Kadan—the boy her husband Aleksandar had died to preserve—Elwin managed to survive amidst the smoky leather yurts of the Wildlands, where fierce nomad clans grazed their shaggy herds. Set upon the frozen loam of the permafrost, the circular encampment trembled nightly beneath the howling of tundra wolves and the shrieking arctic gales. Reared in the teeth of arctic blizzards, the boy grew broad-boned and sturdy, yet his speech developed slowly and he failed to kindle even a spark of elemental mana by his tenth year.

While other nomad youths mounted war-ponies at age five and learned to bend arrows with wind currents, young Kadan quietly hauled iron buckets of glacial water and hammered fallen stockade poles back into the frozen soil with heavy river stones. His small hands bore thick, calloused ridges, and his cheeks were perpetually chapped by frostbite.

The clan elders called him Kadan, honoring the name Aleksandar had whispered before the bridge collapsed: the steadfast shield that endures against every tempest. Kadan cared little for boastful words or martial vanity, cherishing instead the coarse barley cakes and dried mutton his mother placed in his rough hands after a long day of toil.

"Mother, while repairing the fence today, I found a wolf pup frozen in the drifts," Kadan spoke softly by the hearth fire one evening.

"And what did you do, my child?" Elwin asked gently, pausing her mending.

"I used father's silver dagger to carve away the ice and carried it into the barn corner. Will it live?"

Kadan drew forth the treasured heirloom from within his tunic. The ancient rune of the holy order engraved along the fuller glimmered softly against the flickering flames. Elwin clasped her son's weathered fingers in both her hands.

"You did well, Kadan. A heart that honors life possesses greater power than any spell. Your father Aleksandar always remembered the warmth of life he swore to protect before ever drawing his blades."

"Will I ever become a steadfast shield like father, protecting those who stand behind me?"

"Of course, my child. The sturdiest trees strike their deepest roots in the harshest northern gales."

One bitterly frigid dawn, Gilgamesh, the young heir of Conqueror King Fenrir who ruled the confederation of northern clans, was ambushed in a frozen gorge by rival raiders. Enchanted frost arrows felled Gilgamesh's escort, leaving the bleeding youth thrown from his horse and surrounded by blades.

Watching from a nearby pasture, Kadan carried neither bow nor iron knife. Yet without a heartbeat's hesitation, the boy vaulted down the icy embankment into the fray.

"Lay no hand upon him!"

Scooping up handfuls of frozen shale and ice chunks, Kadan hurled them with pinpoint force into the eyes of the charging steeds. As the warhorses reared in confusion, Kadan seized the groaning Gilgamesh and threw the boy onto his own back.

"Are you insane? Leave me and run! They will slaughter you!" Gilgamesh screamed through bloodied teeth.

Kadan answered only by clenching his jaw, bolting toward the center of the frozen river. Crrrk! Crack! The ominous spiderwebbing of brittle ice shrieked beneath their weight. If their mass remained concentrated, both boys would plunge into the black, freezing torrent below. Trusting an instinctive balance inherited from his father's blood, Kadan flattened his posture, sliding across the slick surface like an otter across ice to distribute their weight.

"Loose the quarrels! Drown the savage dog and the prince together!" the pursuing leader roared.

A volley of iron crossbow bolts peppered the sheet. One bolt grazed Kadan's thigh, tearing flesh and spilling hot blood onto the frost. Despite the agonizing burn, Kadan never released his grip on Gilgamesh's arms. A crimson line traced their path across the white riverbed.

"Hold fast! The wolfguard watchtower lies just beyond the ridge!" Kadan gasped through ragged breaths.

By the time King Fenrir's wolfguard crested the ridge to encircle and annihilate the ambushers, Kadan had dragged Gilgamesh safely onto the southern bank before collapsing in exhaustion.

Fenrir reined his silver-maned war-steed before the bleeding boy, his eyes flashing beneath a wolfskin cowl.

"Why risk your young life for my son, peasant boy? Do you covet gold, or land within my horde?"

Nursing his torn leg, Kadan shook his head with quiet sincerity.

"My mother taught me that to abandon a bleeding child before one's eyes is a cowardice no man should bear."

Fenrir studied the unclouded clarity in Kadan's eyes and threw his head back in thunderous laughter.

"A lion's heart! From this sunrise forth, you are a guest of my grand pavilion and a shield-brother to Gilgamesh."

Gilgamesh removed the bronze wolf talisman from his neck, pressing it into Kadan's palm with tearful gratitude.

"My life is yours, Kadan. Henceforth, you are my brother."

That night, six dust-caked travelers in threadbare cloaks rode into the encampment. Having crossed savage peaks over six agonizing years, the surviving masters—Gawain, Grimli, Aila, Eliana, Kaze, and Rondol—had finally reached the northern plains.

Near the fringe of the horse lines, they felt a resonant hum vibrating through their souls. At Kadan's hip hung a slender silver dagger bound in leather thongs. Along the fuller, the ancient rune of the Arcane Holy Order flared with brilliant white-silver radiance, chiming in unison with Gawain's staff and the silver bell upon Grimli's hammer.

"We found him... by the heavens, we have found Aleksandar's boy!"

Grimli let his maul strike the earth as thick tears cut through the soot on his beard. The bell tinkled clearly. Aila dropped to her knees in the drift, pulling the bewildered Kadan into a fierce embrace.

"You live, little one... To return your father's broken legacy and this silver dagger, we have journeyed across half the continent."

Elwin emerged from the yurt flap, her eyes widening as she recognized the Holy Order crest and the companions of Hercul. Tears she had held for six winters poured freely down her weathered cheeks.

"You remembered Aleksandar's sacrifice..."

Gawain bowed his head with the solemn dignity of a lifelong tracker.

"Lady Elwin, we carry the oath paid in Robinyard's blood. Though the boy's tongue be slow and his mana dormant, we shall temper him into an unbreakable shield that the world shall revere."

Grimli slammed his fist against his breastplate.

"I will grind my bones and my hammer to dust before Aleksandar's name is ever tarnished!"

Kaze flicked a silver coin, admiring Kadan's calloused hands.

"Hands tougher than an iron anvil. I like him already."

Beneath the blazing yurt fires, Aleksandar's legacy and the Oath of the Seven Pursuers intertwined at last. In the cradle of the northern gale, the young sapling had taken root, ready to grow into a fortress against the coming dark.

CHAPTER 05

Episode 5 · Phantom in the Downpour

Part 1 · Episode 05 of 40

The brief northern summer cooled rapidly, and a savage tempest swept across the high bluffs of the Wildlands. Violet lightning cracked through the churning clouds, illuminating the basalt canyons in eerie brilliance, driving the six masters and twelve-year-old Kadan into the mouth of a subterranean limestone cavern. Hollowed over untold millennia by underground torrents, the cavern opened like a forgotten titan's shrine, its ceiling bristling with crystalline stalactites hung with luminous green moss.

Drying their heavy fur cloaks beside a kindled fire, the masters remained vigilant. Aila inspected the unstrung sinew of her crossbow, watching the rain sheet across the canyon.

"This is no natural squall," Aila murmured. "The mana threads are twisted. Someone weaves an artificial veil of black sorcery behind the clouds."

Eliana tasted the mineral spring trickling between the rock fissures and frowned.

"The taste of sulfur and rot. Not the water of living earth, but the residue of obsidian crystal corruption that leaches vitality."

Amidst the rhythmic patter of condensation and the roar of the deluge outside, a chilling scrape of iron chains dragged across the cavern flags. Before the embers could catch, the silver runes carved into the cavern ceiling inverted into abyssal darkness. From the shadows emerged Medusa Gorgo, her blind eyes bound in black silk, obsidian talons gleaming with lethal venom.

"Six winters have I hunted your scent across this barren waste," Gorgo sneered, her voice reverberating from every crack in the stone. "And at last, Aleksandar's stray cur is delivered into my web."

Moving without sight, Gorgo rode the acoustic vibrations of falling raindrops and the thermal drafts of the chamber. With the crack of thunder, her poisoned talons plunged toward Kadan's throat.

"Kadan, down!" Aila cried, firing three quarrels, but they struck only a fading purple afterimage. Gorgo had already merged into the shadow cast behind the boy's boots. Panic seized Kadan's chest, but Gawain's thunderous command shattered his dread.

"Close your eyes, Kadan! The witch does not dwell where your eyes seek her!"

Gawain struck his iron staff against the bedrock, sending harmonic acoustic ripples surging through the cavern.

"Your sight deceives you, boy, but the rain lashing your skin never lies! Remember the path of acoustics taught by Lord Aeolus of the Wind Isle! No living being can cut through the air without leaving a void in the gale!"

Kadan inhaled sharply and snapped his eyelids shut.

Within the absolute darkness of his mind, a breathtaking sensory tapestry unfolded: the steady cadence of water droplets from the ceiling, the ragged heave of Grimli's chest, the angled sheets of wind spray, and—there! A solitary pocket where falling drops bent unnaturally around an empty space!

'She is there! The wind is hollow!'

Without hesitation, Kadan gripped his silver dagger and spun on his heel, driving the white-silver blade into the empty pocket of air with all his young strength.

Clang!

The silver blade slammed violently into Gorgo's conjured chain. White sparks erupted through the cavern, the razor tip cutting through her silk cuff and biting deep into her wrist meridians.

"Insolent whelp! You anticipate an unseen strike?"

Gorgo gasped, recoiling as her balance broke. The masters seized the opening ruthlessly. Grimli brought down his great hammer, collapsing the rear rock arch and sealing her escape route. The silver bell upon his hammer chimed like an enraged beast.

"Robinyard's vengeance is at hand, foul witch!"

Rondol swept subterranean water upward in a surging wave, stripping away Gorgo's toxic mist. Three barbed quarrels from Aila's crossbow punched through Gorgo's shoulder and thigh, while Kaze's paired daggers severed her primary mana meridians.

Bleeding onto the stone, Gorgo detonated a violet smoke bomb and leaped toward the subterranean cataract.

"Clever curs... but do not rejoice! While you rot in these northern wastes, Balian's son is raised in the Red Glass Court as Prince Lucian's most lethal assassin! And upon the distant Wind Isle, Lord Aeolus's daughter, the brilliant Silia, grows into a storm that will tear this continent apart!"

"Silence, hag!" Grimli threw his hammer, but Gorgo vanished beneath the surging rapids.

As the deluge subsided, silence returned to the cavern. Kadan wiped cold sweat from his palms and looked toward Gawain.

"Master... who is this girl Silia from the Wind Isle? And who is the son of Balian she spoke of?"

Gawain rested upon his staff, listening to the murmuring earth outside.

"The Wind Isle is an isolated sanctuary upon the eastern sea. Its ruler, Aeolus, is the proudest and most formidable sage of air mana. It is said he has a daughter named Silia, sharp as diamond and free as the sea breeze. If the Shadow Realm touches her, war will engulf the world."

Kadan placed his hand upon his chest.

"Is she... also hunted and afraid, like me?"

Aila brushed back his damp hair with a gentle smile.

"Then you must grow stronger, Kadan. The shield to protect others is never granted to those who simply wait. To honor the silver dagger your father left behind."

Grimli chuckled, setting his maul beside the hearth.

"Aye, lad! Deflecting a phantom blade in the dark was fine work. Tomorrow, your boulder drills triple!"

Eliana bound Kadan's scraped arm with soothing mountain moss salve.

"Fear not your scars. Healed flesh becomes an armor tougher than boiled hide."

Kadan gazed past the broken cavern mouth toward the morning star rising through the clearing skies. Having learned to listen with closed eyes, the boy felt the distant fate of the world and the name of Silia etch itself into his destiny like a shining silver ripple.

CHAPTER 06

Episode 6 · The Art of Breathing Stars

Part 1 · Episode 06 of 40

The divergent teachings of the six masters pulled young Kadan in conflicting directions every single day. On the frozen plateau of the Wildlands, Grimli the dwarven smith roared at him to root his boots like an immoveable granite boulder, while Kaze the gambler urged him to deceive the eye and twist away before a blade could make contact. Aila the Demon Hunter commanded him to halt his breath entirely before drawing the string to erase his heartbeat, yet Rondol the boatman insisted that breath must flow incessantly like ocean swells lest his stamina wither. Eliana counseled him to discern poisonous spores, and Gawain the blind tracker told him to seal his ears and trust only the tremors beneath his boots.

"Axes and hammers know no deception!" Grimli roared across the gale. "Tough as iron forged upon the anvil, yield not an inch of loam!"

"A clumsy bear gets skinned in a pit-trap," Kaze mocked, spinning three silver marks between his scarred knuckles. "Slip past the blade half an inch before it bites your neck!"

"Hold your breath till the pulse fades," Aila whispered with glacial precision. "Only unbroken stillness pierces the shadows."

"Nay, stillness breeds stagnant blood!" Rondol argued, striking his wave-carved staff upon the drift. "Ride the surges as an oarsman rides the breakers!"

Kadan strove desperately to master each doctrine, yet in practice, the disparate disciplines collided, reducing his swordcraft to clumsy chaos. Even upon turning fifteen, the youth could not execute a basic three-step shield parry without tumbling into the snow.

"Your wrist is clenched like an iron bar! Your father Aleksandar held his twin blades as light as eagle down!"

When Grimli cursed and stalked away into the swirling snow one winter night, Kadan swallowed his bitter tears alone. The agonizing shame that he was squandering his masters' sacrifices and dishonoring his father's memory clawed at his chest. Venturing into the freezing darkness, Kadan began scaling the sheer ice-crusted bluffs above the camp. Freezing rime tore beneath his fingernails and blood welled from his scraped knees, yet the physical sting was far gentler than the shame in his soul.

Upon a narrow limestone ledge halfway up the cliff rested the aerie of a northern mountain hawk. Its mother having perished in a trapper's snare, two newly hatched chicks were whimpering in starvation against the frost. It was a dizzying precipice that no wingless mortal could hope to scale.

After slipping and tumbling from the rock face five times, battered and gasping for air, Kadan heard a calm voice speaking from the rock shadow below. An old hermit cloaked in moss-green wool stood leaning upon a crooked hazel staff. It was Malfurion.

"You climb with brute muscle alone, child. That is why the mountain rejects you."

Wiping blood from his forehead, Kadan rasped.

"Can a cliff... truly reject a man?"

"If you refuse to listen to the breath of the world, why should the mountain heed your clumsy struggles? The same is true of the steel in your hand."

Without touching the rock with his hands, Malfurion walked lightly up the sheer vertical wall. Wherever his bare boots stepped, vibrant green moss bloomed from the ice, anchoring his tread upon the slick glaze. Gently gathering the starving chicks into his cowl and feeding them dried venison, the hermit descended and fixed Kadan with an unblinking gaze.

"Three nights hence, when the full moon crests the ridge, meet me at the summit. Speak of this to no one."

For three days Kadan drilled knotcraft and foot placement obsessively. On the appointed night, Kadan spent half the hours of darkness clawing through the blizzard until he dragged his frozen limbs onto the windy peak before the moon could set.

Malfurion sat cross-legged on the summit stone, carrying neither sword nor cudgel.

"Sit, Kadan. Close your eyes. With each inhalation, gather a solitary star into your heart. With each exhalation, return a snowflake to the loam."

Malfurion explained that mana was not an internal fuel to be squeezed from strained sinews, but an acoustic cadence harmonizing the body with the pulse of the continent.

"In the southern Red Glass Court, Balian's son Ignis was born blessed with fierce white flame, amassing destructive arts with every sunrise. Yet raw fire leaves only ash when the fuel burns out. What you must cultivate is the unquenchable breath of the stars."

Kadan finally understood: Grimli's boulder-like weight, Kaze's lightning feints, and Aila's quiet stillness were not contradictory doctrines, but different tempos of the celestial sphere.

Malfurion offered no flattery. If Kadan's breath wavered, he flicked a hardened hazelnut against the youth's brow. When concentration drifted into isolation, he posed abrupt riddles.

"If you count the stars so intently that you miss the tread of your comrade behind you, whom does that shield protect?"

Kadan bowed his head, placing a palm over his breast.

"My shield exists not to preserve my own breath, but to shield the warmth of those trembling behind me from the bitter gale."

Malfurion nodded with a serene smile.

"Hold fast to that truth. Therein lies the true soul of an unbreakable shield."

When Kadan finally returned to the hunters' yurt, Gawain paused his staff upon the shale, turning his blind eyes in astonishment. Kadan's footsteps made no sound upon the gravel, his breathing indistinguishable from the mountain breeze.

"Your footsteps have melted into the gale, Kadan. I shall not pry into where you wander at night. But if you dare brandish this newly found power in vanity, I shall break your legs myself."

Aila wiped her crossbow by the hearth, her lips softening with sisterly warmth.

"Your gaze has deepened, Kadan. The light of the morning star shines in your eyes."

Grimli hoisted his maul with a booming chuckle.

"Aye, lad! Your bones have found their iron. Return to my anvil tomorrow!"

At last, the breath of the cosmos had entered the young warrior's shield.

CHAPTER 07

Episode 7 · The Traitors' Pavilion

Part 1 · Episode 07 of 40

As the campfire smoke coiling across the vast plains of the Wildlands began to wane, the northern night sky gathered heavy charcoal snow-clouds as though preparing to unleash a merciless blizzard. The leather eaves of the yurts fluttered softly against the biting gale, and around the frigid troughs, iron horse-bells chimed with dull, muted clangs. Nomad families appeased the biting frost with strips of dry salted mutton and barley broth steeped in yak butter before extinguishing their tallow lamps for the night. On this final evening before venturing south, Kadan—now an eighteen-year-old wanderer forged by the tundra—stealthily crossed the craggy basalt ridges alongside the hermit Malfurion, hunting the sinister mana trail of Medusa Gorgo.

Gorgo had nestled into an abandoned cobalt quarry barely half a league from Chieftain Fenrir's vanguard camp. Inside the subterranean hollow, the stench of acrid sulfur and charred leather hung thick in the air. Upon the rock wall, she carved forbidden runes of the Nine Shadow Codex stolen from master Aeolus, honing her maddened sorcery. Each time her black-iron chain whip cracked against the stone, the slumbering mana within the bedrock withered away, crumbling into pale flakes of crystalline salt.

Just as Malfurion and Kadan held their breath in the shadows of a fissure, eight riders enveloped in black wool cloaks dismounted before the entrance. Astonishingly, the leading warlord was Bargast, sworn blood-brother to Fenrir and second-in-command of the entire tribal confederacy. Even more alarming was the crimson livery of the figure emerging from the gloom to greet him: an envoy bearing the gold-stitched flame crest of Lucian, prime minister of the Red Glass Court.

The envoy lowered his tone, proffering a wax-sealed parchment.

> "The appointed strike falls upon tomorrow night. Paralyzing venom will be introduced into Fenrir's banquet horn. The instant Fenrir collapses, rally the clan lances beneath the banners of the Shadow Realm."

Bargast's hoarse rasp echoed along the damp stone.

> "Fenrir's fall will ignite fierce outrage among the elders. When will the royal host reach our borders?"

The crimson envoy sneered coldly, tossing a heavy sack of gold coins.

"Ignis, son of Balian, marches north at the head of the Court's White Flame Order. You shall be crowned paramount warlord of the northern reaches, so banish your misgivings."

Hearing the names of Balian and Ignis fall from the emissary's lips sent a jolt through Kadan's chest. Delay was unthinkable. Following Malfurion's silent gesture, Kadan slipped away from the crag, turning their mounts toward Fenrir's war yurt.

Yet when they arrived at the council tent, Kadan was met not by trust, but by an unyielding barrier of suspicion. Seated upon the great white-wolf throne, Fenrir listened to the breathless warning of the youthful wanderer, but thirty winters of brotherhood blinded him to betrayal. Frost clung to the chieftain's iron-gray beard, and deep scars carved across his brow bore witness to dozens of harsh winters survived in blood and honor.

"Bargast has bled beside me for three decades hunting northern frost-beasts! Would you have me condemn my dearest brother upon the loose tongue of a wandering stripling?"

Chieftains muttered in agreement around the hearth. Worse still, Bargast had anticipated the blow, preemptively branding Malfurion as a southern infiltrator and binding him in heavy iron fetters.

Bargast strode into the pavilion, resting a gauntleted hand upon his bloody pommel. His eyes glinted like a hungry timber wolf, a mocking sneer curving his lips.

"Lord brother, I witnessed this vagrant elder and his young pup conspiring in secret with court delegates within the old cobalt mine! Slay these disruptors of northern unity at once!"

Bound in chains, Malfurion offered not a word of self-defense, gazing steadily at Kadan. It was a silent trial—an injunction to rely not upon borrowed authority or blind wrath, but upon senses and wits honed through discipline to lay bare the truth.

The conclusive thread emerged in the dead of night. Slipping beneath the baggage wagons, Titania pried loose shimmering shards of red volcanic glass from the saddle lining of a slain courier, scattering them across Fenrir's oak table. Such tempered glass was manufactured solely by the elite cavalry of the southern capital. Fenrir's calloused hands trembled, his weathered countenance turning rigid as frozen lake ice. At that very moment, Bargast entered the tent unescorted, bearing the wolf-fang amulet they had split between them in their youth.

"Brother, it is enough to graze within the borders set by our ancestors. Why force thirty clans into a single realm and invite the wrath of the throne? Take back this fang and surrender with honor."

Fenrir took the fang, pressing it deep into the frosty soil beneath his boots. His voice fell lower and heavier than the midnight gales.

"I seek to end the madness of children slaughtering one another over the same frozen well year after year. If tradition serves only to swell the count of our graves, I shall shatter it with my own hands."

At dawn, Bargast's rebels and imperial rune-knights stormed the perimeter hills. Common arrows shattered uselessly against the heavy plate of the vanguard, and the mud at the slope's foot echoed with screams. Blending the defensive arts of Master Aleksandar with Malfurion's star-breathing, Kadan held the breach. Tilting his iron shield to deflect charging lances into empty air, Kadan disarmed Bargast's ferocious son, Ursak, sending his broadsword spinning into the frost.

As allied braves raised their spears to claim the young captain's head, Kadan reversed his silver dagger and barred their path with his shield.

"Slaying a helpless captive breeds only terror, not victory. Cleanse his wounds and let him walk."

Ursak spat blood and muddy slush, glaring up with venomous fury.

"Save your false pity, boy! When my father sweeps this hill, your severed skull shall crown a watchpost!"

Without replying, Kadan retrieved a strip of clean linen, binding the gashed brow of the fallen youth before guiding him safely down the slope.

"Do not waste your life in service of your father's vain greed. Live, and witness the truth."

Witnessing such unexpected mercy and unbending resolve, the young rebel levies hesitated, lowering their spear-points across the front.

Three days later, Fenrir launched a decisive flanking assault, breaking Bargast's garrison. The ringleaders were condemned, yet Fenrir granted Bargast a cup of sweetened poison, preserving his final dignity as a warrior. While victory horns resounded over the steppes, Fenrir's eyes remained dark with sorrow. Beckoning Kadan to the armory tent, he offered chests of bullion and a greatbow carved of ancient dragon bone.

"Name your recompense, young warrior. I would carve you half the northern steppes."

Kadan shook his head, replying softly.

"Only ensure that the fallen conscripts from Bargast's levies are inscribed upon the ancestral rolls. True peace comes only when equal rest is granted to all who shed their blood."

Taking Kadan's hand, Fenrir proclaimed his betrothal to Titania before the gathered chiefs.

"I place my greatest treasure into your care. Become the lion of the steppes and lead our people!"

The throng roared in acclaim, but Titania slipped past the bonfires to stand quietly by the horse stalls. The north wind brushed her cheeks with frosty chill, yet her eyes shone with pristine clarity. As Kadan approached, she reached out, tightening the crimson silk ribbon bound to his dagger's hilt.

"I am neither prize nor chattel to be gifted, Kadan. When you return from the southern courts, ask me then whether I choose you."

Within her unyielding gaze, Kadan beheld the true, unbroken soul of the northern frontier.

"I shall remember, Titania. I swear to return alive so that your choice may never bring regret."

Beneath the vault of the midnight sky, stars drew shimmering silver paths behind their shoulders—an overture to the epic trials awaiting a wanderer destined for the southern realm.

CHAPTER 08

Episode 8 · Rider of the Crimson Mane

Part 1 · Episode 08 of 40

After half a day's hard riding south from the frost-locked tundras of the Wildlands, the landscape gradually transformed from stony wastes into the misty border citadel of Pegasus Valley. Beyond the low parapets of rough-hewn rubble, the creaking timber of freight wagons mingled with the coarse shouts of mercenary bands arriving from every quadrant of the realm. Venders along the muddy thoroughfares tended iron pots of boiling turnips and roasted potatoes, the pungent aroma of woodsmoke and damp straw drifting upon the brisk autumn air. Under tavern eaves, coarse gamblers cursed violently over lost dice games. Eighteen-year-old Kadan, having parted ways with the hermit Malfurion to journey south alone, meditated upon the tenets of Master Aleksandar as he found an unoccupied wooden bench at the edge of the market stalls.

In a broad stockade corral at the edge of the marketplace, a horse auction was in full swing. Brandishing leather whips, the traders waved red pennants and bellowed to the crowd, yet the spectators stood ten paces back in murmuring apprehension. In the center of the enclosure stood an enormous wild stallion, its crimson mane billowing like an autumn cascade across sleek, obsidian-black flanks. It was the legendary wild stallion 'Crimson Mane.' Deemed hopelessly feral and branded a wild beast by royal cavalry examiners, the magnificent mount faced imminent slaughter at the knacker's block. Across its muscular chest ran crisscrossed scars from heavy whips and rusted chains.

The chief auctioneer cracked his iron chain against the dirt.

"Three silver pieces! Any gallant soul willing to claim this mad demon for three silver coins? Stand clear unless you fancy having your skulls caved in!"

Maddened by the clinking chains, Crimson Mane reared high, its iron-shod hooves battering the timber railing. Heavy oak palisades cracked with violent splinters. As the onlookers scattered in panic, Kadan stepped calmly through the fractured gate, bearing no weapons in his hands.

The auctioneer turned pale, shrieking in horror.

"Boy! Are you possessed? Back away before you are trampled into red paste!"

Ignoring the cries, Kadan lowered his gaze, harmonizing his respiration with the ragged snorts of the wild mount. When the stallion charged with thundering fury, Kadan neither fled nor drew

steel. Moving fluidly along the beast's flank via the star-breathing discipline, he swept past the shoulder and laid a gentle, steady palm upon the trembling crest of its neck. Sensing the deep rhythm of the earth and an unshakable heartbeat devoid of malice, the beast shuddered. Kadan gently stroked the calloused skin where iron bits had torn the horse's muzzle.

"No chain shall bind you in pain again. If you wish to run, the boundless plains are yours."

As the setting sun cast long amber shadows over the dust, Crimson Mane lowered its proud head, resting its velvet muzzle softly against Kadan's leather vambrace. Leaving behind the stunned cheers of the crowd, Kadan led the stallion by its halter into the bustling tavern lane in search of a warm meal.

At the entrance to the lane, a commotion broke out. A slender girl enveloped in a frayed wool mantle was being violently shoved against a timber counter by a corpulent grain merchant. It was Cilia, the apprentice wind mage.

The merchant brandished an ash truncheon, his face purple with rage.

"Thieving gutter-rat! You crept behind my grain sacks to steal flour! I'll hand you over to the garrison dungeons!"

Soot-smudged cheeks held high, Cilia retorted with razor-sharp defiance.

"Cease your mindless squawking! Look at the flour dust near the cellar hatch. There are no tiny straw-sandal tracks—only the broad wooden clogs of the tavern bouncer across the street. If the gods gave you eyes, try employing your brain!"

As the enraged merchant raised his truncheon to strike, Kadan stepped between them, nudging the weapon aside with the rim of his iron shield.

"The girl speaks the truth, and the evidence is clear. Lower your stick."

Flipping a silver coin onto the counter to quiet the dispute, Kadan guided the famished girl to a nearby soup stall. He ordered two steaming bowls of beef-bone broth with turnips and a warm loaf of sesame bread.

When the soup arrived, Cilia surreptitiously dipped a silver hairpin into the broth to test for narcotics. Noticing her wariness, Kadan took up his wooden spoon and swallowed a generous draught first. Cilia arched a skeptical brow.

"You place blind trust in strangers far too easily. What if I am a cunning cutpurse waiting to pick your pockets?"

Kadan tore the warm sesame loaf in half, offering the larger portion.

"Anyone willing to endure a truncheon blow to prove the truth is genuinely starving. Eat first."

Cilia stared at him in quiet astonishment, then took a sip of the savory broth, her shoulders softening in the steam.

"...My name is Cilia. I was making my way toward the Grand Academy in the capital. And who might you be?"

"I am Kadan of the Wildlands. I seek High Commander Ignis of the White Flame Order."

At the mention of Ignis, Cilia's gaze frosted over instantly. She set her spoon down, murmuring bitterly.

"Ignis... So you seek the gilded puppet of the Flame Court. You will only find yourself ensnared in the venal machinations of the high lords. You would do well to tread lightly."

As they departed the shadowed alleyways after nightfall, a dozen horse thieves lying in wait barred their path, naked steel gleaming in the moonlight. The bandit leader grinned malevolently.

"Hand over the crimson stallion and your purse, and you might crawl away with your hides! That warhorse will keep our crew in luxury for a year!"

Before Kadan could brace his shield, Cilia gave a crisp snap of her fingers.

"Muscular brawn alone is clumsy in tight corridors. Watch the wind's eye."

With a swift incantation, a miniature whirlwind tore through the lane, collapsing the striped canvas awnings over the raiders. Trapped beneath heavy tarpaulins, the thieves stumbled blindly while rolling barrels of winter apples took out their knees. The brigands collapsed in a tangled heap of bruised limbs and howling curses.

Kadan let out a genuine chuckle of admiration.

"You are certainly no ordinary beggar girl."

Cilia brushed her cloak with a satisfied smirk.

"Naturally. So pay heed to my counsel hereafter."

At that instant, violent detonations and terrified screams erupted from the central duel platform. The wandering knight Balbo was battling desperately to protect his foster daughter, Eliana. His

adversary was none other than High Commander Ignis, inspecting the frontier with an escort of royal knights.

With an immaculate sweep of his blade, Ignis unleashed arcs of pure white fire, ruthlessly incinerating Eliana's protective briar wards. The fury of the flames was unbridled, scorching the stone floor in blackened rings of heat. As Balbo collapsed upon the flagstones coughing crimson, Ignis casually kicked Eliana's torn leather shoe into the mud below with cold contempt.

While the spectators cowered in silence, Kadan strode steadily up the timber stairs. Retrieving the muddy shoe, he gently slipped it onto Eliana's foot, then tightened his grip upon the silver dagger with its crimson ribbon, staring directly into Ignis's eyes.

"If you have won, you have nothing left to prove. Why humiliate the fallen?"

Ignis looked upon the silver dagger and the battered iron shield in the stranger's hands. Recognizing the ancient runic engraving of the House of Aleksandar on the pommel, an inexplicable surge of turbulent fury and electric recognition pierced Ignis's heart.

Leveling his blade with icy malice, Ignis sneered.

"A vagrant dares preach righteousness to me? Let us see if that tarnished dagger can withstand my flame!"

Thus began the fateful, fiery reckoning between the two destined youths, as cold autumn mists gathered over the battlements to shroud their drawn blades.

CHAPTER 09

Episode 9 · Wind in Beggar's Clothes

Part 1 · Episode 09 of 40

Upon the timber platform of Lighthaven's inner forum, tension solidified into razor-sharp ice. Crimson silk standards fluttered from the perimeter parapets, and from gilded balconies overhead, noblewomen with ivory fans and courtiers with perfumed beards looked down in avid curiosity. The throng of common folk held their breath, their gazes darting between Kadan—a nameless youth robed in rugged northern furs bearing an unadorned iron shield—and Ignis, the celebrated young champion of the realm gleaming in immaculate white-silver plate. Sulfur smoke from the previous bout seeped through the flagstone fissures, and charred remnants of protective brambles drifted on the chilly autumn gale like gray snow.

The court herald blew his gilded trumpet, his voice booming over the assembly.

> "A vagabond wretch from the Wildlands dares challenge the sacred honor of the White Flame Order! Witness the immaculate judgment of High Commander Ignis!"

Ignis's golden eyes gleamed with haughty condescension as he inspected Kadan's battered shield. A cold sneer curved his lips.

> "A nameless vagabond dares trespass upon an imperial duel? You court your own execution. That rusted iron lid shall serve as your headstone!"

Ignis raised his longsword in a high guard, and pure white sanctifying flames roared to life along the steel like a cataract of liquid fire. Descending with thunderous force, the opening gambit, 'Incandescent Flash,' struck like lightning. A blinding sheet of white brilliance cleaved the air, yet Kadan did not yield half a pace. Drawing upon the foundation taught by Master Aleksandar, he tilted the rim of his iron shield at an obtuse angle, deflecting the kinetic axis of the strike. With a deafening clang, arcs of white flame scattered harmlessly into the empty air.

Shocked that his opening stroke was turned aside, Ignis's expression hardened into granite. Without pausing, he unleashed his second technique, 'Solar Cleave,' sending a fissure of roaring white flame across the arena stones. The granite flagstones split apart with volcanic fury, yet Kadan grounded his weight through star-breathing, redirecting the devastating shockwave into the perimeter stone pillars.

As successive attacks failed before the eyes of the gathered aristocracy, Ignis's pride gave way to dark fury. Channeling forbidden mana, he summoned the parasitic life-drain claw imparted in secret by Medusa Gorgo. Blackish-crimson runes coiled around Ignis's gauntleted fingers, slashing violently across Kadan's left shoulder. With a sickening hiss, the cured leather armor burned away, dark crimson blood welling through the scorched tear. A foul stench of necrotic decay rose from the charred flesh.

Watching from the front ranks of the crowd, Cilia snapped her fingers with lightning speed.

"Subterranean wards are synchronizing with his mana! Disengage, Kadan!"

Manipulating subterranean air currents, Cilia severed the tracking magic circles concealed beneath the flagstones. Microscopic needles of compressed wind punctured the hidden ley conduits, paralyzing the imperial mages' sensory wards in a burst of azure sparks.

At that exact moment, an imposing warrior bearing the sapphire mantle of the Arcane Holy Knights leaped onto the platform like a bolt of lightning. It was Paladin Walker.

Walker brought down his jade-encrusted staff, parrying Ignis's flaming blade with a resounding boom.

"Who taught you to employ that vile parasitic claw? You dare sully the immaculate flame of the Holy Order with the necrotic sorcery of fiends? Shame upon your steel!"

Yet Gorgo's insidious poison leaped from the blade, creeping up Walker's staff. A pale gray shadow of necrotic venom spread across Walker's temples, causing the veteran to stumble. The forum erupted into pandemonium as watch horns wailed and armored guards surged forward with drawn crossbows. Cilia raised a colossal gale wall, swatting aside the incoming hail of bolts. Grasping the wounded Paladin Walker beneath his arms, Kadan and Cilia melted into the labyrinthine alleys of the lower city.

Inside an abandoned timber windmill on the outskirts of the watermills, Paladin Walker collapsed upon a pallet of dry straw, his ragged gasps shuddering through the gloom. Blood dripping from his wound crystallized into dark frost the instant it touched the floorboards.

Cilia cast aside her soiled beggar's mantle. Beneath the rags emerged a breathtaking tunic of teal silk and a delicate circlet of braided wind-silver. Through locks of flowing silver-blue hair peered the slender, pointed ears of high elven lineage. She was none other than Princess Cilia of Whispering Wind Island, sovereign realm of the eastern seas. Even the dust motes in the abandoned mill seemed to bow before her serene aura.

Panting softly, Cilia inspected Kadan's lacerated shoulder.

"It is Gorgo's life-drain venom. If left untreated, your heart will turn to solid stone within three sunrises."

Despite the agony coursing through his veins, Kadan offered a faint, gentle smile.

"Those silk robes look far too thin for the northern winds. You must have been shivering all this time."

Cilia glared at him in disbelief, yet glistening tears welled at the corners of her eyes.

"Is my attire your primary concern right now? Foolish boy, why did you leap into another's duel only to suffer this horrific wound!"

Breathing heavily from the straw pallet, Paladin Walker spoke with strained rasp.

"Eighteen winters ago, beneath the howling blizzard of Elwin hamlet, Brother Aleksandar and Brother Balian touched the flats of their blades above your cradles. Their sacred vow to defend human dignity and justice remained unbroken before any darkness. Yet corrupt lords of the court and Death Knight Artus orchestrated their betrayal, and infant Ignis was stolen away to be raised as a gilded puppet of the Flame Court."

Kadan tightened his calloused fists. The bedtime lullabies his mother Elwin had sung on frozen winter nights finally aligned with the harsh reality before his eyes.

"Then Ignis is not my sworn enemy... but a brother with whom I must share the truth."

Walker rested a blood-stained gauntlet upon Kadan's shoulder.

"Indeed. To strike him down with steel is simple, but to liberate his soul from the fetters of shadow requires a heart bound to the true oath. To purge this venom, you require the Moonlit Herb—an ancient panacea guarded exclusively inside the royal apothecary. Yet that sanctum is sealed behind three tiers of impenetrable imperial wards, and beneath it operate horrific alchemical contraptions extracting the living mana of captive souls."

Kadan withdrew his mother's keepsake, the silver dagger.

"The runes upon this silver blade can unravel any lock. I shall breach the vault."

Cilia blocked the doorway, shaking her head.

"You cannot go alone. The subterranean exhaust shafts of the royal gardens can only be navigated through the guidance of wind sorcery."

Under cover of midnight gloom, the two crept into the imperial conservatory. The sewer waterways reeked of rotting lichen and pungent sludge. Cilia wove a continuous sound-dampening breeze that erased their footfalls, while Kadan channeled the frost mana of the silver dagger, flash-freezing the internal tumbler pins of the heavy iron vaults until they snapped cleanly. Pushing open the massive bronze portals, the radiant azure aroma of the Moonlit Herb greeted their senses, glowing softly in the dark. Growing inside frosty glass domes, the crystalline leaves shimmered with self-luminous starlight.

As they gathered the healing herbs, Kadan's gaze snagged upon an iron dispatch coffer stamped with red wax in the corner. Opening the docket, Kadan's heart ceased beating for an agonizing second.

'Seventh Subterranean Labor Camp: Former Grand Master Balian, living mana extraction trials ongoing.'

Uncle Balian still lived. Within Kadan's breast, the oath sworn beneath the stars flared into an incandescent flame.

"Uncle Balian survives... I swear upon my blood to tear down his chains."

Cilia rested a hand upon Kadan's uninjured shoulder, nodding with solemn determination.

"Let us brew the draught to heal Paladin Walker, then march upon the labor camp at once. The winds shall be our unfailing guide."

Moonlight poured through the skylights, illuminating the path of two young heroes stepping forward across the capital's dark expanse. The profound weight of the ancient vow enveloped their shoulders, and with every passing shadow, the nascent dawn they sought to usher in burned ever brighter.

CHAPTER 10

Episode 10 · Prisoner of the Flame Court

Part 1 · Episode 10 of 40

Towering at the very core of Lighthaven's inner citadel, the Red Glass Palace projected a bizarre and incandescent majesty found nowhere else on the continent. Constructed of interlocking blocks of crimson obsidian hoisted from volcanic vents and transparent heat-resistant sorcery glass, the corridors hovered directly above bubbling conduits of molten magma. The air was a suffocating cocktail of acrid sulfur and sweet crushed rose perfume, scorching the lungs with every intake of breath, while through the crimson glass floor panels, the silhouettes of subterranean torture cells and labor mines flickered like blood-red phantoms.

High Minister Lucian had convened a grand nocturnal masquerade under the pretext of celebrating the southern campaign. While courtiers adorned in silken robes and glittering gemstones clinked crystal chalices of pomegranate wine with frivolous laughter, Kadan and Cilia slipped past the palace guards disguised among the traveling musicians and banquet attendants. Their objective was to unearth the whereabouts of Balian and the suppressed records of the Arcane Holy Knights.

At the center of the hall, an open circular arena burst into incandescent flames to the roaring cheers of noble spectators. Eighteen-year-old Ignis, commander of the White Flame Order and idolized as the kingdom's youthful champion, was undergoing the ritual Trial of Embers. Clad in ornate white-silver plate, Ignis swung his longsword with immaculate precision, releasing arcs of pure white sanctifying fire that incinerated training beasts into drifting gray ash within single heartbeats.

Nobles rose to their feet in frantic adulation.

> "Behold! The pure white fire inherited from Lord Balian himself! The most immaculate blade of the crown stands before us!"

Yet amidst the thunderous acclaim, Ignis's youthful visage remained frozen like carved marble. In his amber eyes gleamed neither pride nor triumph, but a hollow, gnawing desolation.

Seated upon the gilded dais, Lucian raised his golden goblet, a venomous smile curving his lips.

> "Magnificent, Ignis. That immaculate blaze upon your blade is the eternal aegis of our crown. Yet true loyalty is proven not by the edge of a sword, but through absolute submission."

At Lucian's gesture, heavy iron winches groaned as a massive slab of red glass in the amphitheater floor slid open. The grim reality of the subterranean dungeon below was laid bare before the court. Suspended over roaring sulfur vents in heavy runic chains was the withered warrior, Lord Balian. His shoulders and bare back were an agonizing canvas of charred lacerations and necrotic brands inflicted by relentless inquisitions.

The tip of Ignis's longsword quivered almost imperceptibly.

"Lord Minister, my father has already been stripped of his knightly mana and reduced to a crippled shell. Why must you subject him to such wanton degradation?"

Lucian leaned forward, whispering with icy satisfaction.

"Until Balian surrenders the ancient Throne Seal of the Holy Order, his agony will find no reprieve. If you fancy yourself a dutiful son, convince the stubborn old hound to speak."

Witnessing this horrific spectacle from the shadow of the gallery colonnade, a tidal wave of fury surged through Kadan's veins. This was Lord Balian—the sworn blood-brother of Master Aleksandar whom he had revered in his mother's bedtime songs—paraded like a broken cur before laughing aristocrats. As Kadan gripped his blade pommel to charge the arena, Cilia's slender fingers clamped around his forearm with iron tenacity.

She hissed urgently into his ear.

"Hold, Kadan! Charging blindly will only trigger Lucian's perimeter wards and see you slaughtered without purpose. I have already memorized the draft patterns of the exhaust shafts. We must wait until the feast winds down and the embers die."

Biting his lip until crimson welled upon his chin, Kadan lowered his shield. Within his clear eyes, the dancing fire of the Red Palace reflected like keen blades.

As the revelry waned into midnight, the two made their way toward a sequestered garden behind the palace. In the midst of the manicured palace grounds stood a solitary, rustic thatched cottage—a jarring anomaly entirely at odds with the court's flamboyant extravagance. Encircled by thorny crimson briar wards and heavily barred windows, a lone woman could be seen steadily turning a weathered wooden spindle, spinning raw flax into rough thread. It was Issela, mother of Ignis and long-lost wife to Lord Balian.

Her hazel eyes were clouded and vacant, bound beneath layers of imperial forgetting curses. Upon her rough-hewn table rested two clay teacups, set out every evening for eighteen long years

without her ever recalling whom she awaited. Every evening, she brewed tea that grew cold untouched.

Gathering gentle emerald drafts of wind to deflect the sensory runes surrounding the garden, Cilia whispered.

"Her mind is ensnared within Medusa Gorgo's necrotic amnesia hexes. I shall untangle the magical knots with wind runes, but you must provide the emotional anchor of memory, Kadan."

Stepping softly into the room, Kadan unfastened the silver dagger from his sash, laying it gently upon the wooden table.

"Aunt Issela, do you remember the hamlet of Elwin in the northern reaches? Do you recall the vow sworn beneath the howling blizzard between Uncle Balian and my father, Aleksandar?"

As the names of Balian and Aleksandar resonated through the small chamber, ripples of azure light blossomed from Cilia's fingertips, bathing Issela's brow. With a resonant chime like snapping glass, the suffocating shadow binding her soul dissolved.

Clarity returned to Issela's eyes. Gazing upon the silver dagger and Kadan's earnest countenance, she clutched trembling hands to her lips.

"Ah... Balian... My husband... And my sweet infant torn from my arms in the raging snow...!"

Eighteen years of suppressed agony and maternal yearning burst forth in a torrential cascade of tears. Issela remembered everything: the storm, the ambush, and the ruthless smile of Lucian as her babe was dragged away.

"My precious babe... called my name as he was dragged off in Lucian's cold iron grasp. Every night his cries echoed in my ears, yet under this dark curse I could not even recall whose child wept..."

Kadan clasped her weathered hands in his own, speaking with steady conviction.

"Ignis lives, Aunt Issela. Though deceived by the court's falsehoods and bearing steel against us now, noble blood still flows within his heart. I swear to bring him back to your side."

Suddenly, the cottage doors were violently splintered as Lucian strode over the threshold, flanked by the elite Flame Guard.

A grotesque sneer twisted Lucian's lips as he raised his gilded scepter.

"Rats scurrying in the royal garden. Splendid, Issela. Now that your memories have returned, your value has doubled. Let Balian hear the weeping agony of his beloved wife, and that stubborn hound shall finally surrender the Throne Seal!"

The guards leveled their flaming lances, charging across the floorboards. Without hesitation, Kadan planted his iron shield, projecting the earthen bulwark taught by his masters. With a deafening boom, the flame spears shattered against the shield's surface.

Cilia swept her wind staff high.

"Gale barrier, clear our path!"

A violent tempest erupted within the chamber, hurling stools, earthenware pots, and flax into the guards' faces. Seizing the opening, Kadan hoisted Issela onto his back and broke through the rear timber wall into the garden shadows.

Leaping onto the marble parapets of the upper colonnade, Kadan's gaze locked with a figure standing high on an opposite balcony. It was Ignis, bathed in moonlight. For the first time, Ignis looked upon the tear-streaked face of his mother fleeing below. Beholding the striking resemblance in her eyes, the immaculate blade in Ignis's gauntlet trembled visibly.

"Mother...? Could that woman... be my true mother?"

Ignis's bewildered murmur drifted upon the night wind.

Evading the palace hounds through the subterranean sluiceways, Kadan and Cilia led Issela safely beyond the city walls. Reaching a forest hideout beyond the perimeter, Paladin Walker and the Six Masters stepped forward to welcome them. Upon the windswept hills beneath the starry canopy, Issela took Kadan's hands, her voice choked with emotion.

"Kadan... Save my son Ignis. The boy bears no malice... His soul is merely ensnared within the devil's cruel design."

Kadan tightened his grip upon her weathered hands, looking up toward the constant North Star.

"I swear it, Aunt Issela. I shall break Uncle Balian's chains, and bring Ignis home to your embrace."

Dawn broke over the eastern horizon, scattering the lingering night. Within the breasts of the young heroes, the sacred flame of hope burned brighter than any darkness. Beyond the eastern horizon, a radiant crimson sun arose, illuminating the road of renewed purpose.

CHAPTER 11

Episode 11 · The Dagger That Wakes Memory

Part 1 · Episode 11 of 40

Subterranean Labor Prison No. 7, wherein Paladin Balian was held captive, sprawled like a venomous spider's web beneath the deepest vaults of the Red Glass Court, intersecting with the abandoned shafts of an ancient volcanic mine. Scalding crimson torrents of bubbling magma coursed through subterranean aqueducts, filling the subterranean cavern with suffocating heat, while dense billows of sulfur smoke coiled along obsidian rock faces, searing the lungs with every drawn breath. Thousands of emaciated prisoners interned in this subterranean abyss bore no names, answered only to blunt serial numerals stamped upon heavy iron collars, and swung rusted pickaxes from dawn to dusk to unearth crimson firestones, gradually stripped of every sacred memory of their mortal lives.

Princess Cilia positioned the tip of her jade staff against the cavern floor, gauging the cool ripples of subterranean drafts to calibrate the ventilation cycle of the subterranean drainage corridors with absolute precision.

"The sentry rotation interval lasts precisely three hundred heartbeats," Cilia whispered, her emerald eyes narrowing against the haze. "If we catch the reverse updraft when the massive pressure flue unseals, we can bypass the runic lenses of the central watchtower without sounding an alarm."

Kadan regulated his breathing in harmony with Cilia's signal, drawing upon the celestial cadence of star-breathing. Channeled through the circular rim of the boy's iron shield, a cascade of frost mana surged across the boiling magma aqueduct, freezing the churning lava beneath a thick, glittering span of silver ice in the span of a single heartbeat.

Reaching the deepest, darkest rock face of the subterranean excavation pit, their eyes fell upon a white-haired veteran leaning heavily upon an injured leg. His countenance had been ravaged by years of cruel interrogation and scorched by searing flames, yet the calloused knuckles gripping a fractured iron spear shaft remained as unyielding as tempered steel. The instant the old knight caught sight of the Silver Dagger sheathed at Kadan's belt, the heavy iron pickaxe slipped from his trembling grasp, clattering sharply against the stone floor.

"That blade... is that not my elder brother Aleksandar's blade...?"

The veteran's raspy, cracked voice caused the damp cavern walls to shudder. Even amidst the despair of this subterranean tomb, Balian had been covertly teaching his fellow captives how to read and write. Using a sharpened steel chisel, he had carved the passing dates and the names of those unjustly slaughtered into the stubborn firestone rock faces. Preserving mortal memory was the singular, sublime act of defiance remaining in this living inferno. In a secluded crevice of the stone wall, Kadan discovered his father Aleksandar's name, meticulously re-carved each day for eighteen long years as the old paladin swallowed his silent tears.

"Uncle... I am Kadan, son of Aleksandar."

As Kadan sank to one knee, Balian reached out a weathered hand to cradle the boy's cheek with rough tenderness. Balian had not perished beneath the blizzard-swept bridge chasm eighteen winters ago. Captured downriver by the court's vanguard, he had concealed his noble lineage and endured endless humiliation solely to uncover the fate of his abducted wife, Isella, and their newborn son. High Chancellor Lucian had long known the old knight's identity yet deliberately spared his life, nursing a cruel ambition to have the grown son, Ignis, execute his own father with his own hands, thus shattering the proud spirit of the holy paladins forever.

As the companions retreated along the narrow drainage corridor, an imposing silhouette blocked their vanguard. Clad in immaculate silver plate armor and drawing a broadsword wrapped in incandescent white flame, Ignis fixed them with a gaze as frigid as winter ice.

"Where do you think you are fleeing, vile convicts who dare defile the imperial vaults?"

Rather than raising his weapon, Kadan reached into his tunic, retrieved Lady Elwin's final missive and secret ledger, and tossed them deliberately at Ignis's polished boots.

"Sheathe your steel and look upon the truth, Ignis! The man standing before your eyes is your true father, Duke Balian!"

At that moment, Balian stepped into the vanguard, clutching his fractured spear shaft. As Ignis surged forward with his incandescent blade trailing roaring white flames, Balian feigned a retreat, then flicked the spearhead upward with blinding speed, deflecting the lethal trajectory of the blade. It was the ancestral spear art of the Balian bloodline, a guarded defensive secret transmitted solely among fathers and sons of the ducal house.

Clang!

The color drained from Ignis's face in an instant. It was the precise trajectory of spear combat that his father had demonstrated in his recurring childhood dreams, over and over, while cradling him

in strong arms. The very movements his bones and muscles remembered had been dismissed as mere drills taught by the imperial palace instructors, a deception he had whispered to himself to survive.

Balian tapped the young commander's spearhead once more to disrupt his balance, then reached out with practiced ease to correct the youth's grip on the hilt.

"If you raise your thumb in that posture, the backdraft will scorch the tendons of your wrist, my child."

The father's chastising tone was so instinctive and warm that Ignis reflexively shifted his fingers, as if he were once again a small boy kneeling in his father's courtyard. Realizing what he had done, the young commander recoiled violently, slapping the spear aside in frantic denial.

"Lies... this man is nothing more than a condemned felon! The cunning tongue and petty tricks of a prisoner cannot prove noble blood!"

Kadan set his shield firmly between them, his voice cutting through the cavern like a clarion bell.

"Then verify the truth with your own eyes! Before you swing your sacred flame in blind obedience, ask your own heart what truth it whispers!"

A cacophony of emergency bells suddenly resonated through the cavern ceiling. Balian thrust Ignis behind a protective buttress of stone and wrenched open the iron portcullis of the secret escape flue, keeping his spearhead reversed to ensure he would never harm his flesh and blood. Ignis did not give chase, nor could he find the will to step forward with them. The young warrior stood motionless between the iron bars, gazing blankly into the gloomy corridor down which his father had vanished.

Emerging onto the surface under the cover of night, Kadan and his party were met by the Six Masters waiting anxiously in the mountain sanctuary. The masters were infuriated that Kadan had recklessly infiltrated the imperial undercroft without council, and their shock only deepened upon discovering that Cilia was the sole daughter of Sovereign Aeolus of Whispering Wind Island. Grimli the dwarf bared his teeth, refusing to trust an elven princess from the eastern archipelago.

"We cannot trust those islanders! Was it not Medusa Gorgo, an apprentice cast out from that cursed isle, who murdered our sworn brother Robinyard in cold blood?"

Before Grimli's roar faded, a heavy iron chain whipped out from the black mist like a viper. It was an ambush by Medusa Gorgo herself. Having forged an unholy pact with Lucian, she had laid in wait to claim Balian's life in exchange for the missing half of the Nine Shadows Codex.

As the silver chain whip lashed toward the unguarded Cilia, Kadan threw himself forward, intercepting the strike with his iron shield. Twisting along the taut chain, Gorgo's obsidian claws clamped down viciously upon Kadan's throat.

"Murderers who slaughtered my Belphegor in cold blood!"

Though suffocating beneath her grip, Kadan held Gorgo's manic gaze with unblinking clarity.

"A lie... in the raging rapids of Mistfall Cliff, your husband Belphegor saved my life at the cost of his own before sinking into the abyss!"

Gorgo's clawed fingers wavered for a fraction of a heartbeat. Seizing that fleeting opening, Gawain's iron staff struck like thunder, coiling around the chain whip, while Grimli and Rondol surged forward to haul Kadan clear of the witch's reach.

Amidst the fierce skirmish, the crisp chimes of six silver bells rang out simultaneously in Gorgo's ears. They were the silver bells of the pursuers, forged from the keepsakes of fallen Robinyard. A witch's vengeance for a lost husband collided brutally with hunters' grief for a murdered brother in the pitch-black night. Because neither side could acknowledge the sorrow of the other, the clash raged with merciless fury.

It was the aging Paladin Balian who brought an end to the madness. Balian slammed his heavy spear shaft into the cracked flagstones of the ruined shrine, splitting the ground between the opposing forces with a resonant boom.

"Cease this madness! Today is not the day for innocent children to inherit the bloodstained vendettas of their fathers!"

Beneath the collapsed floor, a long-forgotten subterranean tunnel opened its maw. For eighteen winters, Balian had declined countless opportunities to flee alone, laboring with his bare hands to expand this passage so every captive might one day escape to freedom. The companions lowered their weapons, joining hands to lead the suffering mine prisoners up toward the open air.

Medusa Gorgo melted back into the clinging mists, casting a venomous smirk toward Cilia.

"Do you know how many disciples Sovereign Aeolus discarded like refuse to guard the secrets of his coveted codex, Cilia? You shall never wash the blood of your master's sins from your hands."

Cilia offered no retort. It was that very suffocating hypocrisy that had driven her to abandon her arrogant father and wander the continent in beggar's rags.

At dawn's first light, Kadan and his companions reached an abandoned ancient sanctuary beyond the capital's perimeter. When Balian and Isella finally stood before one another, neither could move to embrace. The weight of eighteen stolen years was so crushing that they could only weep in silence, their weathered hands hovering in hesitation before intertwining. Kadan quietly shut the weathered timber doors of the shrine, holding the polished steel of his Silver Dagger toward the rising sun as its brilliance scattered the lingering shadows of the night.

CHAPTER 12

Episode 12 · Spring Between Two Graves

Part 1 · Episode 12 of 40

Deep within the ancient oak groves encircling the outer boundaries of the capital, Lighthaven, the forgotten sanctuary of the Arcane Holy Knights lay steeped in heavy silence. Coiling around the fallen columns of the white marble cloister, deep emerald moss and mistletoe tangled like weathered webs, while through fissures in the fractured altar, melting winter snowdrifts dripped with clear, rhythmic drops. Woodland thrushes chirped softly in the twilight mist of early dawn, yet the atmosphere within the flagstone courtyard remained cold and tense as winter ice.

The aged Paladin Balian rested against a crumbling stone wall within the nave, breathing in shallow, labored gasps. The deep wounds sustained while escaping the sulfur fires of the Seventh Labor Camp burned with fever, and the necrotic venom of Medusa Gorgo spread like blackened veins across the scarred expanse of his chest. Parched and pale as ash, the veteran's lips trembled as involuntary tremors passed through his calloused fingers. As cold drafts brushed the stone floor, Balian coughed up dark blood, pressing a hand to his wound.

With trembling hands, Issela blended crushed comfrey leaves with the cooling sap of the Moonlit Herb brought by Kadan from the imperial apothecary, gently applying the poultice over the blackened lacerations upon her husband's breast. Whiffs of pale steam rose as the cooling herbs touched the fevered flesh.

> "Bear it just a little longer, Balian. The medicine Kadan secured will soon extinguish the fever in your blood. You must live... to hold our boy, our Ignis, in your arms once more."

Balian reached out with a scarred, calloused hand to brush away the tears gathering upon his wife's cheeks, a faint, weary smile touching his lips.

> "Issela... my mortal shell was largely consumed under the inquisitors' fires in the mines. Yet now that you have reclaimed your true memories and sit beside me, the hellish eighteen years of isolation dissolve like spring snow upon the hearth."

That fragile peace was shattered all too soon. Through the oak groves beyond the perimeter walls came the rhythmic thunder of iron-shod hooves and the unmistakable chill of unsheathed steel. High Minister Lucian had arrived, commanding over a hundred elite flame guardsmen to encircle the sanctuary in an iron perimeter. Draped in a mantle of rich crimson silk, Lucian swirled a

chalice of silver wine atop his black charger, bellowing in mocking amusement. Behind him, crimson flame wards flared to seal every retreat path.

Lucian's venomous laughter echoed along the sanctuary walls.

"Lord Balian! What a pathetic spectacle, wheezing like a cornered cur among shattered masonry! Surrender Issela and deliver the Throne Seal of the Holy Order, and I might grant you an untroubled demise without further agony!"

At the foot of the narrow stone stairs guarding the entrance, Paladin Walker and Hercul planted two colossal steel tower shields side by side, barring the gateway. Behind them, the Six Masters—Grimli the dwarven smith, Gawain the wind-blade, Eyla the huntress, Kaze the shadow-blade, Rondol the pugilist, and Eliana the herbalist—drew their weapons with grim resolve, forming an unyielding line.

Grimli slammed his massive iron anvil hammer against the stone flagstones, his voice echoing like rolling thunder.

"The bloated curs of the court bark loud when backed by iron! If you wish to set your corrupt boots upon holy ground, prepare to have your skulls cracked over my anvil!"

With a cold gesture from Lucian, the flame lancers leveled their weapons and charged up the stairway in a roaring tide of fire and steel. The ascent became a slaughterhouse of clashing metal and concussive shockwaves. Shattered marble fragments flew as spells detonated, sulfur smoke choking the air. While Walker's azure barrier and Hercul's golden aegis deflected the incoming tempest of flaming quarrels, Cilia swept her teal staff, weaving a protective draft to open a retreat path through the northern defile.

Cilia turned toward Kadan, her voice urgent.

"We must escort the refugees and Lady Issela into the northern gorge! The wind corridor will collapse within ten minutes before the flame circle closes!"

Kadan nodded firmly, remembering the fundamental defensive lessons of Master Aleksandar as he leaped into the center of the stairs. Angling his iron shield to deflect the kinetic momentum of charging lancers into empty air, Kadan snapped spear-shafts with the razor edge of his silver dagger. The youthful warrior's grounded stance was an immovable wall against the imperial host. As charging spearheads glanced off the curved rim, flying sparks lit the unwavering resolve in his eyes.

An imperial officer swung his broadsword furiously against Kadan's guard.

"A vagrant pup dares block the imperial vanguard? I shall cleave your shield in two!"

Breathing through the star rhythm, Kadan pivoted his shield, burying the blade's force into the earth.

"So long as I have people to protect, this shield shall never yield before any flame."

In the courtyard behind them, Balian rose to his feet with Issela's support, stumbling toward an ancient stone cenotaph. It was the empty grave of his sworn brother, Aleksandar, who had fallen eighteen winters ago in Elwin. Weathered by wind and frost, the headstone bore Aleksandar's name and the faded cross emblem of the Holy Order, surrounded by withered stems of wild chrysanthemums sleeping beneath the snow.

With trembling hands, Balian poured sacred water over the lichen-crusted stone, pressing his forehead against the cold granite.

"Brother... As we swore beneath the snow, our sons have grown into stalwart men. Now I shall pass the last remaining embers of my soul to them, and journey to your side."

Drawing an ancient silver dagger inscribed with the vows of the Holy Knights from his breast, Balian pressed the hilt into Kadan's calloused palm. Kadan met the veteran's eyes with solemn depth.

"Uncle, the flame you have guarded shall never be extinguished. I swear to deliver Ignis from the shadows and restore peace to this continent."

Hidden within the deep gloom of the tree line, a solitary warrior watched the scene in breathless silence. It was High Commander Ignis of the White Flame Order. With his own eyes, Ignis beheld the heartfelt tears of his mother Issela, and the sacrificial dignity of his father Balian kneeling in prayer before Aleksandar's cenotaph. Realizing that the entire foundation of justice taught to him in the capital was a fabricated lie, turbulent agony and sorrow tore through Ignis's golden gaze.

Ignis could not bring himself to draw steel, clutching his breastplate as he murmured into the wind.

"Father... Mother... What then was the truth behind the laws of the throne... Was the righteousness I upheld nothing more than a hollow illusion..."

Through the desperate valor of Kadan and the Six Masters, the companions breached the mountain corridor leading toward the eastern coastline. Gawain's gale blinded the pursuit, and

Grimli's hammer triggered a rockslide, blocking the gorge. Battered by fierce resistance and hindered by the craggy slopes, Lucian's legions broke off pursuit and fell back toward the citadel.

As they emerged from the blood-stained snowdrifts into the valley, Kadan looked down to see a tiny white flower pushing through the frozen shale. It was the first snowdrop of the season. Overcoming the deep scars of winter, the earth was finally drawing its first breath of spring. A gentle breeze brushed their brows, and the steps of the young wanderers were infused with renewed hope.

Cilia looked upon the snowdrop with a tender smile.

"No matter how bitter the winter, spring arrives without fail."

Kadan sheathed his silver dagger, nodding quietly.

"Our path ahead shall be no different. Let us cross the waves to Whispering Wind Island."

Behind them, the rising sun bathed the mountains in warm gold, illuminating their journey toward the sea.

CHAPTER 13

Episode 13 · Master of the Jade Staff

Part 1 · Episode 13 of 40

The rugged cedar forest track winding through the coastal mountains toward the eastern sea was soaked with several days of persistent early spring rain. Dense ocean mist drifted through the towering evergreen canopy, and from the damp soil and lichen-crusted boulders rose the sharp, earthy scents of decomposing pine needles and moss. In the muffled stillness where even woodland birds fell quiet in the fog, Kadan and Cilia pressed forward toward Cloud Return Manor—the primary haven on the eastern coast and the staging point for the voyage to Whispering Wind Island. Along the verges, thawing brooks chuckled over polished pebbles, while wild mountain violets peeked through rock fissures.

Cilia extended her hand, feeling the coastal thermal drafts with her fingertips.

"The winds rolling off the sea grow increasingly turbulent. It is unmistakable proof that the barrier spires of Whispering Wind Island are fracturing, unsettling the mana balance of the coastline."

Kadan tightened his grip upon his iron shield, nodding.

"The runic devices we observed under Lucian's command in the capital were unnatural. Corrupt men seeking power are tearing the fabric of the earth."

As they crested a steep granite ridge, the scent of sizzling animal fat and the sweet woodsmoke of birch logs drifted upon the breeze.

Kadan checked his stride, shifting his shield into a ready guard.

"There is someone near. A heavy, unrefined pulse of mana radiates from beyond that clearing."

Cilia inhaled the smoke, giving a delicate sniff of disdain.

"Wild boar fat. And an utterly incompetent cook who is incinerating the exterior to charcoal. The burnt grease fills this entire mountain hollow."

In a sheltered hollow beyond the outcrop lay a massive, broad-shouldered warrior with a mane of disheveled white hair and a wild beard, snoring with the volume of rolling thunder beside a crackling fire. It was none other than General Leonar, formerly the fiercest warlord of the imperial

vanguard, now living in eccentric retirement. Propped beneath his head like a rough timber pillow was the legendary Jade Staff, its translucent emerald gemstone pulsing with rhythmic ripples of sea-green luminescence. Over the flames, a heavy haunch of boar skewered upon an oak branch was charred into black carbon on the outside, while raw crimson blood dripped steadily from the uncooked center.

Cilia clicked her tongue in dismay, rolling up her sleeves as she approached the pit.

"Sacrificing such magnificent forest game to charcoal! Stand aside, old bear!"

Reaching into her herb satchel, Cilia produced dried juniper berries and wild mountain thyme, rubbing them vigorously across the meat. Conjuring a gentle vortex of warm air with her fingers, she circulated the fire's radiant heat deep into the core of the haunch. As the blackened crust flaked away and savory, amber juices sizzled against the embers, Leonar's nostrils twitched, and he sat bolt upright with a thunderous snort.

Wiping a line of drool from his gray mustache, the veteran glared with sharp, amused eyes.

"Ho! What insolent slip of a girl and her northern wood-hewn pup dare meddle with my dinner!"

Despite his bluster, Leonar snatched the savory slice of roasted pork offered upon Cilia's blade, popping it greedily into his maw. The instant his teeth sank through the crisp skin into the tender meat, his eyes widened like lanterns.

"By the gods! Crisp as winter frost outside and melting like fresh cream within! The subtle juniper cuts the grease like an imperial banquet wine!"

Devouring half the haunch in a dozen bites, Leonar reached down, hoisting the heavy Jade Staff with effortless ease. The giant emerald at its head hummed in deep resonance, sending a heavy emerald shockwave shuddering through the surrounding cedars.

The veteran's jovial expression hardened into the razor-sharp focus of a seasoned general.

"A warrior must earn his supper. Boy, raise that battered lid upon your arm. Let us see if those northern shoulders can endure the weight of the earth!"

Leonar unleashed his first technique, 'Earth Dragon Sundering.' Stamping the staff against the flagstones, the earth surged forward in concussive waves. Unfazed, Kadan angled his shield low, skimming across the seismic shock. In an instant, the Jade Staff spun like a dragon's tail, driving toward Kadan's ribs. With a resounding clash, Kadan rotated his footing, dispersing the centrifugal impact into the air.

Leaping high, Leonar brought down the staff in the crushing arc of 'Heaven Fall.' Though a straightforward downward strike, it carried the terrifying momentum of a collapsing mountain peak. Without hesitation, Kadan angled his iron shield at forty-five degrees, riding the rhythm of star-breathing. With a deafening boom, the strike glanced off the curved rim into empty space. The stone beneath Kadan's boots fractured in spiderweb fissures, yet his upper body remained unyielding.

Leonar burst into a roaring belly laugh, resting the staff across his broad shoulders.

"Splendid! To turn aside brute force along the natural grain rather than meeting it head-on... You bear the steadfast aegis of the Holy Order and the fluid grace of the Wind Isle in a single vessel. Had Brother Aleksandar lived to witness this, he would have emptied his flagon in roaring joy."

Lowering his shield, Kadan bowed with respect.

"Your praise is generous, General. The path of your staff was as honest and imposing as the mountain ridges."

Reaching into his leather tunic, Leonar withdrew a thick strip of cured venison jerky, hurling it toward the shadows of the boulders beyond the firelight.

"None who lurk in the bushes are without hunger! Step forth and eat, gilded pup of the White Flame!"

Silhouetted against the dark pines, Ignis stepped into the firelight, his white cloak spattered with woodland mud. Though his aristocratic pride flared, three days of wandering without rations compelled him to retrieve the dropped meat from the pine needles.

Ignis spoke with a trembling, heavy rasp.

"In the capital I was hailed as an immaculate champion, yet I was merely a puppet dancing on Lucian's strings. Lord Balian is my true father, and my mother was the captive woman spinning flax in that cold garden for eighteen winters... What have I been wielding my sword for all this time?"

Gazing upon the dancing sparks of the hearth, Kadan replied softly.

"Do not condemn yourself, Ignis. The white flame on your blade belongs not to Lucian, but is the noble soul bequeathed by your father. In choosing to confront the truth rather than flee from it, you have already set foot upon the true path of a knight."

Ignis lowered his head, fingers tightening upon his hilt.

"Kadan... Why do you bear no hatred toward me? It was my blade that lacerated your shoulder in the forum."

Touching the crimson ribbon bound to his silver dagger, Kadan offered a calm smile.

"A wound of the flesh mends with time, but a soul trapped in falsehood rots for eternity. I came south not to claim vengeance, but to mend the shattered vow."

Leonar looked between the three youths with a warm, approving smile.

"Thirty winters ago, Whispering Wind Island was a sanctuary of boundless wisdom. Yet Council elders seduced by the Nine Shadow Codex seized the defense spires, and Lord Aeolus wept as he sealed the barrier to protect his daughter Cilia. That betrayal ignited the continental war. The guardian Rondol lost his leg resisting that coup, choosing exile upon Mist Lake."

Tears glistened in Cilia's eyes.

"Uncle Rondol... guarded the waters all these years without holding malice toward father?"

Leonar planted his Jade Staff with a resonant thud.

"Indeed, lass. The truly loyal bear their burdens in silence. Let us march; we have an old boatman's flagon to fill at Cloud Return Manor!"

Thus began the strange fellowship of three young champions and a legendary veteran amidst the ocean gales. Chilly drafts swept the slopes toward Mist Lake, yet their hearthfire burned bright into the twilight. Beyond the morning fog, the colossal basalt pillars of the lake were slowly emerging into view.

CHAPTER 14

Episode 14 · Guests of the Mist Lake

Part 1 · Episode 14 of 40

Sprawling across the threshold of the eastern seaboard, Mist Lake remained cloaked year-round in a dense, milky-white water fog, a mystical realm that rarely permitted casual travelers to cross its expanse. Rising from the tranquil waters were seventy-two colossal basalt monoliths, standing like silent, primordial giants, while beneath the crystal emerald depths, the sunken palace spires and fractured arched stone bridges of an ancient drowned realm flickered like spectral phantoms even on bright days. In this serene stillness where not even a lone waterbird cried, Kadan and Cilia followed General Leonar's measured guidance, advancing with cautious steps toward Cloud Return Manor—a massive floating sanctuary resting at the heart of the lake. Whenever chilled breezes swept through the damp reed beds, white cotton fluff from blooming cattails drifted through the mist like lingering snowflakes. Lush emerald moss carpeted the rock crevices like rich velvet, and the trailing branches of weeping willows traced delicate ripples across the glass-like water.

Extending her hand above the water, Cilia read the intricate currents of the drifting fog with a thoughtful murmur.

"The submerged bell towers beneath the floor are releasing faint, rhythmic pulses of mana. The ancient water spirits are still slumbering down below."

Kadan halted at the shoreline, gazing downward through the clear, green depths.

"What are those monumental stone complexes resting beneath the lake bed? It appears as though an entire imperial metropolis was swallowed whole."

Resting his Jade Staff against a mossy boulder, Leonar explained in his gravelly, booming timbre.

"A thousand years ago, this was the heart of Aquaria, the glorious capital of an ancient water-magic civilization. When the forbidden mana within the Nine Shadows Codex spiraled out of control, the entire realm sank into the abyss in a single night. Those seventy-two basalt monoliths we must navigate were once the immense pillars supporting the imperial palaces."

Reaching the weathered timber landing of the lakeside ferry, Cilia plucked a tender reed leaf from the water's edge, bringing it to her lips to play a tranquil wind lullaby. As the clear, melancholic melody echoed across the fog-draped surface, the steady creak of a solitary oar drifted through the

murk, and a small wooden skiff emerged into view. Rowing upon the deck stood a weathered old boatman with an iron prosthetic leg in place of his left limb. It was Rondol, the legendary guardian and master navigator who had once protected the outer shores of Whispering Wind Island.

Rondol's piercing gaze rested upon Cilia's face and her elegant teal tunic. His voice was dry and raspy, carrying the chill of the morning mist.

"So you have returned at last, headstrong princess who fled the island. The elders brand you a traitor and curse your name to the tides. By what brazen courage do you dare tread upon this sea once more?"

Meeting Rondol's stern eyes without flinching, Cilia spoke with resolute conviction.

"It was the cowardly elders who chose to seal the gates, burying the monstrous truth behind my mother Sylphid's demise. I did not flee; I departed to honor my mother's spirit and illuminate that darkness, Uncle Rondol. Were you not also cast out, losing your leg when you dared defy that very council?"

Kadan stepped forward, lifting his unadorned iron shield in respectful greeting.

"I recognize the wind rune inscribed upon your iron limb. Master Aleksandar always spoke with profound respect of your unwavering loyalty. Please grant us passage to the manor."

Rondol studied Kadan's grounded shoulders and Cilia's unyielding gaze in prolonged silence before letting out a soft sigh and tapping his oar against the gunwale.

"Step aboard. Your stubborn defiance is the spitting image of your mother Sylphid, and this youth beside you possesses the honest eyes of a northern wolf."

Navigating deftly through the labyrinth of the seventy-two towering monoliths, the skiff arrived at last before Cloud Return Manor. Erected upon hundreds of colossal oak pilings driven deep into the lake floor, the timber compound served as a warm haven for war refugees, displaced orphans, and wounded coastal fishermen. The mouthwatering aroma of fat lake carp steamed with wild mountain ginger and forest greens drifted from the timber verandas, accompanied by the bright laughter of children playing along the railings. On one side of the jetty, an elderly dwarven blacksmith hammered away at a small forge, repairing broken harpoons and iron-weighted nets.

As the manor folk approached with welcoming smiles, offering mugs of steaming roasted barley tea, Kadan observed the ancient defensive arrays intricately carved into the walls of the central gallery. It was far more than ornamental art; it was a sophisticated kinetic distribution matrix designed to absorb hostile impacts and diffuse the force through the immense water pressure of

the lake. The tactical philosophy mirrored the profound defensive principles taught by Uncle Balian.

Pointing to the carvings, Kadan asked Rondol in quiet admiration.

"This ward configuration shares an extraordinary resemblance with the Earth Cushioning Array of the northern Holy Knights. Did these two traditions spring from a common foundation?"

Rondol took a deep draught of cloud wine from an earthen bowl and nodded with a grin.

"You have a keen eye, lad. A century ago, Lord Balian's ancestral forebears and the master artisans of Whispering Wind Island collaborated to forge this very matrix. A shield is never merely a wall of metal; it is a gateway that redirects violence back into the gentle embrace of earth and sea."

Offering Kadan a warm slice of fresh barley bread, Cilia smiled softly.

"Fresh lake game is something you never tasted on the frozen tundras of the north. Eat heartily, Kadan."

Suddenly, the water erupted into violent whirlpools, and the manor's alarm bell clanged frantically into the mist. Three immense abyssal sea-drakes, their serpent scales tainted by Medusa Gorgo's necrotic miasma, rammed savagely into the supporting timber pylons. The massive oak timbers fractured with groaning tears, tilting the lower pier at an alarming angle. Corrosive crimson acid sprayed from between the drakes' venomous fangs, hissing as it ate through the wooden planks while panicked refugees scattered in terror.

Stamping his iron pegleg onto the deck, Rondol summoned a swirling vortex across the surface, while Cilia leaped into the air, unleashing a gale of razor-sharp wind arrows. Kadan dashed to the fractured edge of the pier, slamming his iron shield against the timbers to crystallize a wide, shimmering frost bridge across the churning waters.

"Everyone cross the frost bridge into the inner hall! Protect the children first!"

While the terrified families scrambled across the ice to safety, Ignis emerged through the pouring rain onto the lower deck, drawing his longsword with a grim roar.

"Vile abominations who dare prey upon the helpless!"

A searing ribbon of immaculate white flame cleaved through the gloom, decapitating the lead sea-drake in a single blinding stroke. The divine fire incinerated the necrotic venom, sending plumes of pure white steam billowing into the rain. For the first time, water and fire, frost and wind

moved in flawless tactical harmony, shattering the assault and saving the sanctuary from devastation.

As the remaining serpents sank dead into the lake bed and the disturbed waters smoothed into glass, only ragged breathing echoed along the sodden jetty. Soaked to the skin, Ignis breathed heavily as he wiped the blackened ichor from his longsword, letting the rain wash the steel clean.

Rondol limped over, carrying a coarse linen towel and a steaming bowl of hot carp broth, holding them out to the imperial commander in silence.

"Not half bad for a gilded palace pup. Dry yourself off and drink down this broth before your bones take a chill."

Ignis stared at the earthen bowl in stunned bewilderment, his lips tightening with residual arrogance.

"I am a knight commander of the imperial court. I have no need for the charity of common fishermen."

Rondol barked a hearty laugh, slapping the young noble's shoulder with rough camaraderie.

"When one person passes a warm bowl of soup to another, what does rank matter? Drink it down, lad; cold broth tastes like swamp water."

Kadan stoked the nearby brazier with the tip of his silver dagger, tossing on dry birch logs to coax up a roaring flame.

"Come sit by the fire and dry your mantle, Ignis. Come sunrise, we must venture out onto the perilous high seas together."

Biting his lip, Ignis took the bowl with trembling fingers and drank. As the rich, ginger-scented warmth spread down his throat, the stiff tension in his shoulders finally melted away. Above the floating harbor, the dark storm clouds parted, unveiling a canopy of distant stars that mirrored across the lake like scattering silver scales. The true warmth Uncle Balian had sacrificed his life to defend lingered right here upon this humble wooden pier. In this quiet night where scarred wanderers tended to one another's burdens, the silence of the lake felt deeper and infinitely kinder.

CHAPTER 15

Episode 15 · Night of the Vipers and the Lion

Part 1 · Episode 15 of 40

As midnight deepened, the waves across Mist Lake grew increasingly tumultuous. Violent nocturnal gales sweeping down from the eastern mountain crags battered the cedar shingles of Cloud Return Manor without mercy, while torrents of heavy rain churned the dark waters into foam. Within the manor's great central hearth, logs of seasoned oak crackled and cast fluttering orange flames across the hall, yet the uncanny chill seeping through the drafty corridors defied the fire's warmth. Huddled around the hearthstone, displaced fishermen and war refugees roasted salted lake fish, seeking refuge from the bitter cold. Beside the brazier, Cilia ground lily-of-the-valley extracts and mountain mint leaves in a stone mortar, carefully preparing a restorative tonic for General Leonar's lingering battle wounds.

Stirring the ceramic medicine bowl, Cilia gazed through the rain-streaked window into the tempest.

"Ominous currents are churning beneath the lake surface. The cadence of the waves is distorted, poisoned with deep crimson mana."

Resting his unadorned iron shield against the stone mantle, Kadan nodded solemnly.

"It bears the chilling aura of the imperial secret inquisition we witnessed in the capital. Lucian has surely tracked our scent to this lake."

At that moment, an elderly watchman stationed at the jetty tower hurried into the hall, shaking the driving rain from his oilskin cloak. Clutched tightly against his chest was an unidentified parcel wrapped in sodden burlap.

Panting heavily, the fisherman set the container down atop the heavy trestle table.

"Just moments ago, a black-sailed cutter slipped through the fog, hurled this crate onto the jetty, and vanished into the darkness! General Leonar's honored name is carved distinctly across the lid!"

Resting upon the timber planks was a skull-sized chest carved from translucent black crystal. Atop the lid squatted five masterfully sculpted viper heads coiled in serpentine tension, while from the fine hairline fractures along the seams seeped an ominous violet miasma, pulsing like living capillaries.

Cilia gripped her staff, her voice ringing out in sharp alarm.

"Do not approach it! The runes etched across those crystal facets bear the forbidden necromantic death-curses of Medusa Gorgo! The instant the lid is released, lethal necrotic venom will engulf this room!"

Before her warning could be fully registered, the cunning internal clockwork trigger embedded within the box's base released with a crisp, fatal click. With a violent crystalline detonation, the obsidian chest shattered into shards, and from the billowing purple toxic vapor surged five ethereal phantom vipers with burning crimson eyes. The weightless spirit-serpents lunged with blinding speed toward two young refugee orphans slumbering wrapped in blankets beside the hearthstone.

In that heart-stopping instant, General Leonar launched his massive frame across the floor with the thunderous roar of an enraged lion.

"Vile vermin, dare you bare your fangs against innocent babes!"

It was a split second too brief to evade or brandish his heavy staff. Without a trace of hesitation, Leonar swept his immense arms around the children, shielding their fragile bodies against his breast while presenting his broad back and shoulders to the incoming strike. With a sickening hiss of dissolving flesh, the spectral fangs sank deep into the veteran's nape and collarbone, and a network of blackened, corrosive necrotic venom spread like spiderwebs beneath his graying skin. His massive muscles sizzled as sulfurous fumes filled the air.

Kneeling rigidly with his arms locked around the weeping children, Leonar coughed violently, dark clots of corrupted blood spattering the flagstones.

"Ghk... Little ones, are you harmed...? Speak to me, are you whole...?"

Clinging to the titan's chest in sheer terror, the children cried out in agony.

"Grandfather! Your back... Black blood is pouring from your shoulders!"

Caressing their tear-stained cheeks with his massive, calloused hand, Leonar forced a reassuring grin.

"Lion hide is tougher than dragon scales; the poisoned nibbles of garden snakes cannot bring me down. Fear not, little ones."

Kadan sprang forward with decisive fury, drawing the silver dagger from his belt. Channeling the star rhythm perfected across the frozen northern tundras, a brilliant aura of purifying starlight

wrapped around the razor edge like crackling frost.

"Foul spirits shall never desecrate the blood of the righteous!"

With fluid, lightning precision, Kadan cleaved through the air. The sacred anti-fiend sword techniques passed down by Master Aleksandar severed the ethereal spines of the five phantom serpents in consecutive arcs of azure radiance. Wherever the blade passed, the screeching apparitions dissolved into shimmering white ash, snuffed out by the starlight.

Simultaneously, Cilia hoisted her Jade Staff high overhead, invoking the ancient cleansing cantrip of the eastern wind.

"Spirits of the eastern sea, sweep away this defiling shroud and restore the pure breath of life!"

A spiraling vortex of teal wind erupted from beneath Cilia's boots, sweeping the lingering clouds of violet toxic vapor straight up through the open roof vents into the torrential night. Crisp, pristine lake breezes poured into the timber hall, eradicating the last lingering traces of necrotic venom.

Rushing into the hall after hearing the tumult, Ignis froze in horror at the scene of destruction. Amidst the glittering fragments of the shattered crystal chest, a gleam of polished metal caught his eye. It was the golden imperial signet mechanism that had primed the detonation. Stamped into the hardened crimson wax was the personal crest of High Minister Lucian, flanked by the classified cipher runes of the Imperial Secret Inquisition.

Ignis's golden eyes widened in disbelieving agony, his breath catching as blood welled where his teeth bit through his lip.

"The imperial crest... It was Minister Lucian himself who dispatched this cowardly murder weapon? To butcher helpless refugees and an honorable retired general, solely to blame the atrocity upon the Holy Knights... Is this the 'order and justice' to which I pledged my sword and soul!"

In a frenzy of grief and disgust, Ignis violently tore the gilded medal of the White Flame Order from his breastplate, hurling it against the stone floorboards. The gilded emblem clattered across the flags with a hollow, pathetic chime. The grand edifice of imperial righteousness that had anchored his entire existence had collapsed into a cesspool of vile deceit.

Slamming his fist against the timber pillar, Ignis wept in fury.

"For what purpose did I hone my blade all these years! Did my steel defend peace, or merely fatten the corrupt parasites of the imperial court!"

Stepping forward, Kadan placed a firm, steady hand upon Ignis's shuddering shoulder.

"Facing the naked truth is an agonizing wound, Ignis. Yet keeping your eyes open to that darkness is the only way honor can ever be reborn. Uncle Balian prayed every single night that you would one day break free from that hollow shell."

Slumped against a timber stanchion, Leonar wiped dark blood from his lips, his breathing growing shallow and rasping. Though the veil of death was descending swiftly across his features, the old warlord's gaze retained the undaunted majesty of a battlefield titan. With trembling, calloused hands, he lifted his legendary Jade Staff, passing the ancestral weapon into the care of Kadan and Cilia.

"My ember burns down to the wick... But the barrier spires of Whispering Wind Island must never fall. Tell Aeolus... that Leonar never retreated, that he held his ground until his final breath..."

Tears spilled down Cilia's cheeks as her hands closed around the polished jade.

"General, the sacred covenant of the earth bound within this staff shall never be betrayed. We will safeguard the island and illuminate my mother's truth, no matter the cost."

Kadan knelt before the dying lion, clasping the warrior's rough hand in both of his own.

"I swear upon my shield to safeguard the innocent lives and the hearthfire of this manor you defended. May your journey to reunite with Master Aleksandar be filled with eternal peace."

Reaching out with gentle, massive fingers, Leonar patted the heads of the weeping refugee orphans who clung to his knees.

"Weep not, little ones... An old lion is merely closing his eyes for a well-earned slumber..."

The refugees and fishermen gathered in a silent circle around their fallen protector, raising their voices in a sorrowful, ancient mariners' requiem. As the tempest outside gradually waned and the cool blue hues of early dawn settled over Mist Lake, the great warrior breathed his last with a peaceful smile upon his lips. Kneeling before the fallen titan, the three youths forged an unbreakable vow of resolve for the battles that lay ahead. The golden dawn rising over the tranquil waters crowned the old general's departure with transcendent majesty.

CHAPTER 16

Episode 16 · Brothers Before the Ruins

Part 1 · Episode 16 of 40

On the eve of their voyage to Whispering Wind Island, the dense, milky-white fog that had weighed upon Mist Lake for days lifted as if by magic. A cool crescent moon rose above the placid waters, bathing the seventy-two colossal basalt monoliths in silver radiance, while the mirror-like surface reflected the vast river of stars overhead in breathtaking clarity. In the dead of night, while the weary refugees slept after preparing the vessels for the morning departure, only the gentle lap of water against pilings and the rustle of blooming reeds stirred the peaceful silence. Walking along the wooden boards, Kadan stepped alone toward the furthest jetty of the floating manor.

Standing silhouetted against the moonlight at the far edge was a solitary, familiar figure. Having cast aside his immaculate white commander's cloak, Ignis wore only a battered leather arming doublet.

Grasping his silver-hilted ceremonial longsword—the ancestral heirloom of his lineage and the proud symbol of the White Flame Order—with both hands, Ignis gazed upon the keen, polished edge gleaming in the moonlight. Without a trace of hesitation, he opened his fingers. The blade sliced through the cool air, vanishing into the black depths of the lake with a heavy splash. Rippling concentric rings spread across the surface, swallowing the weapon's trail into the abyss.

Approaching quietly, Kadan stood beside him.

"That blade carried the highest honor of the imperial court. Do you feel no regret?"

Fixing his gaze upon the dark ripples, Ignis spoke in a hoarse, hollow voice.

"Honor stained in deceit and innocent blood is far better buried beneath the lake mud. Everything I spent my life fighting to protect was nothing more than a shield for corrupt monsters feasting upon the weak."

Looking up into the crystal canopy of northern constellations, Kadan murmured softly.

"Casting aside a blade is never defeat. Only when one empties hands that gripped falsehood can they truly embrace what is worth defending."

The despair and self-loathing in Ignis's tone cut deep into the night air. The crushing burden of guilt for blood shed in service of lies weighed heavily upon the young warrior's spirit.

Reaching inside his woolen coat, Kadan retrieved a weathered parchment scroll from an oiled leather pouch. It was dog-eared and stained with dried blood—the final letter written by Uncle Balian before his passing.

Kadan offered the scroll into Ignis's hands.

"Uncle Balian entrusted this letter to me. He said his soul could only rest in peace once it rested within your own grasp."

With trembling hands, Ignis broke the wax seal. Written upon the parchment in rough, powerful strokes was his father's unmistakable handwriting.

'To my son, Ignis. When you took up the White Flame in the capital, your father's heart ached with sorrow, yet I never held bitterness toward you. I knew the pure integrity of your spirit, yearning only to bring light to the realm. The path brother Aleksandar and I walked was fraught with hardship, but it was never in vain. The point of your sword must never serve the throne of tyrants; it must shield the hands of freezing children. You are loved, my son.'

As Ignis read the words, large tears welled and fell, darkening the ink upon the parchment. The father he had believed had abandoned him had, until his dying breath, held him in his heart as a cherished son. Overwhelmed by grief and redemption, Ignis sank to his knees upon the wooden planks, weeping openly.

Clutching the parchment against his chest, Ignis sobbed into the wind.

"Father... Blind to your suffering, I cursed you as a traitor and danced as a hunting hound for the court... How can I ever atone for this disgraceful blindness..."

Kneeling beside him, Kadan placed a comforting arm around his shoulders.

"Uncle Balian never once faulted you. His only prayer was that you would endure to find the true light."

When the quiet sobs subsided under the silver moonlight, Ignis lifted his tear-streaked face toward Kadan.

"Kadan... How did you endure? Having lost your parents, your master, and with the entire world branding you a criminal... How did you keep from being swallowed whole by the roaring fires of hatred?"

Drawing the silver dagger at his waist, Kadan gazed upon the moonlight gleaming along its spine. The red knot danced gently in the nocturnal lake breeze.

"Master Aleksandar taught me that a weapon is never an instrument to conquer or punish. It must be a sturdy roof that weathers the storm in place of the fragile and defenseless. The heavier the shield in your hand, the warmer the hearts of those you protect will dwell within your breast. Hatred incinerates one's own soul long before it reaches the foe, but the resolve to protect kindles an eternal ember even amidst the bitterest blizzard."

Ignis looked down at his empty, calloused hands. The warrior's scars across his palms no longer felt like badges of shame.

"A roof... Could hands like mine ever serve as a shelter for another?"

Kadan tapped his iron rim with a warm smile.

"We are brothers, Ignis. Just as Uncle Balian and Master Aleksandar stood together, it is our turn to watch each other's back."

Approaching from the jetty gallery, Cilia offered two steaming ceramic cups of herbal tea.

"You two should stop letting the chilly dawn wind bite your cheeks. Drink this and warm your bones; tomorrow we must conquer the open sea."

In that tender moment, a sharp hiss of crossbow quarrels and the frantic cry of a sentry shattered the night air from the outer timber colonnade. Twenty elite inquisitors of the Crimson Fang, dispatched by Minister Lucian to exterminate all living witnesses, charged across the outer piers toward the ships. Hooked blades and poisoned bolts gleamed in their hands, accompanied by jars of flammable pitch meant to incinerate the refugee vessels before departure.

The inquisition commander barked with vicious malice.

"Slaughter the northern rebels and the imperial turncoat without mercy! Burn the manor and every ship to ash to leave zero evidence behind!"

Without an instant's hesitation, Kadan planted his iron shield forward, anchoring the front line. A volley of poisoned bolts slammed into the curved surface, scattering sparks and splintering harmlessly away.

"Not a single foot shall pass behind this shield!"

Beside him, Ignis charged forward. Deprived of his sword, he seized a heavy iron stanchion from the deck, channeling his mana to the absolute limit. Stripped of imperial arrogance, the pure white flame roared to life along the metal. It was no longer a fire of conquest, but a sanctifying hearthfire ignited solely to defend his comrades.

Ignis's sweeping strike shattered the assassins' hooked blades, casting the assailants headlong into the icy lake. Kadan's immovable barrier and Ignis's immaculate white flame moved in seamless harmony, annihilating the ambush within minutes. Broken blades and sputtering torches hissed out in the freezing water.

Spitting lake water, the assassin leader snarled from the waves.

"Ignis! You shall pay dearly for betraying the grace of the throne!"

Looking down from the deck, Ignis replied with cold resolve.

"The grace of the throne never existed. A power that tramples its own people deserves only to be dismantled."

As the surviving assassins scrambled into the dark waters in panic, tranquil silence returned to the pier.

Beyond the eastern horizon, the deep indigo sky blushed with the first rose-gold hues of dawn. The massive sails of the flagship, 'Breeze Wing', unfurled in the morning wind, and the resonant blast of a conch horn echoed across the mist-cleared lake. On the pier, gathered refugees and children waved their hands, blessing the voyagers with heartfelt prayers.

Leaning over the forward railing, Cilia waved eagerly.

"Kadan, Ignis! The anchors are drawn! The wind has turned favorable, come aboard!"

Gripping the helm, Rondol bellowed with hearty triumph.

"The sea gods have opened our passage! Young lions, unfurl the sails toward the new dawn!"

Clasping each other's forearms in an unbreakable pledge of brotherhood, Kadan and Ignis bounded up the gangway. Slipping gracefully between the seventy-two ancient basalt monoliths, the ship glided out toward the boundless expanse of the azure ocean. Morning sunlight washed over the brothers' shoulders, crowning their journey with a golden blessing. Before them lay the uncharted high seas and the legendary shores of Whispering Wind Island.

CHAPTER 17

Episode 17 · Invitation to the Wind Isle

Part 1 · Episode 17 of 40

Across the deck of the flagship 'Breeze Wing' slicing through the eastern ocean, salty gales whipped in relentless squalls. In every direction stretched the rolling azure swells of the boundless main and the distant horizon, and each time the vessel's timber prow cleaved through a crest, showers of crystalline foam scattered into the air like shimmering rainbows. Thick manila rigging groaned in protest against the mastheads, and from the wet oak decking rose the sharp, briny mingling of sea salt and pine tar. At high noon on the second day of their voyage, the rhythmic thunder of immense wings pierced the roar of the surf from beneath the heavy storm clouds to the north.

Gripping the ship's helm, Rondol adjusted his brass monocular, pointing toward the northern squall line.

"Look to the northwestern heavens! That is no common albatross. It is an imperial wind gryphon bearing the silver plumage of the royal aviary!"

At Rondol's shout, Kadan and Ignis hurried to the weather railing. A magnificent beast adorned in silver and deep indigo feathers circled the rigging before alighting with majestic grace upon the topgallant yardarm. Fastened to the gryphon's right talon was a cylindrical silver courier tube, its wax seal bearing the distinct plum-blossom cipher of Master Titania, high royal scholar of Whispering Wind Island and Cilia's revered mentor.

Whistling a melodious wind greeting, Cilia coaxed the gentle beast to glide down and perch upon her leather arm-guard.

Extracting the parchment scroll from the silver canister, Cilia murmured with growing apprehension.

"An urgent dispatch from Master Titania. Grave calamity has struck the island."

Kadan rested his iron shield, gently stroking the beast's downy feathers.

"A messenger that flew thousands of leagues across open water. It carries your mentor's utmost devotion."

Across the unfurled scroll, ink strokes had been brushed in hurried, frantic haste, conveying news that chilled the companions to their marrow.

High Elder Zephyr, supreme archon of the Wind Isle Council, had placed King Aeolus under de facto house arrest and proclaimed martial law across the entire archipelago. Colluding with Minister Lucian of the imperial court, Zephyr had integrated the forbidden mana siphon of the Nine Shadows Codex into the island's vital core, the Jade Barrier Spire. It was an act of treason designed to open the kingdom's sacred elemental mantle as an invasion corridor for the imperial armada.

Cilia's face paled as her voice trembled.

"Master Titania writes that Elder Zephyr has already locked down the southern and eastern commercial havens, inviting the imperial navy's shadow galleys into our territorial waters. My father Aeolus, ensnared by phantom illusions regarding my mother Sylphid's death, has become Zephyr's helpless puppet..."

Ignis slammed his armored fist against the oak railing in mounting fury.

"Lucian's venomous claws have reached even the sacred havens of the eastern sea! Wielding the empire's legions like private mercenaries to usurp the sovereign throne of an allied realm! I swear to snap that tyrant's neck with my bare hands!"

Placing a steadying hand upon Cilia's shuddering shoulder, Kadan asked in calm tactical focus.

"Did Master Titania provide an alternate approach? Sailing into the fortified harbors will only draw concentrated fire from the coastal mana batteries."

Turning the scroll over, Cilia nodded with renewed hope.

"Master Titania has drawn the secret maritime passage known only to my mother and Uncle Rondol."

Spreading the secret naval chart across the plotting table, Cilia traced an intricate nautical route. The weathered brass compass and arcane mana gauges clicked in rhythm with the rolling deck.

"Beneath the western sea cliffs lies Razor Reef Defile, where violent subterranean currents normally prevent ships from navigating. A flooded subterranean grotto there leads directly into the catacombs beneath the Black Temple at the base of the barrier spire."

Rondol whistled through his teeth as he examined the jagged shoals marked upon the chart.

"Razor Reef Defile! The seabed is bristling with serrated granite ridges like dragon's teeth. Misjudge the current by half a fathom and the keel will be ripped out. Even seasoned elven pilots would never dare attempt that passage under the cover of night. An old sea dog like me lost his ship and left his leg behind in those very waters a decade ago."

Adjusting the scarlet ribbon bound to his silver dagger, Kadan spoke with unwavering resolve.

"A treacherous reef is far better than imperial cannon batteries. Master Aleksandar taught me that danger and opportunity share the same threshold. When night falls, the surface chop will settle; with Cilia's wind weaving and Uncle Rondol's master seamanship, we can navigate the defile."

Rondol stroked his briny gray beard, letting out a booming belly laugh.

"Ha! The northern wolf knows how to stoke the embers in an old sea dog's chest! So be it! This pegleg will prove that an old sailor's blood has not turned to bilge water!"

Ignis tightened his jaw with fierce determination.

"I know the firing angles of imperial siege vessels by heart. If we penetrate their blind spots, my flames will light our path."

At twilight, as blood-red dusk stained the rolling swells, danger struck without warning. Slicing through the ocean fog, three black-hulled imperial attack galleys surged forward, flanking Breeze Wing from port and starboard. From their mounted ballistae erupted a lethal volley of sulfur-tipped fire quarrels and iron grappling anchors.

Stepping swiftly to the windward deck, Kadan angled his unadorned iron shield, deflecting the hail of flaming missiles to shield the crew. Sparks cascaded like fireworks against the iron rim, yet Kadan's grounded stance absorbed the kinetic momentum without yielding an inch. Hissing fiercely, deflected quarrels plunged into the brine.

"Hostile cutters boarding! Prepare for melee on deck!"

Seizing his iron stanchion, Ignis leaped onto the bulwarks. A sweeping ribbon of immaculate white flame cleaved through the air, melting through the approaching grappling hawsers in a blinding flash. As imperial shock troops hurled boarding irons to breach the deck, Cilia swept her Jade Staff, conjuring a crushing gale-force vortex across the waves. Caught in the sudden swell, one enemy galley lost its trim and slammed violently against an outcrop of razor shale, its timber hull buckling in half.

Planting his boots back-to-back with Kadan, Ignis called out over the roar of the gale.

"Kadan! Their flagship is driven by an arcane mana-steam turbine! We must disable their drive furnace to slip their pursuit!"

Bracing his shield with firm balance, Kadan opened the assault vector.

"Spring from my shield, Ignis!"

Launching himself off the face of Kadan's shield, Ignis vaulted across the churning sea. Cleaving downward in a spinning crescent, his pure white flame pierced straight through the armored grates of the enemy's mana furnace. With a concussive roar, the arcane boiler detonated, crippling the flagship's propulsion in clouds of boiling steam.

Leaving the burning imperial galleys adrift in their wake, Rondol wrenched the helm, expertly slipping the timber bow of Breeze Wing into the narrow, swirling waters of Razor Reef Defile. With Cilia's gentle wind mana filling the canvas, the vessel glided gracefully between the menacing granite fangs like a phantom. Though violent swells slammed against the hull, Rondol's seasoned helmsmanship and Kadan's grounded mana stabilization kept the ship upright.

When total darkness enfolded the sea, the legendary Whispering Wind Island rose before them in breathtaking splendor, shrouded in luminous emerald sea mist. High atop the colossal basalt crags at the heart of the island, the majestic Jade Barrier Spire pulsed with ripples of soothing, translucent green light across the starry firmament. The ship glided silently into the gaping mouth of an ancient limestone sea cavern beneath the cliffs.

Tears glistening upon her eyelashes, Cilia gazed upon her ancestral shores.

"I have returned... to the sacred haven where my mother sleeps. The light of the barrier spire has not yet been extinguished."

Lowering his iron shield, Kadan spoke with solemn depth.

"Now is the hour to banish the encroaching shadow and return true freedom to the realm of the wind. Queen Sylphid's spirit watches over our blades."

Ignis touched his breastplate with solemn devotion.

"I shall be the first to pay the debt my empire incurred."

With resolute hearts, the three young champions and the old mariner cast anchor into the dark waters before the submerged cavern of the Black Temple. Rhythmic drops falling from the cavern

ceiling echoed their solemn silence.

CHAPTER 18

Episode 18 · Secret of the Black Temple

Part 1 · Episode 18 of 40

Emerging cautiously from the flooded sea cavern beneath Razor Reef Defile, the companions set foot upon the ancient ruins of the Black Temple, buried deep in the subterranean foundations of Whispering Wind Island. Isolated from mortal eyes for millennia, the sunken sanctum resembled an immense, majestic library flanked by endless rows of towering basalt columns. Yet nowhere were paper codices or vellum scrolls to be found. The entirety of the colossal obsidian walls, stretching scores of fathoms toward the vaulted ceiling, functioned as living memory crystals pulsing with faint azure phosphorescence. From between the massive stalactites clinging to the vaulted roof, cold subterranean droplets fell in rhythmic intervals, tracing clear, concentric ripples across the glass-like water. Veins of azure mana coursed through the stone like the quiet pulse of primordial elemental spirits.

Tracing the glossy basalt with trembling fingertips, Cilia spoke in a hushed, reverent whisper.

"This is the primordial archive established by the ancestors of Aeolus, Spirit King of the Winds, to preserve the unblemished truths of the continent. Parchment and ink decay with the passage of centuries, but every breath of the earth and every true memory is eternally sealed within this living obsidian matrix."

Resting his unadorned iron shield, Kadan surveyed the solitary altar at the hall's center.

"The histories penned on paper are easily manipulated by the brushes of tyrants, but the stone of the earth never speaks falsehood. Master Aleksandar always told me that only the memories sleeping within the Black Temple across the sea could heal the deep scars of the continent."

Staring at his own shadowed, battered reflection in the dark stone, Ignis swallowed hard.

"Eighteen winters ago... The fateful night when my father was branded a traitor and Master Aleksandar fell in ash... Is the blood-stained truth of that tragedy recorded here as well? I almost fear to look with my own eyes upon the reality of what I spent my life fighting to defend."

Turning to him with gentle warmth, Cilia placed a reassuring hand upon his arm.

"Do not fear, Ignis. No matter how bitter the truth, facing our wounds in the bright light of day is infinitely nobler than wandering lost in the shroud of comfortable falsehood."

Reaching the center of the hall, Cilia stood before the jade-veined crystal sphere resting upon the altar. Around the cold stone dais, sacred elemental wards carved by wind spirits cast soothing teal light, and etched into the crystal sphere in archaic glyphs was the inscription: 'Let he who seeks truth offer the purest tear.'

With reverent care, Cilia drew the legendary Jade Staff—her mother Sylphid's heirloom—and seated the ferrule into the altar's socket. The massive emerald atop the staff hummed in resonance, stirring a gentle vortex of air. Closing her eyes, Cilia let fall a single crystalline tear born of long years of yearning and sorrow upon the sphere.

Instantly, the entire temple shuddered with blinding azure brilliance.

Tens of thousands of obsidian crystals resonated in thunderous harmony, projecting a colossal, lifelike phantom memory across the vaulted ceiling, recreating the tragedy that had unfolded in the Jade Palace eighteen winters ago.

It revealed a reality utterly antithetical to the imperial histories taught in the capital.

High Elder Zephyr, colluding with Minister Lucian of the imperial court, was seen secretly pouring the lethal venom of Medusa Gorgo into the ceremonial silver chalice of Queen Sylphid during the peace banquet eighteen winters ago. When Sylphid collapsed coughing blackened blood, Zephyr had sealed the colonnades with pre-cast shadow wards, shrieking in feigned horror to frame the Holy Knights stationed outside.

"The Holy Knights have assassinated the queen! Slay every traitor without mercy!"

Within the projected memory, Aleksandar and Balian charged through the flaming colonnades. Drawing his silver dagger and bracing his iron shield, Aleksandar fought desperately against Zephyr's shadow assassins, striving to defend the dying queen.

"Protect Her Majesty! Balian, take the child and the refugees to the western pier! I shall hold this passage!"

Riddled with crossbow bolts, Balian bore the infant Cilia and weeping refugees into the night, carving an escape corridor. Yet the Imperial Secret Inquisition and Zephyr's faction buried the truth, declaring the two knights traitors and unleashing bounty hunters across the continent. In the flaming ruins, Master Aleksandar stood alone against hundreds of pursuers until he fell in battle.

Witnessing the agonizing truth, Ignis dropped to his knees, slamming his fists into the basalt flags as tears of blood spilled from his eyes.

"Father... Father Balian... You were no traitor; you were the noblest knight who fought to your dying breath to protect the queen and her child... Yet I... I held hands with those vile murderers, poisoning my heart with hatred toward you all these years!"

Kadan knelt beside him, wrapping an arm around his brother's shuddering shoulders. Kadan's eyes were wet with unshed tears.

"The fault does not lie with you, Ignis. It was a cruel tragedy forced upon us by tyrants blinded by power. Neither Master Aleksandar nor Uncle Balian ever resented us. Now it falls to our steel to illuminate that truth before the entire world."

Wiping her tears, Cilia drew the Jade Staff from the altar with burning resolve.

"I swear upon my life to prove that my mother's demise was not the crime of the Holy Knights, but the vile treason of Zephyr and Lucian."

At that moment, the screech of shearing stone echoed from the ceiling as an ominous pulse of mana erupted from the shadows. Automated defenses set by Zephyr activated: three colossal obsidian golems and twenty shadow stalkers surged into the hall to entomb the intruders forever.

As the titan golems brought their colossal fists down toward the altar, Kadan bounded forward, angling his iron shield to catch the crushing impact with star-breathing.

Boom!

The concussive shockwave felt as though an entire mountain peak had collapsed upon his guard. Yet drawing upon star-breathing, Kadan channeled the kinetic fury through his boots and into the subterranean water conduits. The stone floor fractured as pressurized springs geysered upward, yet Kadan's upper body remained as unyielding as granite.

"Cilia, Ignis! Protect the memory crystal!"

Wielding his iron pipe, Ignis unleashed his immaculate white flame with volcanic ferocity. Burning away his agonizing guilt, his holy fire pierced straight through the shadow stalkers' black iron blades.

"I will never be deceived by monsters of shadow again!"

Sweeping her Jade Staff, Cilia transformed the geysering subterranean waters into razor-sharp hydro-blades, cleanly severing the golems' limbs. In the face of the three youths' furious coordination, the ambush was annihilated within moments.

As silence settled once more over the hall, Cilia wrapped the glowing azure Memory Shard in a fine silk mantle. It was the undeniable proof containing her mother's dying breath and the vindication of Master Aleksandar and Uncle Balian.

Pointing his shield toward the spiraling stone stairway carved into the cavern wall, Kadan spoke with determination.

"This stairway ascends directly beneath the Sky Altar of the Barrier Spire. King Aeolus must be held captive there."

Cilia nodded with unyielding resolve, gripping her staff.

"We must present this memory crystal to my father. We must shatter the illusions blinding his eyes and stop the barrier spire from collapsing."

Ignis stepped into the lead, his golden eyes blazing with righteous fire.

"I will take Zephyr's head with my own hands. That is the only atonement I can offer to my father Balian and Master Aleksandar."

Exchanging solemn smiles of brotherhood, the three young wanderers left the dark sanctuary behind, climbing boldly toward the light above. The wind rushing down the staircase was freezing, yet the fire of justice burning within their breasts was hotter than any tempest. Behind them, the azure glow of the obsidian temple illuminated their ascent like the eternal blessing of ancient heroes.

CHAPTER 19

Episode 19 · The Three Trials

Part 1 · Episode 19 of 40

Ascending the final coils of the spiraling staircase, the companions reached the Sky Altar, suspended thousands of fathoms above Whispering Wind Island. Far below stretched the panoramic expanse of the azure ocean and jagged coastal shoals, while overhead, the colossal mana vortex of the Jade Barrier Spire cleaved through the thunderheads with concussive roars. Across a narrow stone bridge bridging the chasm stood King Aeolus, once revered as the sovereign Spirit King of the Winds. His silver hair whipped wildly in the tempest, his eyes clouded with profound grief and corrupted by High Elder Zephyr's phantom illusions. Crackling ribbons of lightning coiled around the massive broadsword held in his trembling grasp.

Leveling his storm blade, Aeolus bellowed in a voice hoarse with pain.

"None shall cross this bridge! I will never permit the heir of the treacherous Holy Knights who butchered my beloved Sylphid, nor the wayward princess who consorts with our foes, to desecrate the sanctuary!"

Stepping forward with the Jade Staff, Cilia pleaded through falling tears.

"Father, look upon me! Look at mother's staff in my hands and this living memory crystal! It was not the Holy Knights who took mother's life, but High Elder Zephyr, who poisoned her cup in treasonous collusion with the imperial court!"

Clutching his temples in agony, Aeolus refused to lower his guard.

"Vile deceptions! Zephyr testified before the council that the silver dagger of the Holy Order pierced my queen's heart! If the youth beside you is truly innocent, let him brave my three trials to prove his purity of purpose!"

Planting his boots firmly, Kadan raised his unadorned iron shield to chest height.

"I will not shrink from any trial. If crossing this bridge can vindicate Master Aleksandar and prove Cilia's truth, I wager my life upon this stone."

Ignis gripped Kadan's shoulder with solemn urgency.

"Stay sharp, Kadan. King Aeolus's storm blade is a divine relic of the winds, capable of cleaving imperial knights in twain with a single stroke."

The first trial was the Trial of the Gale.

With a sweeping gesture from Aeolus, thousands of razor-sharp wind blades erupted across the bridge, churning the air with deafening shrieks. The kinetic pressure was fierce enough to pulverize granite, while beneath the narrow span lay an abyss plunging straight into the ocean depths. A glancing gale sheared Kadan's cheek, drawing crimson blood.

Yet Kadan drew no weapon. Bracing his unadorned iron shield, he drew star-breathing deep into his lungs.

"Master Aleksandar taught me never to fight the gale, but to embrace its flow through the unyielding weight of the earth."

Angling the face of his shield at forty-five degrees, Kadan deflected the tempest's fury into the empty air. Wind blades shrieked violently against the iron rim, yet Kadan advanced step by steady step across the stones. Blood seeped through his sleeves where veins strained under the pressure, yet his eyes remained as tranquil as a frozen northern tarn. He pressed forward like an immovable iron monolith cleaving the storm.

Halting midway across the bridge, Kadan stood firm, shaking Aeolus to his soul.

"To advance without unsheathing steel, taking the storm upon his own flesh... That grounded posture and that impenetrable guard... It is beyond question the peerless art of Aleksandar."

The second trial was the Trial of Memory.

The moment Kadan set foot on the center of the span, Aeolus's arcane illusion erupted, transfiguring the altar into the flaming ruins of the Elwin estate in the north. Before Kadan's eyes rose the slaughter of his childhood: village elders cut down and his parents' dying cries echoing through the smoke. From the shadows coiling around the stones hissed a serpentine voice: 'Hate this corrupt world. Draw your blade and burn the empire and the wind kingdom in retribution. Avenge the blood stolen from you.'

Violent fury and grief constricted Kadan's throat, tempting him to draw his steel and butcher the phantoms.

Yet Kadan gripped the scarlet ribbon bound to his silver dagger, breathing out a steady, measured breath.

"My shield was never forged for bloody vengeance. It exists to protect the fragile warmth of those shivering behind me, to halt the cycle of tragedy forever!"

With a decisive thrust of his shield, Kadan shattered the phantom mist. The dark mirage fractured like brittle glass, returning the pristine light of the Sky Altar. Staring at the young warrior who refused to surrender to hatred, Aeolus fell speechless.

"He broke the nightmare not through wrath... but solely through the resolve to protect..."

The final trial was the Trial of Sacrifice.

As Aeolus invoked the central lightning glyphs, a colossal thunderbolt formed in the clouds, crackling with righteous execution. It was a lethal judgment designed to cease only when an intruder's life was consumed.

In that fatal instant, Ignis vaulted across the stones, throwing his unarmored body beside Kadan. Conjuring his immaculate white flame, he erected a radiant dome of pure fire.

"I will not let my brother perish alone! If blood must atone for imperial crimes, let mine be the first to fall!"

Cilia raised her Jade Staff, layering an azure gale barrier over their heads.

"Father! If your blade remains blind to the truth, let it strike through my heart first!"

Shoulder to shoulder, the three youths braced against the descending thunderbolt. Fire, light, and wind fused into a blinding supernova across the altar. The devastating stroke broke upon their unified barrier, dissolving into harmless sparks. In the quiet that followed, only their ragged breathing stirred the heights.

The great storm blade slipped from Aeolus's fingers, clattering upon the stones. The gray film clouding his eyes washed away in tears. Stumbling forward, the king cradled Cilia's face in trembling hands.

"Cilia... My precious daughter... I was blinded by sorrow, dancing like a fool to a traitor's whispers... In the eyes of these youths shielding one another, the dream of peace once shared by Sylphid and Aleksandar lives still..."

Kneeling, Aeolus grasped Kadan's calloused hands.

"Young knight, your shield has opened my blind eyes. Sir Aleksandar's noble spirit smiles proudly within you."

Wiping her tears, Cilia supported her father.

"Father, we must halt the spire's collapse! Zephyr is channeling the Nine Shadows Codex!"

Aeolus pointed toward the inner bronze doors with grim urgency.

"Make haste! Zephyr has inverted the mana flows to awaken the abyssal depths! Before the black tsunami drowns the island, race to the core!"

Kadan adjusted his shield with solemn resolve.

"Though the tides rise to the heavens, this shield will never yield."

Blessed by the sovereign of the winds, the three companions sprinted boldly into the core of the raging spire.

King Aeolus draped his mantle of royal azure feathers around Cilia's shoulders. "This mantle was the cherished legacy bequeathed by your mother Sylphid. Step forward now as the true sovereign of the winds, and lead our people into the dawn." Cilia fastened the golden brooch, bowing deeply before her father.

CHAPTER 20

Episode 20 · Waves Swallowing the Flower Boats

Part 1 · Episode 20 of 40

Entering the sanctum of the Jade Barrier Spire, the companions discovered that High Elder Zephyr had already integrated the core mana matrix into the obsidian apparatus of the Nine Shadows Codex. Forbidden abyssal mana tainted the jade conduits of the spire, shaking the foundations of the island. Black lightning erupted from the apex, cleaving through the ocean horizon and awakening a catastrophic tidal wave from the sleeping depths. Ancient mana circulation systems that had maintained the island's gentle climate for thousands of years inverted with cataclysmic violence, staining the heavens crimson as colossal marble walls fractured and tumbled into the abyss.

Zephyr shrieked in maniacal ecstasy as he primed the conduits.

> "Foolish Aeolus and witless princess! Whispering Wind Island shall serve as the grand sacrificial altar for the new era! Once the ocean swallows everything, the empire and I shall rule supreme over the continent!"

Kadan and Ignis surged forward, but a violent concussive shockwave from the collapsing core swept Zephyr into a spatial teleportation rift. Laughing in vile triumph, the traitor fled toward the imperial capital.

At that moment, the frantic clangor of the island's temple bells echoed from the harbors below, accompanied by the terrified screams of thousands of citizens.

Rushing to the terrace, Cilia looked down and turned pale as ash.

> "No! Zephyr has dismantled the elemental barriers, unsealing the oceanic abyss! A black tsunami hundreds of fathoms high is bearing down upon the harbor!"

Whispering Wind Island possessed not a single war galley. Only hundreds of traditional ceremonial 'Flower Boats'—timber barges festooned with water lilies, lotus blooms, and spring irises for the equinox festival—were moored along the wharves. The festive vessels that had once wafted sweet floral fragrances were now fragile leaves tossed before a wall of liquid death.

As the mountain of black water crested the horizon, panic consumed the gathering refugees. Mooring pylons groaned and snapped under the violent receding undertow, flooding the wharves in chaos.

Raising her Jade Staff, Cilia projected her voice across the harbor with wind magic.

"People of Whispering Wind Island, hear my voice! I am Cilia, daughter of Queen Sylphid! There is nowhere on land to flee! Board every flower barge along the piers! The festive craft of our ancestors shall serve as our ark of salvation!"

Inspired by Cilia's clarion call, the islanders rallied, boarding the barges in disciplined haste.

Stamping his iron pegleg upon the planks, Rondol took command of the dockside evacuations.

"Board the children and elders first! Thirty souls per barge, sturdy hands to the oars on port and starboard! By Rondol's name, the sea shall not claim a single life today!"

Ignis bounded onto the piers, wielding his pure white flame to incinerate fallen timber and shattered rocks, carving open departure channels for the flower barges. The hands of the former imperial commander now reached out to lift weeping children and frail elders safely onto the decks. Bracing fallen beams with his iron shield, Kadan cleared paths for the elderly.

Kadan called out to the boatmen.

"Make haste! Cast off the mooring lines before the deluge swallows the wharves!"

Yet from beyond the boiling swell rose the Leviathan, a colossal sea behemoth corrupted by Medusa Gorgo's necrotic blight. Riding the crest of the black deluge, the abomination opened its gaping maw, charging a cataclysmic beam of shadow mana aimed squarely at the refugee flotilla. If the tsunami struck, the wooden flower boats would be obliterated into splinters.

In that fatal instant, Kadan bounded onto the timber prow of the flagship 'Breeze Wing' at the van of the flotilla.

Grasping his unadorned iron shield with both hands, Kadan drew the foundational power of the earth deep into his spirit. The ultimate defensive mystery passed down by Master Aleksandar—the 'Star-Steadfast Bulwark'—ignited within Kadan's breast in an aura of brilliant starlight.

Planting his boots into the timbers, Kadan unleashed a lion-hearted roar.

"To protect the warmth behind me, this shield shall never break! Guardians of the earth, awaken through the breath of the stars!"

A monumental wall of celestial blue starlight erupted from Kadan's shield. Cilia channeled the tempestuous winds of the Jade Staff into the barrier, while King Aeolus directed the full fury of his

storm mana from the Sky Altar into Kadan's guard. Starlight and jade wind fused into an impenetrable mountain of protective light rising from the sea.

Boom!

The black tsunami and the Leviathan's necrotic beam crashed headlong into Kadan's starlight barrier. A cataclysmic shockwave rent the heavens and the sea, vaporizing waves into billowing walls of white steam. The deck beneath Kadan's boots groaned and splintered. Blood welled through the young warrior's sleeves as veins strained under the titanic impact, yet his boots remained wedged into the prow like iron spikes, yielding not an inch.

The apocalyptic tsunami broke against Kadan's shield, cleaving in two and cascading harmlessly to either side. Riding through the towering spray, the frail flower boats crest the swells without capsizing.

Seizing the opening, Ignis vaulted high into the churning air. Channeling his immaculate white flame along his blade, he plunged like a bolt of holy lightning toward the Leviathan's glowing eye.

"Begone into the abyss, fiend of shadow!"

The blazing strike pierced the beast's skull. Howling in agony, the Leviathan thrashed and sank back into the ocean depths. Together, Kadan's immovable aegis and Ignis's sanctifying flame had vanquished the ancient catastrophe.

As the deluge receded and peaceful swells returned, thousands of refugees across the flower boats wept in joyous relief. Millions of colorful petals—lotus, iris, and water lily—floated upon the tranquil emerald sea, blanketing the horizon like a vast floral tapestry. A million floating blossoms bore silent witness to the triumph of life over destruction.

Yet beneath the waves, the outer coral ramparts and ancient palaces of Whispering Wind Island slowly slipped into the deep. Standing by the forward railing, Cilia wiped away quiet tears as she watched her homeland sink beneath the tide.

Stepping to her side, Kadan offered gentle solace.

"Weep not, Cilia. The stone walls have sunk, but the realm of the wind lives eternally within the hearts of the people you saved. So long as our people draw breath, the kingdom shall never perish."

Draping his cloak around her shivering shoulders, Ignis looked toward the western horizon.

"Our duty is not to stone and earth, but to the living warmth of tomorrow. Now we march upon the capital to bring Lucian and Zephyr to justice."

Led by King Aeolus and Captain Rondol, the armada of flower boats hoisted their canvas, sailing boldly toward the western continent. Beyond the jagged coastal peaks, the golden dawn of a new era broke in dazzling splendor. The second arc of the SNS Heroes drew to its triumphant close, opening the final battle for the fate of the realm. The ocean winds now filled their sails like sturdy wings bearing them into history.

CHAPTER 21

Episode 21 · Traces of the Burned Ship

Part 1 · Episode 21 of 40

When the armada of hundreds of flower boats led by the flagship 'Breeze Wing' crossed the treacherous ocean swells to reach the southwestern coast of the mainland, what welcomed the companions was not fluttering banners of celebration, but the suffocating stench of burning pitch and towering pillars of blackened smoke. The timber wharves of Seven Bridges Haven, once a tranquil maritime sanctuary connecting the northern tundra with the eastern seas, had been reduced to smoldering ash, while receding tides dragged fractured spars and scorched decking across the mudflats. In this desolate graveyard where not even a solitary gull cried, only the bitter reek of scorched cedar bore testimony to the scale of the atrocity. Rusted harbor chains lay snapped amidst the tidal mud, and the timber warehouses along the shoreline stood as skeletal frames vomiting black soot into the gray sky.

Gripping the helm, Rondol surveyed the ruined piers, his broad fists trembling with suppressed rage.

> "Merciless curs... To trap the fleeing populace, they incinerated civilian transports and fishing cutters without distinction. A decade ago, this haven bustled with grain barges and silk merchants from every corner of the world, yet the madness of those blinded by power knows no boundary."

Bracing his unadorned iron shield, Kadan leaped first onto the wet mudflats, his leather boots crunching through crushed seashells and charcoal dust.

> "Lucian's imperial vanguard has fortified the coastline and initiated a brutal scorched-earth campaign. The fires were set less than half a sunrise ago. We must search for survivors amidst the ruins."

Raising her Jade Staff to gather the coastal winds, Cilia knit her brow in deep concentration.

> "Beneath the western sea cliffs near the salt cellar, I sense the faint, labored breathing of living souls. But lethal mana snares are woven densely across the approach."

Weaving through heaps of sodden ash and charred timber ribs, the companions advanced cautiously toward the western cliff face. There lay the canted keel of a massive, burned hospital barge, dark bloodstains smeared along the fractured hull. Medicine chests and linen bandages lay

trampled into the muck, and upon a broken tea bowl rested the faint, weathered cross-crest of the Arcane Holy Knights. It had been a sanctuary of mercy established decades ago by Master Aleksandar and Uncle Balian to relieve northern famines.

Smoothing the scarlet ribbon bound to his silver dagger, Kadan spoke in a hushed, reverent murmur.

"This was the charitable clinic established by Uncle Balian and the Holy Knights. A haven that healed impoverished fishermen and orphans... incinerated into cinder."

Just then, a weathered trapdoor at the base of the granite cliff creaked open, and a white-haired elder brandishing a broken stone pestle peeked out with trembling wariness. It was Ordo, the elderly apothecary of the haven.

Beholding the sacred cross-crest upon Kadan's iron shield, Ordo broke into racking sobs of relief.

"Praise be to the heavens! The sacred shield of the Holy Knights has returned! Lucian's Crimson Wolf vanguard put the harbor to the torch and dragged our able-bodied youths to the labor mines, but I managed to conceal twenty orphaned children beneath these salt vaults!"

Stepping forward, Ignis took the old man's trembling hands, bowing his head in solemn remorse.

"Forgive our tardy arrival, elder. For the atrocities committed by the imperial host, I offer my life in earnest atonement."

Cilia lifted a broken ceramic herb jar, tears glittering upon her lashes.

"To set fire to a sanctuary dedicated solely to mercy and healing is an unforgivable sacrilege."

Descending into the salt cellar, the companions beheld twenty orphaned refugee children and wounded fishermen huddled together amidst sacks of coarse sea salt. Caked in grime and starving after days without rations, the children shivered, while injured mariners clutched gangrenous limbs in silent agony. The damp subterranean chill froze the little ones' bare feet blue.

Without a second thought, Cilia knelt upon the damp stone, extracting soothing restorative powders from her satchel to dress their lacerations.

"Do not fear. You are safe now. This is the soothing balm of mountain herbs brought from Whispering Wind Island."

As gentle teal mana radiated from Cilia's staff, stroking the children's fevered brows, their rasping breath smoothed into peaceful cadence.

Kadan drew loaves of barley bread and dried venison from his pack, placing them into the children's fragile hands.

"Eat slowly and take heart. Beyond these shores, hundreds of festive flower boats are waiting to bear you to safety."

A small girl touched Kadan's battered iron shield with her tiny fingers, weeping softly.

"Mister knight... The men in armor set fire to our home... Where has my mother gone?"

Caressing the girl's hair with tender gentleness, Kadan mastered the blazing fury surging in his breast.

"I will find your mother, little one. And those who crushed your hearth shall answer for every drop of sorrow they caused."

Offering his canteen of honeyed water to the injured elders, Ignis spoke with earnest depth.

"Moisten your throats. I swear upon my life to hold this battle line so the hunting hounds of the court can never harm you again."

In that tender moment, the sharp crunch of armored boots and the rhythmic creak of cocked crossbows echoed outside. Thirty elite inquisitors of Lucian's guard, alerted by the smoke, had cordoned off the cellar entrance.

Kicking down the outer door, the inquisition commander sneered in cruel triumph.

"So the vermin survived beneath the stones! Exterminate the traitors and feed their bones to the sea!"

Without hesitation, Kadan charged through the threshold, raising his iron shield. A volley of poisoned bolts shattered against the curved surface with deafening clangs.

"Not a single foot shall approach these children!"

Channeling star-breathing, Kadan spun his shield, snapping spearheads and shattering the vanguard's formation. Ignis charged beside him, his iron weapon wreathed in roaring white fire. The sanctified heat incinerated the assassins' plate armor, driving them headlong into the muck, while Cilia's blinding sandstorm stripped away their vision.

Sprawling in the mud, the inquisition commander hurled away his shattered helmet, shrieking in venomous rage.

"Ignis! Have you truly renounced the grace of the throne to become a lackey for northern rebels! Minister Lucian has placed the empire's greatest bounty upon your head!"

Planting his weapon into the earth, Ignis glared down with frigid disdain.

"Lucian's 'grace' is merely a sandcastle built on the blood of the innocent. Return and tell him: the shield of the Holy Knights and the flame of redemption will soon arrive to shatter his gilded throne!"

With the threat vanquished, tranquil surf returned to the shore.

Kadan and Ignis escorted the refugees safely onto the flower boats, where Rondol's crew served steaming carp soup to the shivering children. Beyond the western horizon, the rose-gold dusk cast long, dramatic shadows across the ruined harbor. From the decks of the flower boats drifted the tender, solemn melodies of seafarers' hymns.

Touching the scorched stone of the lighthouse, Cilia spoke with solemn resolve.

"The entire continent groans beneath Lucian's reign of terror. The road ahead will test every fiber of our spirits."

Ignis clenched his fists with unyielding conviction.

"They burned timber and stone, but they could never incinerate the hope of the people. At every crossroads toward the capital, we will deliver the suffering from despair."

Gazing toward the distant western mountain passes, Kadan tightened his grip on his dagger.

"This is the realm Master Aleksandar and Uncle Balian bled to protect. Even in the ashes of despair, we have defended the warmth of living souls. Now we raise our shields and walk that road until the dawn."

Under the dying light of dusk, the three youths sealed their unbreakable oath, taking their first bold strides into the heart of the troubled continent. Beyond the cold night fog, the rugged peaks of Mount Dragonhorn silently watched over their march.

CHAPTER 22

Episode 22 · Catapult of the Deserted Isle

Part 1 · Episode 22 of 40

When the flotilla of flower boats clearing Seven Bridges Haven reached the threshold of the Siren Strait—the solitary maritime gateway into the continental capital—chilled tension solidified across the water like winter ice. Atop the jagged cliffs flanking the narrowest defile of the strait, three colossal mana-ballista batteries erected by Lucian's imperial navy gleamed with lethal menace, while anchored directly in the mid-channel sat two titanic black-iron ironclads, enforcing an airtight maritime blockade. The siege engines possessed an effective range of a thousand paces, rendering any frontal assault by the frail wooden flower boats an act of suicidal folly.

Gripping the helm, Rondol studied the imperial fortifications through his brass telescope, clicking his tongue in frustration.

"Those ironclads draw too much water for our craft to board them, and their battery arcs overlap completely. Unless those cliffside ballista towers are silenced first, not a single flower barge will slip through alive."

Standing upon the timber prow, Kadan pointed his unadorned iron shield toward a solitary, wind-scoured reef rising outside the channel—Gull Crag.

"That rocky islet lies in the battery blind spot. If we establish a beachhead upon those cliffs, we can construct a counter-siege weapon to break the blockade."

Cilia swept her Jade Staff, reading the coastal squalls with a nod of approval.

"Violent undertows around Gull Crag deter imperial patrol cutters from venturing near. We can establish an encampment there under total concealment."

Ignis clenched his fists, examining the enemy ships with tactical precision.

"Imperial ironclads boast impenetrable belt armor, but their top decking is notoriously vulnerable to plunging kinetic fire. If we strike them from the heights, we can cave in their boiler rooms."

Altering their trim under the cover of sea mist, the companions dropped anchor upon the gravel sandbar of Gull Crag. Though an arid, forbidding rock shelf battered by howling surf, the shoreline

was littered with colossal oak timbers, shattered keels, and heaps of massive bull kelp washed ashore from centuries of shipwrecks.

Slamming his massive double-bitted battleaxe into the sand, Grimli the dwarven smith burst into a roaring laugh.

"Bwahaha! The sea gods have delivered the finest siege timber right to our doorsteps! Look at these seasoned oak ribs and dense ironwood spars! Give this old dwarf half a day, and I shall erect a triple-torsion counterweight catapult capable of cracking a citadel wall!"

Drawing his silver dagger to strip the briny bark from the timbers, Kadan joined the work.

"Lead the way, Master Grimli. I will shape the mortises and drive the locking wedges."

Ignis gathered granite stones to construct a makeshift forge, kindling his immaculate white flame to smelt discarded anchor chains into heavy iron axle bearings.

"I will fuse these iron links into balanced rotating spindles. We will give those imperial tin cans an iron greeting they will never forget."

Weaving the thick, fibrous bull kelp into high-tensile torsion cords, Cilia infused the fibers with elasticity through wind mana. Under the unified labor of the three youths and the master dwarven smith, the colossal siege engine rapidly took form upon the cliffs.

By the time the crimson sun dipped toward the waves, a magnificent thirty-foot counterweight catapult stood poised upon the highest precipice of Gull Crag. Massive basalt boulders were quarried as ammunition, upon which Cilia carved frost runes designed to shatter into concussive shards of razor ice upon detonation.

Checking the ratchet gears of the winch, Grimli clapped Kadan's broad shoulder.

"Kadan, lad, your master Aleksandar and I built just such a siege thrower amidst the blizzards of the First Crusade twenty winters ago. That stubborn knight not only wielded a shield like a mountain, but he also had the finest hands for timber and stonework I ever saw. Watching your hammer work today, I know his craft lives proudly in your blood."

Resting against his shield, Kadan gazed across the sunset swells with a serene smile.

"Master Aleksandar taught me that craft is never about senseless destruction, but the manifestation of wisdom to protect the vulnerable. This catapult is not a weapon of slaughter, but the key to open a path of life for our people."

Coating the throwing basket with sanctifying fire, Ignis spoke in quiet reverence.

"The road once walked by father Balian and uncle Aleksandar... is now ours to complete."

Just then, alarm klaxons blared across the strait as two swift imperial scouting pinnaces detected the activity upon the crag, surging forward with archers nocking fire arrows.

Sweeping her Jade Staff, Cilia conjured dense oceanic fog around the heights.

"I will shroud the peak in mist to blind their bowmen! Stand ready!"

As milky-white fog swallowed the rock shelf, Kadan gripped the release lever with steady nerves.

"Target: imperial flagship engine bay, three thousand paces ahead!"

Grimli hammered down the locking dog.

"Loose the stone, lad!"

Boom!

With a concussive crack of bending timber, the catapult arm cleaved through the air, hurling the frost-inscribed basalt monolith into the twilight sky. Like a roaring meteor, the projectile arced over the channel, crashing dead-center through the armored deck of the lead imperial ironclad.

Crr-aaash!

The thick iron plate buckled like parchment as the frost runes detonated in an apocalyptic freezing blast. The arcane steam boilers ruptured in cascading detonations, vomiting black smoke as the flagship tilted violently onto its beam ends.

In rapid succession, the second and third projectiles slammed squarely into the cliffside ballista towers. Hundreds of tons of pulverized granite cascaded into the sea, burying the imperial artillery beneath landslides.

With the ironclads crippled and the gun towers silenced, the passage through the Siren Strait lay wide open.

From the hundreds of flower boats holding position offshore erupted a deafening roar of triumph. Hoisting his sails, Rondol sounded the conch horn to signal the general advance.

Standing beside the timber catapult, Kadan, Ignis, and Cilia watched the refugee flotilla glide safely through the gap, letting out long breaths of relief.

Passing a leather flask of potent dwarven ale to Kadan, Grimli barked a hearty chuckle.

"Magnificently done, children! The first iron gate is shattered! Now let us march to the secret grottos of Mount Dragonhorn and reclaim the ancestral heritage left by our forebears!"

Taking a deep draught, Kadan nodded firmly.

"Forward, companions. The dawn of the continent is at hand."

Leaving Gull Crag in their wake, the companions resumed their resolute voyage toward the foothills of Mount Dragonhorn.

CHAPTER 23

Episode 23 · Records of the Grotto

Part 1 · Episode 23 of 40

Having safely breached the Siren Strait, the companions reached the foothills of Mount Dragonhorn, a rugged coastal mountain range towering along the continental mainland. Jagged black granite cliffs cleaved into the sky like the spine of an ancient dragon, and each time violent swells crashed against the stone, concussive booms echoed through showers of crystalline sea spray. Accessible only during low tide, the yawning mouth of a submerged sea cave lay concealed beneath dense carpets of black moss and barnacles, entirely invisible to passing imperial patrols. It was the legendary Dragon Grotto—the secret redoubt where the Arcane Holy Knights had established their rear headquarters during the First Crusade two decades ago.

Limping forward on his timber pegleg, Rondol ran his fingers along a fractured crevice at the cavern threshold.

"This is the threshold. Twenty winters ago, Lord Balian and Sir Aleksandar slipped through imperial cordons to shelter thousands of starving refugees in these vaults. The subtle resonance of the Holy Knights' warding mana still lingers amidst the rock."

Bracing his unadorned iron shield, Kadan took the lead into the gloom. The interior was remarkably cool and tranquil, shielded from the coastal tempest. Phosphorescent lichen clinging to the stalactites overhead cast soothing azure luminescence, illuminating an ancient flagstone passage.

Kindling a gentle wind lantern at the head of her Jade Staff, Cilia examined the subterranean architecture.

"Ancient wind wards etched into the stone walls are still active. They function as a screening matrix, neutralizing imperial tracking cantrips."

Touching a weathered emblem of the White Flame Order carved into the stone, Ignis swallowed hard.

"Somewhere in this vault... lie the personal records penned by my father."

Entering the great central rotunda, a colossal round stone table encircled by twelve high-backed chairs greeted the companions. Though fine dust coated the granite, an ornate iron lockbox resting upon the table remained pristine and unblemished, preserved by an ancient kinetic barrier.

Stepping forward, Kadan carefully disengaged the arcane locking mechanism. Within lay thick vellum campaign journals bound in cured leather, accompanied by classified tactical diagrams of the imperial palace's subterranean aqueducts.

With trembling fingers, Kadan opened the first volume. Written across the yellowed parchment in bold, commanding strokes was the familiar hand of Master Aleksandar.

'First Crusade Expedition Log. Chronicler: Aleksandar. May the Light grant that the blades and shields in our hands never become instruments of tyranny, but remain a steadfast bulwark for the vulnerable. High Minister Lucian has surrendered his soul to the shadows of the Nine Shadows Codex; my sworn brother Balian and I bury the untainted truth within this cavern to preserve the final hearthfire of the continent.'

Tears welled in Kadan's eyes as he read his master's words.

"Master Aleksandar foresaw everything from the very beginning. He knew that even if they were branded traitors and driven to their graves, they had to preserve the beacon of truth for the generations to come."

Cilia placed a comforting hand upon his shoulder.

"His noble spirit has survived inside these cold stone walls, guiding our steps to this very threshold."

Meanwhile, Ignis lifted a slender leather ledger resting at the bottom of the chest. It was a secret operational diary kept by his father, Paladin Balian. Detailed within were the security rotation schedules of the capital, the subterranean waterways beneath the cathedral, and the layout of Lucian's subterranean 'Alchemy Dungeons' where innocent citizens were subjected to forbidden mana extraction.

Horror and fury twisted Ignis's features.

"A massive subterranean dungeon was hidden directly beneath the capital cathedral... Lucian imprisoned dissenting nobles and scholars there, injecting them with Medusa Gorgo's necrotic venom to synthesize monstrous abominations! My father was condemned to the sulfur mines because he attempted to demolish that hellish laboratory!"

Ignis slammed his fist into the stone table, unheeding of the blood welling from his knuckles.

"While my father bled in chains, I patrolled those gilded corridors playing the obedient soldier for his torturers... How can I ever wash away such disgraceful blindness!"

Kadan gripped Ignis's arm with unwavering strength.

"Do not torment yourself, Ignis. Uncle Balian left this blueprint not so you would weep over the past, but so your hands could shatter those iron gates. Now we finish the work they began."

Suddenly, a mournful shriek echoed from the ceiling stalactites as violet vapor seeped through the cracks. Twelve necrotic wraiths planted decades ago by Medusa Gorgo to desecrate the sanctuary awakened, their serpent tails and skeletal maws snapping with venomous malice.

Bracing his iron shield, Kadan channeled star-breathing into an impenetrable bulwark.

"Vile apparitions shall never defile this sacred haven!"

A brilliant sheet of celestial starlight erupted from Kadan's shield, blowing back the toxic miasma. Vaulting forward, Ignis channeled his immaculate white flame along his weapon, incinerating the necrotic cores of the apparitions in rapid succession.

"Begone, remnants of the shadow!"

Sweeping her Jade Staff, Cilia conjured vacuum blades that cleanly severed the remaining specters. Confronted by the unified wrath of the three youths, the shadows dissolved into white ash within minutes, returning serene tranquility to the cavern.

As they cleared the dais, Cilia discovered a delicate jade key nestled in the lining of the chest, engraved with the intertwined emblems of the Holy Order and Whispering Wind Island.

"This is the key to the Sealed Arsenal deeper within the grotto, where ancestral relics forged for the final campaign are enshrined."

Adjusting his silver dagger, Kadan nodded with grim focus.

"To shatter Lucian's legions, we must elevate our strength. Let us claim our forebears' legacy."

United in purpose, the companions took up the jade key and marched toward the massive adamantine gates sealed within the deepest recess of the mountain.

CHAPTER 24

Episode 24 · The Sealed Chamber

Part 1 · Episode 24 of 40

Reaching the deepest cul-de-sac of the Dragon Grotto, the companions stood before a colossal adamantine portal carved into the living rock face. Towering scores of fathoms into the gloom, the gate was intricately inscribed with the sacred litanies of the Holy Order, the swirling glyphs of the wind, and the roaring sigils of the White Flame. At the portal's center rested three circular indentations radiating celestial starlight, verdant jade, and pure sanctified fire, denoting an ancient elemental seal that no physical crowbar could ever breach.

Cilia rested her staff against the door, sensing the intricate mana conduits.

"This is the Tripartite Seal of the Sworn Brothers. It yields only when the pure faith of the Holy Knights, the noble royal lineage of the winds, and the sanctified flame of redemption resonate in absolute harmony. Our mana frequencies must synchronize to the exact heartbeat."

Unslinging his iron shield, Kadan stepped before the starlight socket.

"The covenant forged between Master Aleksandar, Uncle Balian, and Queen Sylphid lives on in this stone."

Ignis stepped before the flame socket, his head held high.

"With the fire of an unyielding spirit seeking true atonement, I offer my strength."

Exchanging glances of profound trust, the three youths pressed their palms into the three respective sockets.

"Now!"

At Kadan's command, a torrent of mana surged forth. From Kadan's fingertips flowed pristine starlight honed across northern tundras; from Cilia's palms poured life-giving gale mana; and from Ignis's grasp roared molten white fire that purged all impurity.

The three elemental streams raced along the carved circuitry in dazzling brilliance.

Cra-aaack!

Centuries of slumber ended as titanic adamantine gears groaned in thunderous synchrony. The massive gates parted, unleashing a cascade of ancient temple frankincense and pure, revitalizing mana that filled the grotto like a waterfall.

Within lay a magnificent vaulted sanctuary of white marble. Enshrined atop the central altar was an imposing defensive relic carved from the fossilized jaw of an ancient wyrm: the legendary Dragon Breaker shield reinforcement armature. Flanking the relic rested Paladin Balian's sanctified breastplate and Master Gawain's wind cloak.

With reverent steps, Kadan approached the altar, lifting the Dragon Breaker armature and affixing it onto the face of his unadorned iron shield.

Clang!

As if forged together at the dawn of time, the dragonbone armature fused seamlessly with the iron rim, erupting in blinding golden brilliance. Raised relief of dragon scales and the holy cross blossomed across the face, multiplying the shield's kinetic deflection and mana capacity a hundredfold. A profound pulse of celestial mana coursed through Kadan's arms into his spirit.

Ignis breathed in awe.

"Magnificent... Master Aleksandar's shield has reclaimed its legendary glory. No siege cannon in the empire can breach that bulwark."

Smiling, Cilia retrieved a pair of ancient gale-rune earrings that amplified atmospheric resonance.

"The final armaments prepared by our parents are assembled."

Suddenly, the heavy stomp of iron greaves and violent battle cries shattered the peace. Thirty elite shock troopers of Lucian's 'Iron Hounds' burst into the chamber, led by Commander Barto wielding an immense two-handed warhammer.

Barto sneered in feral delight.

"The northern rats unearthed the vault for us! Surrender the relics and offer your necks!"

Leaping into the air, Barto brought his crushing hammer down toward Kadan's skull with world-shattering momentum.

Kadan stood immovable, raising the newly forged Dragon Breaker shield to meet the blow with star-breathing.

Boom!

The moment hammer struck shield, a golden kinetic shockwave detonated across the chamber. Barto's iron hammer shattered into a thousand jagged fragments, and the concussive backlash hurled the commander against the basalt wall, vomiting blood. Caught in the radial shockwave, the thirty shock troopers were swept off their feet like dry leaves.

Ignis and Cilia swept forward, neutralizing the disoriented vanguard in seconds. In a single decisive exchange, the empire's elite heavy infantry was utterly dismantled.

Leaving the broken weapons in their wake, the companions inspected the rear portal. Beyond lay a forgotten aqueduct leading directly into the vaults beneath the grand cathedral of the imperial capital.

Clasping his reinforced shield, Kadan spoke with immovable resolve.

"Our preparations are complete. Through these waterways, we march into the heart of the empire."

Cilia gripped her staff with quiet fury.

"In the cathedral above, Lucian is preparing a coerced wedding to consolidate his tyrannical usurpation. We shall expose his treachery before the eyes of the entire realm."

Ignis clenched his fists, holy fire burning in his gaze.

"I will personally dismantle the empire's hypocrisy. Forward, my brothers!"

Adorned in ancestral relics and bound by sacred oaths, the three companions charged into the subterranean waterway, sounding the overture that would tear open the continent's darkest night.

CHAPTER 25

Episode 25 · The False Wedding

Part 1 · Episode 25 of 40

Soaring high above the imperial metropolis of Lighthaven, the Grand Cathedral of White Marble appeared cloaked in dazzling festive grandeur. From every vaulted spire fluttered crimson silk tapestries bearing the imperial crest, while within the nave, thousands of gilded candelabras cast shimmering radiance across the polished marble flags. Yet beneath this extravagant facade lay an atmosphere of suffocating dread. Stationed in every shadowed alcove stood imperial shock guards and black-robed inquisitors, eyeing the gathered aristocracy with predatory vigilance.

The ceremony was a grotesque political farce manufactured by High Minister Lucian. By coercing a forced union between his puppet cousin and the captured elven noblewoman, Lady Sylvia, Lucian intended to legitimize his usurpation of the eastern seaboard and the Whispering Wind alliance.

Slipping through the throng of commoners outside the cathedral doors were two figures robed in rustic northern minstrel tunics: Kadan, his brow concealed beneath a thick fur cowl, and Cilia, veiled in fine northern silk.

Whispering beneath her veil, Cilia noted with sharp eyes.

"Upon Lady Sylvia's wrists are mana shackles inscribed with Medusa Gorgo's puppet curse. They paralyze the spirit, forcing her hands to sign the blood covenant against her will."

Kadan touched the contours of the Dragon Breaker shield beneath his mantle.

"Ignis has infiltrated the belfry to sever the alarm ropes. The instant the ceremony reaches its peak and Lucian's guard slackens, we strike the high altar."

A thunderous overture from the great pipe organ filled the vaulted cathedral as the false wedding commenced. Draped in opulent scarlet clerical vestments and bearing the archiepiscopal staff, Minister Lucian strode onto the high pulpit, an arrogant sneer curling his lips.

"Citizens of the empire! Today, through this sacred bond, all embers of northern sedition are extinguished forever! Let Lady Sylvia sign the blood covenant in humble obedience to the throne!"

Inquisitors seized Sylvia's hands, forcing a poisoned quill into her trembling fingers while silent tears tracked down her pale cheeks.

In that fatal heartbeat, the massive stained-glass rose window high above shattered into a shower of crystalline shards. Having disabled the alarms, Ignis descended upon a severed bell rope, unleashing a barrage of immaculate white firebolts directly into the pulpit.

Boom!

The pulpit exploded into kindling, setting Lucian's vestments ablaze as screams of panic consumed the nave.

Landing gracefully upon the altar rail, Ignis unleashed a lion's roar.

"Deceive the realm no longer with your cowardly lies, butcher Lucian! The true fire of the White Flame Order has arrived to deliver your judgment!"

Clutching his smoldering robes, Lucian shrieked in terror.

"Traitorous dogs! Guards, cut them down! Drown this altar in northern blood!"

As dozens of heavy cataphracts surged toward the dais with drawn broadswords, Kadan cast aside his minstrel disguise, striding forward as the golden cross of the Dragon Breaker shield blazed to life.

Slamming his shield against the marble steps, Kadan anchored his stance.

Boom!

An earthquake of kinetic force buckled the flagstones, blasting the charging cataphracts headlong into the air. Shielding Lady Sylvia behind his immovable frame, Kadan deflected a barrage of throwing spears into the vaulted ceiling.

"Not a single foot shall touch this innocent soul!"

Simultaneously, Cilia swept her Jade Staff, conjuring razor winds that neatly severed the puppet shackles binding Sylvia's wrists with a metallic chime.

Tears spilling down her cheeks, Sylvia looked upon her deliverers in awe.

"Knights of the Light... Princess Cilia... You have come for me..."

The cathedral erupted into a battleground of truth against tyranny. Witnessing the ancient cross of the Holy Order and Ignis's sanctifying flames, the gathered citizens and lesser nobles stirred in turbulent realization.

"That crest... The Arcane Holy Knights have returned!"

"Commander Ignis fights against the court's assassins!"

Terrified by the rising tide of public revolt, Lucian fled toward the private iron sally port behind the altar under heavy escort.

Lucian shrieked over his shoulder into the gloom.

"Artus! Tear those miserable vermin limb from limb!"

From the subterranean crypts beneath the altar radiated the freezing chill of death as a colossal figure clad in cracked obsidian plate emerged: Death Knight Artus. His crimson visor flared with baleful malice, brandishing his broken runic greatsword.

Stepping forward, Kadan braced the Dragon Breaker shield against the undead champion.

"Abandoned by the tyrant you serve like a discarded puppet. But this shield shall never yield before your defiled blade!"

Artus's obsidian blade crashed against Kadan's guard with cataclysmic fury, yet the reinforced dragonbone armor absorbed the death magic without flinching, hurling the death knight backward with concussive force. Ignis unleashed a torrent of holy fire, scorching Artus's pauldrons and forcing the fiend to retreat into the shadows, bolting the iron gate behind him.

Though Lucian had fled into the inner citadel, the cathedral was liberated. Weeping in gratitude, citizens and nobles surrounded the three heroes with thunderous cheers. The false wedding was smashed, and the empire's crimes were laid bare before the realm.

Ascending the altar steps, Cilia raised her Jade Staff before the multitude.

"People of the capital! Kneel no longer before Lucian's falsehoods and terror! Rise with us to reclaim true peace and honor for this continent!"

A roar of thousands echoed through the rafters, shaking the citadel to its foundations.

Kadan clasped Ignis's forearm, their eyes fixed upon the inner palace gates.

"Only one door remains. Let us march into the inner court and end this darkness forever."

The final avenue of liberation lay wide open before them.

CHAPTER 26

Episode 26 · Open Door, Closed Heart

Part 1 · Episode 26 of 40

Word of the grand cathedral's liberation spread like wildfire across the imperial capital of Lighthaven. Merchants and dockworkers who had endured decades under tyranny poured into the avenues bearing blazing pine torches, and amidst the roaring acclamation of the populace, the Sun Gate—the first perimeter portal of the inner citadel—was forced wide open. Yet beyond the shattered iron gates, the inner palaces presented an uncanny, necrotic gloom. Fountains in the grand plaza pooled with foul, bubbling sulfur wastewater instead of clear springs, and from every marble colonnade, flocks of ominous black ravens tainted by the Nine Shadows Codex took flight. Though the physical gates had fallen, the hardened hearts of the imperial aristocracy, steeped in terror and tyranny, remained sealed behind stone walls.

Bracing his Dragon Breaker shield, Kadan surveyed the parapets with sharp eyes.

"The iron gate has fallen, but the battle is far from won. Lucian has entrenched himself within the Obsidian Spire of the inner keep, preparing a fanatical last stand."

Lifting her Jade Staff, Cilia inhaled the chilly night air, her brow furrowing in distaste.

"Scarcely any living mortal aura lingers within these walls. The courtiers and shock guards have been poisoned by Medusa Gorgo's necrotic venom, reduced to mindless marionettes devoid of human sentiment."

Gazing upon the scorched guard barracks where he had once trained, Ignis spoke in solemn grief.

"The palace gardens where I played as a boy have rotted into a festering pit... It tears at my heart that I must shatter the memories of my youth to deliver judgment."

Kadan placed a firm hand upon Ignis's shoulder.

"New flesh can never bloom until the necrotic gangrene is carved away. Forward, Ignis."

Advancing into the central courtyard, a gilded balcony door creaked open, revealing Count Balthazar, commander of the inner palace guard and Lucian's cousin. Black serpentine runes coiled around Balthazar's throat, and his eyes burned with madness.

Clutching the railing, Balthazar laughed maniacally.

"Insolent commoners and turncoat knights! How dare you set foot in the imperial gardens! Tonight, your severed heads shall fertilize my rose beds!"

With a snap of his fingers, the marble flags parted, unleashing three armored Chimeras engineered through Gorgo's forbidden arts. With lion torsos, viper tails, and black-iron scales, the roaring monstrosities charged forward, spitting corrosive acid.

Wielding his iron weapon, Ignis stepped forward.

"Count Balthazar! You, who taught me swordsmanship in my youth, have fallen into this abominable madness! Cast down your steel and defile the empire's honor no longer!"

Balthazar sneered in contempt.

"Honor is merely the excuse of the vanquished! Power alone is the absolute law of this realm!"

The chimeras lunged, their iron-plated claws cleaving through the air with concussive snaps.

Without hesitation, Kadan anchored his Dragon Breaker shield, unleashing star-breathing.

Boom!

The beast's massive claws slammed into the dragonbone plate, only to be pulverized by the shield's golden kinetic backlash. Twisting his guard upward, Kadan struck the lead chimera's jaw, sending the titan tumbling backward.

Vaulting from Kadan's flank, Ignis cleaved through the air.

"Holy flame of purification, grant peace to these corrupted beasts!"

A crescent of pure white fire severed the necks of the chimeras, vaporizing the necrotic corruption into plumes of clean white steam. Simultaneously, Cilia swept her Jade Staff, conjuring a violent whirlwind that collapsed the marble balcony beneath Balthazar's boots.

Crashing onto the flagstones, Balthazar lay mortally wounded, coughing black blood.

Kneeling beside his former mentor, Ignis spoke through clenched teeth.

"Why... Why did you surrender your soul to Lucian's deceit, Count? Did you not teach me that a true knight is a shield for the weak?"

Trembling, Balthazar gasped in ragged breaths.

"Ignis... Minister Lucian is no mere conspirator... Behind him stands the true archduke of the abyss, Belphegor... Tomorrow at midnight... In the Jade Council... The emperor's soul will be offered as a blood sacrifice..."

With those final words, Balthazar expired, the serpent runes dissolving into thin smoke.

Cilia closed the fallen nobleman's eyes with a gentle wind prayer.

"The tragedy of those whose fear locked their hearts in darkness."

Tightening his grip on his shield, Kadan spoke with unwavering resolve.

"Tomorrow at midnight, the council will attempt the dark coronation. We must seize the barrier tower before the blood sacrifice begins."

With the courtyard secured, volunteer militias from the cathedral took up defensive perches along the parapets. Rondol and Grimli arrived with fresh supplies, fortifying the forward breach.

Gathered around a small brazier beneath the shadow of the Obsidian Spire, the three companions studied the palace blueprints.

Touching the scars across his palms, Ignis whispered into the night.

"Tomorrow night, everything concludes. Even if my life is extinguished, I will deliver the emperor and our people from the abyss."

Touching the crimson knot of his silver dagger, Kadan replied.

"We shall live through the storm together, Ignis. When the dawn breaks, we will look upon a realm where children smile without fear."

Clasping hands in an unbreakable vow, the three youths stood ready for the fateful night.

CHAPTER 27

Episode 27 · Between Two Promises

Part 1 · Episode 27 of 40

As midnight approached, the gardens of the inner citadel fell into an uncanny, breathless stillness. Though the fires of daytime skirmishes had subsided, the sharp chill seeping through the nocturnal mist prickled the skin like needles. Standing upon the marble terrace overlooking the capital, Kadan gazed up into the northern firmament, where the North Star shone with crystal clarity—the very constellation he had contemplated alongside Master Aleksandar across the snowy wastes of his youth.

Quiet footsteps stirred behind him as Cilia approached, carrying two steaming silver goblets of wild mountain mint tea.

Offering a cup to Kadan, Cilia smiled gently.

"Sleep eludes you, Kadan? Tomorrow night, eighteen winters of bitter vengeance will reach their conclusion, yet your shoulders remain as steadfast as northern granite."

Sipping the warm tea, Kadan replied in a quiet, measured cadence.

"I was thinking of the sacred vows I pledged to Master Aleksandar. That steel is never an instrument of dominion, but a shield to dry the tears of the suffering. And... the fraternal oath I shared with Ignis."

Leaning against the balustrade, Cilia caressed the night air with her fingers.

"You constantly shoulder the covenants of others, Kadan. Where does your own heart's longing reside?"

A faint, tender smile touched Kadan's lips as he looked down upon his battered iron shield.

"My wish is humble. When this war ends, I wish to return to my master's resting place in the northern wildlands, repair the fallen fences, and sow barley in the dormant fields. To kindle a warm hearthfire where weary wanderers shivering from the cold can always find shelter. That is the only peace I desire."

Cilia's eyes softened under the moonlight.

"A warm hearthfire... How wonderfully like you, Kadan. If so, when the peace is won, will you invite me to sit beside that northern hearth? I shall bring the fragrant lily oil of Whispering Wind Island to sweeten the air of your timber cabin."

Meeting her gaze with deep sincerity, Kadan nodded.

"I promise, Cilia. When spring arrives, we will watch the green barley sprout through the snow together."

A tender, sacred silence lingered between them under the silver moon, binding their spirits in quiet trust.

Soon, the heavy scrape of boots broke the reverie as Ignis joined them upon the terrace. Robed in a simple leather arming doublet, he carried the weathered wooden horse toy carved by his father Balian before his imprisonment.

Sitting beside the brazier, Ignis offered a wry, sorrowful smile.

"I trust I am not intruding upon your peace."

Handing him a cup of tea, Kadan shook his head.

"Never, brother. We were reviewing the infiltration route into the council chamber."

Caressing the carved mane of the toy horse, Ignis spoke in solemn resolution.

"Tomorrow night, I will settle the final debt with Lucian. To atone for the infamy forced upon my father and the innocent blood shed by my steel, I will extinguish Lucian's abyssal rites, even at the cost of my very breath."

Kadan frowned, his voice firm with reprimand.

"Speak not of throwing away your life. We fight so that all three of us may walk into the dawn together."

Shaking his head, Ignis withdrew a slender glass phial from his tunic. Suspended within was a miniature ember of pure white fire, pulsing with the gentle rhythm of a living heartbeat.

Ignis pressed the glass ember into Kadan's palm.

"This is the White Glass Ember, bound to my life's mana. Tomorrow, Lucian will prime the Abyssal Core beneath the throne. To shatter that core, it must be neutralized by the sacred bloodline of the White Flame."

When Kadan tried to return the phial, Ignis held his wrist in an unyielding grip.

"Listen to me, Kadan. You are the immovable shield of this continent. Cilia is the wind queen who will guide the new dawn. But I am the last scion of a corrupted court, whose duty is to burn away the sins of the past. If the worst befalls me... hold this ember close, survive, and protect the world in my stead."

Tears welled in Cilia's eyes as she cried out.

"No, Ignis! A victory bought with your martyrdom is no true salvation! We must return together!"

Smiling with profound gentleness, Ignis replied softly.

"My thanks, princess. But a knight knows the hour when he must stand without retreating."

Deep in the night, the three youths shared the dying warmth of the brazier.

Touching the glass ember pulsing against his breast, Kadan bore the staggering weight of three immense covenants: his vow to Master Aleksandar, his promise of spring to Cilia, and the tragic pledge entrusted by his brother.

Embracing the Dragon Breaker shield, Kadan closed his eyes in prayer.

"Whatever destiny awaits, this shield shall never surrender the lives of those I love."

Beyond the horizon, the first faint gray of dawn stirred, heralding the fateful day that would decide the fate of the realm.

CHAPTER 28

Episode 28 · The Jade Council Revolt

Part 1 · Episode 28 of 40

As midnight descended, the Jade Council Hall of the Imperial Palace was consumed by a tempest of catastrophic black mana. Enshrined atop the high dais where the thrones of past emperors had rested for centuries floated the forbidden relic of the Nine Shadows Codex: the Abyssal Core, pulsing with sickening crimson veins. Bound in dark mana chains, the unconscious elderly emperor hung suspended as a blood sacrifice, while spellbound senators and nobles chanted dissonant, guttural hymns in vacant delirium.

Stepping from the shadows of the dais in flowing crimson vestments, High Minister Lucian raised the desecrated Sovereign Blade bestowed by the demon prince Belphegor.

Lucian bellowed in manic ecstasy.

"The hour has arrived! With the emperor's blood, the gates of the abyss shall open, and I shall reign as the immortal sovereign of the new world!"

In that fatal breath, the massive stained-glass dome high above detonated into a shower of crystalline shards as three figures dropped from the ceiling like thunderbolts.

Slamming his Dragon Breaker shield against the altar steps, Kadan detonated a concussive shockwave of golden starlight.

Boom!

The kinetic backlash rent the dais, snapping the sacrificial chains binding the emperor. Sweeping forward with her Jade Staff, Cilia scooped the monarch into an azure wind gale, depositing him safely behind the front ranks.

Snarling in fury, Lucian brandished his blade.

"Insolent vermin! Death Knight Artus, tear them limb from limb!"

Summoned from the crypts, Artus charged with his broken obsidian greatsword, unleashing cleaves meant to split mountains. Yet Kadan angled the curved dragonbone plate of his shield with star-breathing, redirecting the shearing force into empty air. The deflected shockwave shattered colossal marble pillars, yet Kadan's guard remained impenetrable.

Brandishing his weapon, Ignis charged directly toward Lucian.

"Lucian! Your vile tyranny ends tonight!"

Ignis's pure white fire collided with Lucian's necrotic shields, filling the hall with blinding brilliance and suffocating heat. Cilia swept her staff, systematically severing the ley lines powering the inquisitors' wards.

Driven into a corner, utter madness flared in Lucian's eyes.

"Bwahaha! Do you think you have triumphed? Then let this entire palace burn to ash in the abyss!"

Slashing his palm across the blade, Lucian drove his bloodied steel straight into the heart of the Abyssal Core.

Cra-aaack!

The core went critical, expanding into an apocalyptic black sun that began consuming the hall's pillars. Space warped violently, initiating a cataclysmic dimensional collapse capable of vaporizing every living soul across the metropolis.

Kadan planted his boots forward, shouting over the roar.

"Fall back behind my shield! I will hold the line!"

Yet the scale of the impending detonation defied mortal containment. Unless an elemental champion entered the epicenter to neutralize the mana feedback with his own life essence, tens of thousands of citizens in the plazas outside would be obliterated.

In that heart-stopping instant, Ignis shoved Kadan backward with sudden, desperate strength.

"No, Kadan! Your shield must protect the future! This fire exists to burn away my sins!"

Kadan cried out in sheer agony.

"Ignis! Stop! In the name of our fathers, do not do this!"

Cilia shrieked, reaching out with all her might, but Ignis never looked back. He threw his living body into the raging vortex of the Abyssal Core.

From Ignis's spirit erupted a supernova of pure, immaculate white fire brighter than the sun. The ancient royal bloodline of the White Flame ignited in transcendent sacrifice, systematically

neutralizing the necrotic singularity.

Turning his head through the flames, Ignis offered the radiant, innocent smile of his childhood, speaking his final words over the roaring tempest.

"Kadan... my brother... Tell Master Aleksandar and father Balian... that Ignis was never a coward at the end... Cilia... watch over Kadan..."

BOOOOM!

A blinding sheet of pure white starlight engulfed the entire palace. Wrapped in the holy flames of martyrdom, the Abyssal Core shattered into harmless dust, yet the physical vessel of the young hero dissolved into a shower of celestial light, scattering into the heavens.

"IGNIS————!!"

Kadan's grief-stricken roar rent the collapsing hall.

When the brilliance faded and silence settled over the ruins, only a small mound of white ash remained upon the altar.

Stumbling forward, Kadan dropped to his knees. Miraculously intact amidst the embers rested the carved wooden horse toy and the White Glass Ember, glowing with gentle, eternal warmth.

Clutching the relics against his chest, Kadan wept racking sobs, his tears darkening the ash.

Beside him, Cilia sank to the flagstones, biting her lip in agonizing sorrow.

Mortally wounded by the backlash, Lucian had fled through the subterranean conduits, while Artus dissolved into the shadows.

Stepping forward, the rescued emperor laid a trembling hand upon Kadan's shoulder.

"A noble knight's soul... has preserved the realm and its people..."

Gripping his silver dagger, Kadan lifted his face. Through the tears in the young warrior's eyes blazed an unbreakable, eternal resolve of iron.

"Ignis... Your sacrifice shall never be in vain. Upon the world you preserved with your life, I swear to erect an enduring peace."

Before the solemn martyrdom of the young hero, the darkest night of the continent was passing into dawn.

CHAPTER 29

Episode 29 · Queen of the Wind

Part 1 · Episode 29 of 40

On the morning following the tragedy at the Jade Council, the skies above Lighthaven hung heavy with gray storm clouds. Though the fires had been extinguished, the crushing sorrow of losing Ignis weighed upon every stone of the grand cathedral and the imperial palace. Standing beside the fountain in the palace courtyard, Kadan held the White Glass Ember, which pulsed with gentle, living warmth against his palm like the steady heartbeat of his fallen brother.

Approaching with her Jade Staff, Cilia stood silently beside him, tears drying upon her pale cheeks.

Cilia whispered softly into the morning draft.

"Holding this glass ember, Ignis's pure spirit speaks clearly to my fingertips. Though his noble sacrifice delivered the capital, the hollow void beside us aches with bitter sorrow."

Adjusting his shield, Kadan nodded with solemn depth.

"Ignis is not dead. The oath he left behind breathes eternally within this ember and within the chambers of our hearts."

At that moment, the high council of senators and the captain of the imperial guard approached, sinking to their knees before Cilia.

Holding aloft an imperial parchment decree, the senate chancellor proclaimed with deep reverence.

"Princess of Whispering Wind Island! By decree of His Imperial Majesty, we humbly petition you to ascend as Regent of the Empire and the Eastern Alliance—the Sovereign Queen of the Winds!"

Across the plaza, thousands of assembled citizens broke into thunderous acclamation, dropping to their knees in tearful entreaty. It was the offer of supreme dominion over the entire continent.

Yet Cilia shook her head gently, extending her hand to raise the chancellor to his feet.

Her voice rang out across the square with crystal clarity.

"Do not address me as Queen. The wind never seats itself upon a throne of stone."

A breathless silence fell upon the multitude.

Raising her Jade Staff, Cilia declared her covenant to the people.

"I seek no gilded crown. A world where every soul draws breath in freedom without the terror of tyrants—that was the true path of the wind envisioned by my mother Sylphid. I shall stand not as an empress above you, but as a sister of the wind who binds up your wounds and marches beside you to the very end."

A roar of tears, cheers, and heartfelt reverence erupted across the metropolis. To reject the imperial crown in favor of walking beside the common folk was the hallmark of true sovereignty.

Kadan looked upon her with profound pride.

"Master Aleksandar and Queen Sylphid smile upon your wisdom from the heavens."

Retiring to the war chamber, Kadan and Cilia convened with Rondol, Grimli, and the Six Masters around the regional charts.

Pointing to the northern passes, Rondol spoke in grim assessment.

"The wounded serpent Lucian has retreated to his final necromantic fortress in the Black Marsh, rallying the remaining legions of Belphegor. But to pursue him, our armies must breach the Four Gates Fortress, where four colossal sluices spew lethal venom."

Grimli slammed his fist onto the oak table.

"A hellish barrier! Acidic mist that dissolves steel plate within minutes. No army can march through that defile."

Taking the White Glass Ember from his coat, Kadan placed it upon the map. Miraculously, the ember cast a slender needle of pure white light pointing toward the northern sluice.

Kadan's eyes sharpened with certainty.

"Ignis is showing us the path. This is the structural flaw in their necrotic conduit."

Leading an elite vanguard, Kadan and Cilia advanced to the northern water gates. Sulfuric fog choked the rocky canyon, and the waterways boiled with violet poison inscribed with Gorgo's necrotic runes.

Surfacing from the venomous swamp, the venom-mistress Arachne sneered with spider-like fangs.

"Fools! A single breath of this miasma dissolves mortal flesh to bone! Your journey ends in this mire!"

A storm of poisoned quills rained from the heights.

Bracing his Dragon Breaker shield, Kadan unleashed the full power of star-breathing.

"This shield shall never yield before any poison!"

The golden aegis deflected the volley harmlessly into the stone. Sweeping her Jade Staff, Cilia conjured an azure gale that purged the violet fog into the upper atmosphere.

With Kadan shattering the central runic conduit with his silver dagger, the boiling toxins neutralized into crystal springs. The first gate swung wide open, revealing the path to the Black Marsh.

Standing beside Kadan, Cilia looked toward the northern horizon.

"Where Ignis's light guides our steps, we walk together until the dawn."

Grasping the warm ember in his pocket, Kadan nodded.

"So long as this fire burns, we shall never lose our way."

United in grief and unwavering resolve, the companions marched toward the final abyss.

CHAPTER 30

Episode 30 · Poison of the Four Gates

Part 1 · Episode 30 of 40

Breaching the outer perimeter, the companions stood before the formidable citadel of the Four Gates—the ancient northern rampart of the empire. Spanning the narrow chasm between sheer granite precipices, four massive black-iron sluice gates vomited waterfalls of corrosive serpentine bile engineered by Medusa Gorgo. Muck rose to the warriors' knees, threatening to swallow their boots, while the stench of burning sulfur and putrefaction filled the air.

Tapping the stone with his hammer, Grimli grimaced in disgust.

"Vile filth! An acidic miasma capable of melting tempered dwarven steel. Breathe a lungful of this vapor, and the strongest warrior will vomit black blood within a mile."

Kadan withdrew the White Glass Ember, holding it in his open palm. Even amidst the toxic murk, the ember radiated pure, immaculate white brilliance, wrapping his skin in soothing warmth.

Fastening fresh comfrey leaves to her staff, Cilia observed with wonder.

"The toxic fumes dare not approach the ember's light. Ignis's sanctified mana encloses us in an invisible sanctuary of pure air."

Bracing his shield, Kadan took the lead.

"Ignis has carved our path. We have no time to delay; we must demolish the four sluice cores in succession."

Reaching the eastern sluice, fifty undead cataphracts clad in rusted plate erupted from the mire, brandishing corroded broadswords in suicidal charges.

Kadan lowered his center of gravity, meeting the charge with the Dragon Breaker shield.

Boom!

The impact shattered the undead blades against the dragonbone rim. Spinning his shield with star-breathing, Kadan pulverized the front ranks in a single concussive sweep. Simultaneously, Rondol brought down a geyser of pressurized water with his iron pegleg, and Gawain sheared the primary control valve with wind blades.

With a dying hiss, the corrosive effluent of the eastern gate ceased.

Rondol barked a hearty laugh.

"Ha! The northern wolf scatters bone-men like autumn leaves! On to the western portal!"

The western sluice was defended by twenty venomous wyverns circling overhead, raining clouds of caustic spores upon the defile.

Hoisting her Jade Staff, Cilia sang an ancient wind hymn to the heavens.

"Spirits of the eastern sea! Cleanse this blight with the silver tempest of the dawn!"

A towering whirlwind erupted from Cilia's boots, reversing the falling spore clouds straight into the wyverns' maws. Paralyzed by their own venom, the beasts tumbled from the sky, where Eliana and Eyla dispatched them with frost arrows.

Kadan leaped onto the parapet, driving his silver dagger into the obsidian mana core, silencing the western sluice in a shower of azure sparks.

At last, the companions arrived before the central northern gate, where General Bargast, Lucian's chief fortress commander, stood atop the iron catwalk. Covered in venomous serpent tattoos, the brute leveled a massive sulfur flamethrower.

Bargast sneered in sadistic triumph.

"Insolent pups! This Four Gates Hellfire melts living stone! Burn to ash and feed the swamp!"

A torrent of liquid hellfire and concentrated venom engulfed the narrow defile.

Kadan braced the Dragon Breaker shield with both hands. Resonating with his heart's resolve, the White Glass Ember within his coat blazed to life, weaving a double aegis of white fire and celestial gold across the shield's face.

BOOM!

The inferno crashed against the bulwark, splitting in two and melting the canyon walls into slag, yet Kadan's boots remained anchored like iron pilings, yielding not a single fraction of an inch.

Roaring with righteous fury, Kadan stepped through the flames.

"So long as we have living warmth to defend, this shield shall never melt!"

Slamming his shield into the machinery, Kadan's strike pulverized the flamethrower and hurled Bargast from the parapet into the chasm below. With a final thrust of his silver dagger, Kadan severed the master chains.

With groaning thunder, all four iron sluices rose, unleashing the pristine mountain reservoirs behind the fortress. A flood of crystalline water rushed through the defile, washing away the corrosive slime and cleansing the putrid swamp into a clear, living lake.

Cheering wildly, thousands of volunteer troops and refugees surged through the liberated gates.

Cilia stepped to Kadan's side, her eyes fixed upon the northern peaks.

"The poison of the Four Gates is cleansed. The final road to the heart of the Black Marsh is open."

Holding the warm ember in his hand, Kadan nodded with unbreakable resolve.

"Following the beacon left by our brother, we march to deliver the final judgment."

Bearing the memories of their forebears and the sacrifice of their comrade, the companions marched forward into the final campaign.

CHAPTER 31

Episode 31 · The Wagered Hand

Part 1 · Episode 31 of 40

Advancing across the northern plains after cleansing the Four Gates, the allied host stood before the Quicksand River, a treacherous watery boundary encircling the outer perimeter of the dreaded Black Marsh. Scores of fathoms wide, the torrent churned with thick, viscous sludge and liquefied sand rather than clean water, harboring bottomless quicksand pits that could swallow supply wagons in seconds. Across the opposite bank rose Lucian's dark citadel amidst rolling storm clouds, yet without specialized shallow-draft craft, crossing was impossible.

Probing the riverbank with his timber pegleg, Rondol clicked his tongue in grim assessment.

"This quicksand river is more foul than any stormy sea. Standard timber cutters will founder within minutes under the weight of the mud. Only the buoyant reed-skiffs crafted by the swamp goblins can navigate this slurry."

Bracing his shield, Kadan examined a crude skull-inscribed marker post.

"I understand a solitary overlord monopolizes all the river barges."

Spitting into the sand, Grimli replied in disgust.

"Bogart, the greedy goblin casino king. Colluding with the imperial court, he extorts fortune from fleeing refugees while hoarding the ferry fleet in his subterranean den. We must confront the cur directly."

Cilia swept her Jade Staff, reading the subterranean drafts with a nod.

"Beneath that shale ledge, I hear the clinking of gold coins and smell roasted fat. That is Bogart's lair."

Infiltrating the cavern den behind the reeds, the companions entered a vast subterranean gambling hall. Hundreds of rough brigands and goblins gathered around dice tables and card games amidst thick clouds of sulfuric tallow smoke. Lounging atop a silk divan at the center sat the corpulent goblin king Bogart, festooned in garish gold jewelry and swigging dwarven stout.

Eyeing Kadan's Dragon Breaker shield with a covetous smirk, Bogart sneered.

"Heh-heh! The northern knight who shattered the palace gates graces my humble den! You desire a hundred reed-skiffs to cross the Quicksand River? But Bogart never parts with his property for free!"

Planting his shield onto the table with a heavy thud, Kadan spoke calmly.

"Name your price. We can compensate you generously in imperial gold."

Juggling two gilded dice in his claws, Bogart's yellow eyes gleamed with malice.

"Gold is boring! Let us wager, knight! If you defeat me in a single throw of the dice, I grant you a hundred skiffs without fee. But if you lose... I shall sever your left arm at the shoulder and mount that legendary shield as the grand trophy of my gambling hall! Do you dare accept the wager?"

Cilia leveled her staff, her voice ringing in anger.

"A despicable cheat! We will not gamble human lives upon a table!"

Yet Kadan raised a calm hand to steady her. Reaching into his coat, he touched the White Glass Ember, which pulsed with rhythmic warmth against his palm. The ember's subtle resonance detected the microscopic magnetic core embedded within Bogart's dice.

Sitting before the stone table, Kadan replied evenly.

"I accept the wager. My shield arm against your fleet. You cast first, and I cast after."

Grinning in cruel triumph, Bogart rattled the dice in a golden cup. Weighted with loadstone to react with a magnetic plate concealed beneath the table, the dice were rigged to land invariably upon double sixes.

Clatter-bang!

Bogart lifted the cup, revealing a perfect pair of sixes.

"Heh-heh-heh! Twelve! An immaculate, unbeatable score! At best, you tie; at worst, you lose! Lay your arm upon the anvil, boy!"

The gathered ruffians roared, drawing rusted daggers, while the Six Masters tensed their weapons.

Unperturbed, Kadan took the golden cup, placing the dice within. As he swirled the dice, he channeled a minute pulse of star-breathing into the metal. The celestial mana vibrated the loadstone, inverting its magnetic polarity.

Boom!

Kadan brought the cup down with decisive force. As the cup rose, the first die rolled true, displaying a clear '6'. The second die, unable to endure the concentrated mana shock, split cleanly in half down its center seam, presenting both a '6' and a '1' facing upward.

A total score of thirteen.

Stunned silence fell across the gambling den.

Kadan declared with tranquil authority.

"My score is thirteen. All pips face the ceiling. The wager is mine."

Bogart's greenish skin paled as his jowls quivered in disbelief.

"Im-impossible! The dice split... A score of thirteen is blasphemy! Guards, butcher them all!"

The ruffians lunged forward, but the Six Masters moved in devastating unison. Grimli's hammer pulverized the stone table, Gawain's wind blades disarmed the thugs, and Kadan pinned Bogart against the rock face with the rim of his shield.

"You played with loaded dice, Bogart. I could sever your head for your fraud, but I grant you your life. Deliver two hundred reed-skiffs to the riverbank at once."

Terrified, the goblin king groveled in the dust.

"Mercy, noble knight! Two hundred skiffs... Three hundred skiffs, anything you desire!"

Within an hour, a grand armada of buoyant reed-skiffs lined the shore, ferrying the entire allied host safely across the quicksand without shedding a drop of blood.

Touching the warm glass ember in his pocket, Kadan gazed toward the distant citadel.

"Ignis, the wisdom you left behind has opened another bloodless path."

Smiling beside him, Cilia gripped her staff.

"Now we march into the heart of the Black Marsh to end Lucian's reign forever."

CHAPTER 32

Episode 32 · Echo of First Love

Part 1 · Episode 32 of 40

Crossing the Quicksand River, the allied host entered the Whispering Willows, an ancient elven grove preserved amidst the desolate rot of the Black Marsh. Thousands of years ago, this sanctuary was where the ancient spirits of the wind and the first high elven sovereigns had pledged their sacred covenants. Silver willow boughs cascaded across placid, glass-like ponds, and bioluminescent fireflies drifted between the leaves like falling starlight. Yet beneath this breathtaking beauty lurked the intoxicating, lethal miasma of Lilith, arch-demon of illusions serving Belphegor.

Cilia paused, embracing the Jade Staff against her breast.

"This is the Silver Willow Garden... where my mother Sylphid and father Aeolus first met in their youth and pledged their eternal love. It is the sacred grove praised in our kingdom's oldest lullabies."

Bracing his shield, Kadan scanned the misty shadows with sharp senses.

"Lethal hallucinatory spores are drifting on the breeze. Ignis's glass ember pulses with warning heat. Maintain utmost vigilance."

Tightening their formation, Grimli and Rondol readied their steel.

"Ancient sanctums make prime nesting grounds for foul phantoms. Keep your boots light."

Reaching the central clearing, the mist thickened into an ethereal emerald palace. Beside a pristine crystal pool sat a radiant woman robed in immaculate white silk, bearing the crest of the Wind Kingdom upon her bodice. Smiling with infinite maternal tenderness, she opened her arms toward Cilia. It was Queen Sylphid, preserved in the prime of her youth.

The spectral queen whispered in a melodious, heartbreaking cadence.

"Cilia... my precious child... How cold and lonely you must have been amidst the harsh tempests of the world... Lay down that heavy staff and rest eternally within your mother's embrace... You need fight no longer..."

Tears spilled from Cilia's eyes as her fingers loosened upon her staff. The deep yearning of eighteen motherless years surged forth like an uncontainable tide.

"Mother... Is it truly you...? Please... do not leave me alone again..."

Spellbound, Cilia took a trembling step toward the apparition.

Just as the phantom slipped a poisoned necrotic dagger from behind her back, her features twisting into a cruel sneer, Kadan sprang forward like a thunderbolt, slamming his Dragon Breaker shield between them.

Boom!

A concussive shockwave shattered the phantom pool, revealing the hideous shadow demon beneath. It was no queen, but Lilith, the soul-devouring illusionist of the Nine Shadows.

Grasping Cilia's trembling shoulders, Kadan shook her with desperate conviction.

"Open your eyes, Cilia! That is not your mother! Queen Sylphid was a valiant sovereign who held her ground to her dying breath to shield her people! She would never counsel you to flee into cowardly illusions!"

Cilia gasped, snapping out of the trance as tears streamed down her cheeks.

"Kadan... I... I faltered for a moment..."

Reaching into his tunic, Kadan placed the warm White Glass Ember into her trembling palm.

"We have an unbroken covenant to fulfill. Remember our promise to watch the green barley sprout through the northern snows together."

The pristine warmth of the ember and Kadan's steadfast presence dispelled the lingering poison in Cilia's spirit. Drawing her reed flute, Cilia raised it to her lips and began playing the primordial wind hymn passed down by her mother: the 'Echo of Purification'.

The clear, celestial notes resonated across the weeping willows. Wherever the melody touched, the dark mist melted away like morning frost, shattering Lilith's illusionary web into glass shards.

Exposed in her true demonic visage, Lilith shrieked in rage, only for Kadan's shield and Rondol's axe to smash her physical form into dust within seconds.

Tranquility returned to the ancient grove as starlight broke through the canopy.

Clasping Kadan's hand, Cilia whispered with profound gratitude.

"Thank you, Kadan. Because you stood beside me, I did not lose my mother's true spirit."

Smiling gently, Kadan replied.

"When you stumble, I shall be your shield; when I weary, your wind shall lift my wings. That is why we walk this road together."

Emerging from the willows, the companions beheld the menacing bulk of the Black Citadel looming at the center of the swamp. The final hour had arrived.

CHAPTER 33

Episode 33 · The Black Marsh

Part 1 · Episode 33 of 40

Clearing the willows, the allied army arrived before the ultimate bastion of imperial corruption: the central fortress of the Black Marsh. Stretching to the horizon lay putrid quagmires and boiling sulfur pools, under skies choked by the necrotic squalls of the Nine Shadows Codex. At the heart of the mire upon a volcanic crag rose the Black Citadel, a titanic obsidian fortress erected by primordial shadow warlords, bristling with legions of undead cataphracts and iron-plated golems.

Bracing his Dragon Breaker shield, Kadan surveyed the formidable ramparts.

"Lucian has marshaled every remaining reserve in the realm. The moat before the gates is a boiling abyss of magma and concentrated venom; a conventional crossing is impossible."

Reading the atmospheric conduits with her staff, Cilia noted with grave urgency.

"Catastrophic mana inversions are building within the foundations. Lucian intends to detonate the continental ley lines, incinerating the land in hellfire."

Grimli honed his twin battleaxes, gritting his teeth in fury.

"No time to dally! We Six Masters will spearhead the assault to bridge that infernal moat!"

Stamping his pegleg, Rondol bellowed with hearty resolve.

"Time for old dogs to blaze their final embers! Follow our charge, young lions!"

The battle horns of the allied host tore through the marsh.

As thousands of volunteers charged across the mud, the citadel's black-iron ballistae and mana cannons opened fire, raining fiery sulfur boulders across the approaches.

Standing at the vanguard, Kadan held his Dragon Breaker shield high, anchoring an impenetrable dome of starlight that deflected the falling siege shot into the swamp.

Behind his bulwark, the Six Masters demonstrated the peerless artistry of seasoned veterans. Grimli pulverized boulders to anchor an ice bridge across the moat, Gawain's wind scythes cleared the battlement gunners, and Eyla and Eliana neutralized the ballista crews with pinpoint frost arrows.

Reaching the iron drawbridge, the massive gates parted, unleashing two gargantuan Bone Drakes animated by the Nine Shadows Codex. The skeletal horrors plunged from the towers, vomiting torrents of caustic dragonfire.

"Scatter!"

Kadan leaped forward, catching the direct blast upon his shield. Molten flames split around the dragonbone plate, scorching his gauntlets, yet his stance held firm.

Seizing the opening, Rondol raised a massive mud spout with his pegleg, throwing the lead drake off balance, while Gawain vaulted overhead to decapitate the beast with an azure wind stroke. Simultaneously, Cilia swept her staff, conjuring a vacuum vortex that smashed the second drake against the granite ramparts.

Breaching the outer lines, the companions stood before the great obsidian gates of the inner keep. Standing atop the parapet, Minister Lucian appeared in flowing crimson vestments, his body warping under demonic possession.

Lucian shrieked in maniacal frenzy.

"Insolent insects! Even gods cannot force these adamantine gates! You shall be entombed alive beneath the mountain!"

Pulling the master lever, Lucian initiated the fortress self-destruct sequence. The foundations groaned as titanic stalactites began crashing from the vaulted ceiling.

Cilia cried out in horror.

"He is bringing down the entire mountain to bury our army!"

In that fatal breath, Kadan raised the White Glass Ember high into the gloom.

The ember resonated with his heart's resolve, firing a beam of pure celestial starlight directly into the gate's runic core. Corrupted by holy fire, the necrotic wards shrieked and dissolved.

Driving his silver dagger into the keystone, Kadan slammed his Dragon Breaker shield into the timbers.

BOOM!

The ancient gates shattered inward with concussive force.

Raising his blade high, Kadan bellowed to the host.

"The gate is broken! Forward, to the heart of the citadel!"

With a roar that shook the swamp, the army poured into the breach, launching the final assault upon the seat of darkness.

CHAPTER 34

Episode 34 · Fallen Wind Isle

Part 1 · Episode 34 of 40

The inner colonnades of the Black Citadel resembled the bowels of the underworld. Burning sulfur boulders rained from the collapsing ceiling, and the flagstones split apart, disgorging geysers of molten magma. Lucian's doomsday runes had destabilized the mountain roots, threatening to entomb the citadel and the allied host beneath millions of tons of granite.

Deflecting a falling boulder with his wind staff, Gawain coughed against the sulfur smoke.

"This is no fortress; it is a mass grave! The madman never intended to survive; he seeks to drag the entire continent into his pyre!"

Channeling her Jade Staff, Cilia strained to hold back the fracturing vault, blood seeping from her lips under the crushing mana strain.

"The subterranean ley lines are snapping like thread... The ceiling cannot endure!"

Kadan raised his Dragon Breaker shield over Cilia and the wounded vanguard.

"Do not despair! Reach the high altar and shatter Lucian's master rune, and the collapse will halt!"

Reaching the central junction, disaster struck: three of the four colossal adamantine support pillars holding the cavern roof fractured in cascading detonations. If the final central pillar collapsed, the entire mountain peak would crush every soul within the citadel.

In that fatal instant, Grimli the dwarven smith burst into a hearty laugh, shouldering his great anvil as he strode toward the buckling pillar.

Driving the anvil beneath the fractured base as a locking wedge, Grimli bellowed.

"Kadan, Cilia! Run to the altar and do not look back! An old blacksmith shall hold up the heavens for his disciples!"

Horrified, Kadan lunged to drag him back.

"Master Grimli, no! If the pillar snaps, there is no escape!"

Eyla the huntress, Rondol the pugilist, Kaze the shadow, and Eliana the herbalist stepped beside Grimli, their weathered faces serene with transcendent peace.

Bracing his pegleg against the shale, Rondol thrust his broad shoulder against the stone.

"For eighteen winters we lived on borrowed time, honoring the fallen Aleksandar and Balian! The hour has come to pass the dawn to our children! Run, Kadan!"

Channeling their life essence into the adamantine stone, the Six Masters wove an impenetrable bulwark of five-element mana, miraculously halting the ceiling's collapse.

Weeping bitterly, Cilia reached out in agony.

"Masters... please come with us! Please!"

Eliana offered a tender, radiant smile.

"Weep not, little princess. Our souls shall dance forever amidst the lilies of the Wind Kingdom... Our reunion with Sir Aleksandar shall be joyous."

Just then, hundreds of abyssal golems breached the rear walls, lunging to slaughter the masters holding the pillar.

Planting his staff into the earth, Gawain turned to Kadan with fierce pride.

"Behold Gawain's final tempest, boy! Leap to the altar!"

Igniting his very soul, Gawain unleashed the forbidden mystery: the 'Divine Gale Gyre'.

A colossal hurricane tore through the hall, pulverizing the golem horde and carving an open passage directly toward the high altar. Stepping into the center of the vortex, Gawain linked hands with Grimli and the other masters, holding the failing pillar firm.

Bloodied but smiling proudly, the masters nodded to Kadan and Cilia.

"We entrust the future to your shield, heir of the Holy Order!"

CRRR-AAASH!

The mountain peak collapsed in an apocalyptic avalanche, burying the central hall beneath hundreds of thousands of tons of granite. The heroic champions passed into legend, shielding their disciples' retreat with their very flesh.

"MASTERS————!!"

Kadan's agonized roar echoed through the stone, yet from beyond the fallen rock wall came only solemn, eternal silence.

At the summit of the cleared stairway stood the Altar of Ruin.

Atop the high throne waited Minister Lucian, his eyes burning with demonic madness as he clutched the blood-stained Nine Shadows Codex.

Drawing his silver dagger, Kadan wiped the tears from his eyes, ascending the altar steps with footsteps heavy as destiny. The sacrifice of the Six Masters and the memory of Ignis ignited within his breast in an eternal flame of iron resolve.

Leveling his Dragon Breaker shield, Kadan proclaimed his judgment.

"The blood of the Six Masters carved this road. Lucian, you shall answer for every crime to the final drop of your blood."

Raising her Jade Staff, Cilia stood beside him.

"In the name of Whispering Wind Island and the Holy Order, your darkness ends tonight."

The final battle for the soul of the continent commenced upon the summit of ruin.

CHAPTER 35

Episode 35 · Mistaken in the Fog

Part 1 · Episode 35 of 40

Breaching the final threshold through the sacrifice of the Six Masters, Kadan and Cilia emerged upon the Phantasm Colonnade encircling the Altar of Ruin. Open to the storm-swept heavens, freezing northern winds howled through the fractured pillars above dizzying chasms plunging thousands of fathoms into the abyss. Choking the suspended flagstone spans was a dense, milky-white fog woven from Medusa Gorgo's necrotic hallucinations and Belphegor's dark sorcery. From the drifting mists echoed the phantom laughter of Grimli, the warm counsel of Gawain, and the familiar cadence of Ignis, testing the young champions' grief.

Touching the White Glass Ember pulsing against his breast, Kadan steadied his breathing.

"Cover your ears, Cilia. Those voices in the fog are not our masters. They are vile phantoms engineered to exploit our sorrow."

Gripping her Jade Staff with both hands, Cilia swallowed her tears.

"I know, Kadan. The spirits of our forebears do not tempt us into weakness; they blow strength into our wings from beyond the veil."

Back to back, the two companions advanced across the fog-shrouded stone bridge.

From the gloom strode a massive, armored figure clad in cracked obsidian plate: Death Knight Artus. Yet within the mist, his shadow fractured into five identical replicas, each bearing the same terrifying mana signature and brandishing broken obsidian greatswords.

Artus's hollow voice echoed simultaneously from every direction.

"Miserable orphans who buried your masters in the stone... The living cannot navigate the labyrinth of the dead. Your hollow convictions shall rot within this fog!"

Five obsidian broadswords slashed downward in unison, targeting Kadan and Cilia from every angle.

Defending against five simultaneous strikes with mortal sight was impossible; vision alone could not distinguish phantom blade from solid steel.

Without hesitation, Kadan closed his eyes.

"Discard visual deception. Master Aleksandar taught me that when the eyes are shuttered, the ear perceives the true pulse of the earth."

Focusing entirely upon star-breathing and the ground beneath his boots, Kadan read the subtle micro-vibrations in the flagstones. Four of the descending blades cleaved only air, but one strike bore the crushing kinetic mass of living stone.

"Found you!"

Snapping his eyes open, Kadan spun his Dragon Breaker shield upward at a forty-five-degree angle.

Boom!

The moment the true blade struck the dragonbone rim, a radial shockwave of golden starlight detonated across the span. The four shadow clones dissolved into wisps of smoke, and the real Artus was hurled backward, vomiting black blood.

Stumbling, the death knight lost his balance.

Seizing the opening, Cilia vaulted overhead with her Jade Staff.

"Blade of the gale, sever the chains of the damned!"

A crescent of pressurized vacuum severed Artus's right arm at the elbow, sending the obsidian greatsword clattering into the chasm below.

Robbed of his weapon, Artus clutched his shattered armor, groaning in human torment as Lucian's controlling curse fractured.

"Lord Lucian... I have failed to breach the knight's shield..."

Retreating through the fog, Artus sealed the inner bronze gates of the sanctum behind him, retreating into the final chamber.

With the phantom fog dispelled, the starlit night sky illuminated the stone bridge.

Before the shattered portal lay the inner sanctuary of the Altar of Ruin, where Lucian channeled the final pages of the Nine Shadows Codex.

Checking the edge of his silver dagger, Kadan turned to Cilia.

"Are you ready, Cilia?"

Wiping the dust from her brow, Cilia smiled with unbreakable resolve.

"Yes, Kadan. Our masters and Ignis march beside us. I fear nothing."

Slamming his Dragon Breaker shield into the bronze gates, Kadan shattered the final locking bar.

Boom!

The doors swung wide, and the two young champions crossed the threshold to face the architect of the realm's long nightmare.

CHAPTER 36

Episode 36 · Map of the Cross-Shaped Scar

Part 1 · Episode 36 of 40

Having fought their way through the suffocating illusions of the misty corridors, Kadan and Princess Cilia at last set foot within the highest sanctum of the Black Citadel—the Starlight Archives, where the empire's darkest arcana had lain interred for centuries. The vaulted ceiling of the circular obsidian gallery opened directly to the heavens, where the frigid constellations of the northern sky poured down their pale luminescence upon a colossal granite altar. Chiseled into the altar's stone in deep relief was the Continental Star Chart, tracing every ancient leyline, ridge, and river across the breadth of the realm.

Though the crushing grief of having lost the Six Masters pressed heavily against their shoulders, neither companion faltered in their stride. The rough calluses on Kadan's forearm gripping the Dragon Breaker shield and the crimson cord binding the Silver Dagger whispered of solemn vows sworn in blood, steadying his resolve against the biting night gale.

Through the chilled fog drifting along the flagstones, the gentle warmth of starlight spirits who had watched over these archives for centuries still lingered. Embedded like luminous constellations into the obsidian walls were the archaic cross-shaped stigmata of the holy order, casting radiant amber beams into the shadows. Kadan brushed his boot against the floor's runic engravings, remembering the footsteps of his fallen mentor.

Princess Cilia stepped toward the star chart, raising her jade staff toward the outer mountain ranges.

> "This chart is the living lifeline of the realm," Cilia whispered softly. "Though Lucian has warped the subterranean leylines through the foul sorcery of the Nine Shadows Codex, once we shatter the core barrier of the central nexus, the earth's innate purification will restore the mana to its pristine flow."

Kadan scrutinized the central coordinates of Lighthaven and the northern expanse of the Elwin fief.

> "Here lies the proof of Lucian's plot to drain the leylines of all seven great sanctuaries through the dark codex. Had our masters not laid down their lives to halt the flow, the continent would have shattered beneath our feet long ago."

As Kadan pressed his gauntleted hand upon the coordinate of Lighthaven, a metallic click echoed through the altar base, and a concealed stone coffer rose smoothly from the floor. Within lay a weathered, blood-crusted leather pouch enclosing an ancient parchment tactical diagram etched with a deep cross-shaped scar.

It was the Map of the Cross-Shaped Scar, drafted twenty winters ago during the First Crusade by Master Aleksandar and Uncle Balian, tracing the sacred stigmata carved across their own chests.

With trembling fingers, Kadan unfurled the yellowed parchment. Upon it, Master Aleksandar's brushstrokes remained as sharp and vivid as iron.

'To my child Kadan. If your eyes read these words, I have already returned to the earth. Yet weep not. Though a paladin's shield must turn to dust, the seed of life shielded beneath its iron shall take root and blossom upon this soil. Lucian's dark wards appear impenetrable, yet when the living warmth of the people dwelling in the four cardinal sanctuaries unites, the dark citadel's core shall crumble like sand.'

The brushwork was rugged, yet every stroke brimmed with boundless faith and tender fatherly love. Foreseeing the agonizing trials the orphaned boy would endure in his absence, Aleksandar had inscribed this testament of hope in his own blood until his final breath.

Kadan touched the worn parchment edge, moisture welling in his eyes.

"Master never feared his own demise. His only thought was the brightness of the dawn awaiting the children who walked behind him."

Cilia drew near, clasping his weathered hand, and decoded the four cardinal runes inscribed along the margin.

"The northern snow, the oceanic gale, the imperial sacred flame, and the guardian shield of the earth... The intersection where these four primordial forces converge is the Throne of Ruin where Lucian awaits. Master left us the ultimate key to victory."

Kadan retrieved Ignis's White Glass Ember from his tunic and nestled it upon the sacred flame node of the parchment. In an instant, pure white sanctifying flames surged from the glass vessel, racing along the scarred contours of the map to envelop the obsidian dais in ripples of incandescent gold and radiant jade. The flame Ignis had bequeathed at the cost of his mortal life fused seamlessly with Master Aleksandar's tactical diagram, manifesting a luminous miracle that banished the darkness.

Clenching his fist, Kadan looked upon the light.

"Ignis breathes alongside us even now. The three flames and the sacred shield are finally united."

Cilia nodded, aligning her jade staff with the wind node.

"All the solemn oaths of the ancient heroes have gathered at our fingertips."

Kadan unsheathed the Silver Dagger, resting its tip at the map's nexus.

"Master Aleksandar, Uncle Balian, and Ignis stand with us. We have no time to linger in grief."

Suddenly, thunderous hoofbeats and the resonant roars of great wolves pierced the nocturnal air from the abyss beneath the terrace. King Fenrir's Silver Wolf Vanguard had enveloped the lower bastion of the Black Citadel, launching a fierce assault against the demonic legions.

The battle cries echoing from the lower terraces reignited the spirits of the allied hosts. King Fenrir and his northern warriors methodically dismantled Lucian's reserve beast legions, severing every outer line of communication and reinforcing the perimeter. Because the northern beasts held the bloodstained sulfur swamps, Kadan and Cilia were freed from guarding their vanguard, able to focus their entire will upon the tyrant on the throne.

Kadan raised his Dragon Breaker shield toward the warriors battling below.

"King Fenrir's loyalty has lifted the burden from our shoulders. Now it is our turn to cleave the tyrant on the throne."

Securing the parchment and the glowing glass ember, the two companions advanced toward the colossal obsidian portal sealing the inner sanctum. From beyond the threshold drifted the choking stench of brimstone and the violent ripples of corrupted mana.

Standing before the stone gate, Kadan hoisted his shield to his chest, its cross-shaped insignia humming in resonance with the parchment's scar.

Cilia gripped her jade staff with both hands, standing shoulder-to-shoulder with him.

"Lucian waits beyond this threshold. Whatever darkness lurks within, I shall not yield half a pace from your side."

Kadan offered a warm, unwavering smile.

"The warmth of the lives we must protect rests at our backs. Come, Cilia. Let us open the final door to wipe away every tear from this land."

Kadan drove his shield into the portal's center, shattering the massive stone gates in a roar of splintering granite. Beyond lay the blood-drenched Throne of Ruin, and the monstrous silhouette of High Chancellor Lucian waiting in the dark.

CHAPTER 37

Episode 37 · War of the Conqueror King

Part 1 · Episode 37 of 40

Across the lower bastions and jagged ravines of the Black Citadel, a savage contest raged between King Fenrir's Silver Wolf cavalry and Chancellor Lucian's final elite guard, the Spectral Knights. Massive silver wolves forged in the permafrost of the northern wastes lunged across the sulfur bogs, tearing into the throats of undead riders, while King Fenrir's greatsword cleaved through black-iron plate with incandescent sparks.

King Fenrir rested his bloodstained broadsword upon his broad shoulder, his thunderous voice reverberating across the battlefield.

> "Do the sons of the north fear the spilling of blood? Brother Aleksandar, watch from the heavens! The wolves of the tundra never forsake their oaths! Do not allow a single fiend to ascend toward Kadan until the throne is shattered!"

Northern Vanguard Captain Torvald gripped the coarse mane of his mount, raising his lance in answer.

> "Brothers, show them the fangs of the wolf pack! Grant no quarter until the young paladin brings down the tyrant!"

Thousands of northern warriors banged their axes against their shields, their battle cries shaking the citadel walls and sealing the upper galleries against enemy reinforcements.

Hearing the distant roar of battle at their backs, Kadan and Princess Cilia pushed forward through the upper arched colonnade. As they neared the inner threshold, Lucian's dread champion, Blood Knight Karnak, stepped into the corridor at the head of a hundred crimson-armored shock troopers. Karnak's flesh had been warped by injections of Medusa Gorgo's necrotic blood, transforming him into a hulking brute whose hands swung a colossal broadsword carved from dragon bone.

Karnak bared his fangs, his bloodshot eyes burning with unholy madness.

> "This corridor is the beating heart of the citadel! Traitors, you shall not advance a single pace! Your flesh shall feed the sacrificial altar!"

The hundred blood-armored soldiers lowered their spears, filling the narrow corridor like an iron tide. Cilia swept her jade staff, launching a crescent of compressed wind, but the strike shattered against the noxious crimson barrier conjured by Karnak's bone blade.

"Ordinary wind cannot pierce their lines! Their blood is bound by Gorgo's vile sorcery!"

Kadan stepped forward, lowering the Dragon Breaker shield into a resolute defensive wedge.

"Bonds forged in bloodshed crumble before the conviction to preserve life."

Kadan regulated his core through star-breathing, anchoring his stance to the bedrock. When Karnak's massive bone sword slammed down upon the adamantite face of the shield, Kadan did not merely absorb the blow; he twisted his guard, unleashing the full kinetic recoil of the earth.

A blinding golden dragon materialized from the shield's starlight core, sending a devastating shockwave tearing through the corridor. The impact shattered Karnak's bone broadsword into splinters, hurling his massive frame through the air, while the concussive burst swept the hundred shock troopers across the flagstones, disarming them in a single stroke.

Cilia unleashed a swirling gale that swept the discarded weapons over the parapet into the chasm below, neutralizing the elite vanguard without shedding innocent blood.

Kadan drew a calm breath, adjusting his shield.

"Our crusade seeks not slaughter, but the salvation of mortal lives."

Kneeling in the rubble, Karnak coughed black bile, staring at Kadan's clear, unblemished gaze with tears of bitter repentance. Seeing the serene purity of the paladin's shield, he recognized how wretched his lust for brute power had been.

"Your shield is truly... an unyielding mountain to sustain this world... Behind Lucian's throne... lie the Three Silk Seals of the Nine Shadows... I beg of you, destroy that darkness..."

Kadan placed a firm hand upon the fallen warrior's shoulder.

"I have heard your repentance. Lay down your arms and await the breaking of the dawn."

Karnak bowed his head in reverent humility. At that moment, a northern messenger falcon descended from a fissure in the vaulted ceiling. Tied to its talon was a brief missive in Fenrir's bold hand: 'The beast host below is annihilated. Lucian's retreat is severed. Strike down the throne without hesitation!'

Releasing the falcon, Kadan turned to Cilia. Both wore expressions of unyielding resolve. Kadan clasped the warm glass vessel holding Ignis's ember within his coat, drawing strength from its steady pulse.

Cilia leveled her staff toward the inner hall.

"King Fenrir and our northern kin hold the path. Let us face Lucian's throne."

Kadan took the lead, stepping into the crimson glow of the throne room.

"Come, Cilia. Let us end this eighteen-year night and greet the morning sun."

CHAPTER 38

Episode 38 · Three Silk Seals

Part 1 · Episode 38 of 40

The grand throne room atop the Citadel of Ruin was engulfed in a maelstrom of corrupted crimson mana. Upon the obsidian dais sat High Chancellor Lucian, who had cast aside every vestige of humanity. From his arched spine sprouted the venomous serpentine wings of Medusa Gorgo and the curled black horns of Belphegor, while hovering before his gauntlets were the Three Silk Seals of the Nine Shadows Codex, burning with oily black smoke.

Lucian rose from his seat, his forked tongue tasting the brimstone air.

"Hahaha! You have crawled like vermin before my throne at last! Yet you are too late! When these three seals dissolve, the entire realm shall sink into the bottomless abyss!"

With a savage hiss, Lucian tore the first silk seal. From the obsidian floor erupted dozens of barbed crimson tentacles, weeping corrosive bile that hissed upon the flagstones.

Kadan braced his footing, bringing the Dragon Breaker shield forward.

"Your monstrous ambition ends here! So long as this shield stands, the light of this continent shall never flicker out!"

Cilia pointed her staff toward the ceiling vaults.

"With every seal that unbinds, an abyssal monarch descends! We cannot afford a heartbeat of hesitation!"

The barbed tentacles descended in a vicious volley, striking like steel ballista bolts. Yet Kadan channeled star-breathing through his vanguard, the adamantite plate of his shield scattering the acid in blinding golden sparks.

"The illusions of your darkness are broken! Behold the light of truth!"

Leaping into the air, Cilia swung her jade staff in a wide arc.

"Blades of the southern gale, sever the first chain of curse!"

A crescent of concentrated wind cleaved through the gloom, striking the first silk seal dead center. With a shriek like tearing iron, the seal burst into fragments, and the flailing tentacles turned to

grey ash.

Lucian snarled, tearing the second silk seal in a frenzy. From the ceiling plunged the phantom manifestation of Medusa Gorgo—a monstrous serpent with dozens of glowing crimson eyes, spewing beams of petrifying light. Marble pillars struck by the rays turned to chalky limestone, crumbling into dust.

Kadan threw himself in front of Cilia, planting his shield into the stone.

"Not a hair upon her head shall be touched while I draw breath!"

The petrifying beam struck the Dragon Breaker shield dead center. As the adamantite plate began to turn grey under the ancient curse, Kadan unsheathed the Silver Dagger and drove its tip into the shield's core. Master Aleksandar's paladin runes roared to life, reversing the petrification in a blast of sacred white flame that shattered the serpent's skull and obliterated the second seal.

Cilia called out in triumph.

"The second seal has fallen! Only the dark core within Lucian's heart remains!"

Black blood erupted from Lucian's chest as the backdraft of corrupted mana tore his flesh. Driven to utter madness, the tyrant plunged the third silk seal directly into his own heart.

"If I must perish, you shall be dragged into the underworld with me! Lord Belphegor, accept my mortal soul and pull this world into eternal damnation!"

A dimensional singularity tore open within Lucian's chest, threatening to swallow the citadel and the capital into the void.

Cilia gripped her staff, her voice urgent.

"The third seal is fused to his life force! Unless we pierce that core, the entire mountain will collapse into the void! Kadan, I trust your shield and blade!"

Kadan set his jaw, pressing Ignis's White Glass Ember against the crest of his shield.

"I shall open the vanguard. Support my back with your wind, Cilia!"

Pure white sanctifying flame, golden starlight mana, and Cilia's jade wind converged into a towering spear of incandescent brilliance that enveloped Kadan's silhouette.

"In the name of every life we have defended, pierce the heart of darkness!"

Kadan charged directly into the vortex. The Dragon Breaker shield smashed through the dark barrier, and the Silver Dagger drove through the glowing core of the third silk seal.

A blinding explosion of immaculate light filled the hall. The third seal shattered, Lucian's dark mana dissolved into nothingness, and the cursed wards of the Nine Shadows Codex dispersed forever on the morning gale.

CHAPTER 39

Episode 39 · The World Worth Protecting

Part 1 · Episode 39 of 40

As the Three Silk Seals shattered and the shroud of the Nine Shadows Codex dissipated, a crisp morning breeze swept through the ruined colonnade. Yet from the shadows behind the splintered dais, a battered figure in dented black armor dragged himself forward—Sir Artus, the final Death Knight.

Artus's crimson eyes were dim, and his fractured obsidian broadsword dripped necrotic black blood. Only the residual tendrils of Lucian's puppetry compelled his withered frame to advance.

Through parched lips, the fallen knight rasped:

"A paladin's vow... is never sullied... even in the dark..."

Kadan lowered his Dragon Breaker shield and pointed the Silver Dagger toward the floor.

"Sir Artus. You were once a peerless champion of the holy knights and the dearest friend of Uncle Balian. The time has come to cast off these cursed chains and enter eternal rest."

Cilia raised her jade staff, letting a gentle melody of wind drift across the shattered stones.

"His soul weeps in agony. Though his body was made a monster, the heart of a paladin beats within, yearning for release."

Artus brought down his broken broadsword with a desperate cry—not an attack of malice, but a plea for deliverance. Kadan did not draw his steel; instead, he stepped forward, meeting the blow with the gentle embrace of his shield.

A soothing aura of golden starlight radiated from the shield face—Master Aleksandar's ultimate art, 'Star Deliverance.' The necrotic tendrils wrapping Artus's plate disintegrated into luminous white butterflies that drifted upward into the sky. His battered helm slipped away, revealing the serene countenance of a white-haired elder.

Kneeling before Kadan, Artus took the youth's hand with trembling fingers.

"Thank you... child of Aleksandar... Your shield has redeemed me... Now I may face Sir Balian and Sir Aleksandar with head held high... This world... was truly worth defending..."

With a peaceful smile, the old knight's spirit dissolved into silver dust, carried away on the morning breeze.

Only Lucian remained, weeping black bile upon the marble floor. Stripped of his codex, the once-mighty tyrant had withered into a frail, trembling old wretch. He clawed at Kadan's boots, begging for mercy.

"Spare me, Kadan! I shall grant you every treasure and province in the empire! Only spare my life!"

Kadan looked down with eyes as cool as northern mountain streams.

"The villages you burned, the captives who perished in the mines, and the lives of my masters and Ignis cannot be bought with gold. You shall answer for your deeds before the judgment of law and history."

Allied soldiers bound Lucian in heavy chains and hauled him down to the dungeons. The eighteen-year tyranny that had choked the realm had come to an end.

Kadan and Cilia stood side-by-side upon the terrace. Below, the dark storm clouds parted as the morning sun rose over the eastern sea, bathing the scarred land in gold. The sulfur fog was swept away, revealing green forests and sparkling rivers.

Cilia leaned against Kadan's shoulder, tears shimmering in her eyes.

"We have done it, Kadan. True dawn has arrived."

Kadan retrieved Ignis's White Glass Ember, holding it toward the sun. The vessel emanated a steady, warm white light, as though their fallen brother were smiling beside them.

"Are you watching, Ignis? Master, uncle... We have kept our vow."

Far below, tens of thousands of allied soldiers and liberated citizens raised their weapons, sending a thunderous cheer across the mountains. Cilia swept her staff, releasing a blessing of gentle wind across the valleys.

"This world bears countless scars, but the warmth of hands held makes it beautiful and worth defending."

Kadan lowered his shield, clasping her hand tightly.

"To protect that warmth, we raised our shield. Now let the laughter of the people fill this earth."

CHAPTER 40

Episode 40 · One Who Is Not Called a Hero

Part 1 · Episode 40 of 40

A month following the final battle, the imperial capital of Lighthaven thrummed with peaceful vitality. The charred wharves of Sevenbridge Port had been rebuilt through the labor of dwarf artisans and fishermen, while flower ships laden with grain and medicinal herbs lined the docks. In the cathedral square, the aged Emperor and the restored Senate convened a grand festival to honor the savior of the realm.

The Emperor stood from his gilded throne, unrolling an imperial decree. His voice boomed across the assembled thousands.

"People of the continent! To Kadan, disciple of Aleksandar who vanquished the Nine Shadows, I bestow the title of Grand Marshal and the rank of Duke! And to Princess Cilia of Whispering Wind Island, I offer the crown of Empress and Regent of the Eastern League!"

Cheers erupted across the plaza, the crowd shouting their names into the sky. Supreme power and boundless wealth lay before their feet.

Yet Kadan and Cilia stood before the dais clad not in velvet robes, but in simple traveler's furs and rough linen.

Stepping forward, Kadan bowed with deep courtesy, declining the golden coronet.

"I thank Your Majesty for this generous grace. Yet I can accept neither title nor dukedom. I am no hero; I am merely a wanderer who raised a shield to carry the warmth of my fallen master and Ignis to those who shiver in the cold. My place is not in marble halls, but upon the fertile earth of my homeland."

Cilia placed her jade staff upon the stone steps, offering a serene smile.

"Nor can I accept an imperial crown. The wind wears no coronet, nor can it be confined within palace corridors. My home is upon the plains where the people dwell."

Kadan touched the worn rim of his shield, his voice steady and calm.

"A shield is forged not to defend a throne, but to clasp the hands of shivering children. My place remains beside the hearth of my northern home."

Moved to tears by their humility, the citizens fell silent, bowing their heads in reverence as the two youths departed the dais.

That evening, away from the grand banquet, Kadan and Cilia shared ale beside the hearth of a humble tavern with King Fenrir, Rondol, and their comrades.

Fenrir clinked his timber tankard against Kadan's, laughing heartily.

"Hahaha! Men wage war their entire lives for crowns and provinces, yet you two cast them aside without a backward glance! You possess a stouter heart than Aleksandar ever did, Kadan."

Rondol stroked his wooden leg, emotion softening his rugged face.

"The flower ships of Whispering Wind Island are trade vessels now. Whenever you miss the ocean breezes, return to our shores. We remain brothers and allies for all time."

Kadan touched the Silver Dagger and the carved wooden horse toy of Ignis resting in his pocket.

"I shall never forget your kindness. A warm fire shall always await you in our northern cabin."

At dawn, Kadan and Cilia quietly departed Lighthaven's northern gate. There were no trumpet fanfares or armored escorts. On Kadan's back rested his scarred iron shield, while Cilia held a simple reed flute.

They walked along the winding dirt road toward the northern Elwin fief. Green shoots of winter barley poked through the thawed earth, and a warm spring breeze ruffled their hair. Cilia plucked a blue violet from the roadside, tucking it into the strap of Kadan's shield.

"We kept our promise, Kadan. Spring has truly arrived."

Kadan took her hand, his smile gentle and untroubled.

"Yes, Cilia. The winter was long, but spring never lost its way."

Upon the quiet hill of the Elwin fief, warm sunshine bathed the side-by-side graves of Master Aleksandar and Uncle Balian. Wildflowers bloomed in abundance across the grassy mound. Kneeling together, Kadan and Cilia poured fresh spring water upon the stone markers. Between the two graves, they gently buried Ignis's small wooden horse toy beneath the rich soil.

Kadan closed his eyes, whispering softly to the wind.

"Master, father... and Ignis. We brought spring to this land as promised. Here we shall till the soil and wash the feet of weary travelers."

The spring breeze rustled the grass, as if ancient heroes were resting gentle hands upon their shoulders.

From the chimney of a small log cabin at the foot of the hill, white woodsmoke drifted into the azure sky. The cabin door stood wide open, and beside the hearth rested an empty chair for any traveler seeking shelter from the cold.

The age of heroes had ended, but the quiet, beautiful story of living mortals was only just beginning. The legend of the Snow Hero would live on, not in frozen histories, but in the enduring warmth shared beside the hearths of the people.

SNSHero: Kadan & Arcane Echoes (Part 1)

Official Complete e-Book Edition

Title	SNSHero: Kadan & Arcane Echoes (Part 1)
Copyright	ModooSoft / SNSHero Revolution
Publication Date	October 2026 (Official Revised Edition)
Genre	Epic Dark Fantasy Web Novel
Contents	Episode 1 – Episode 40 (Complete)
Publisher	SNSHero Revolution Media Lounge (https://snshero.com)

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